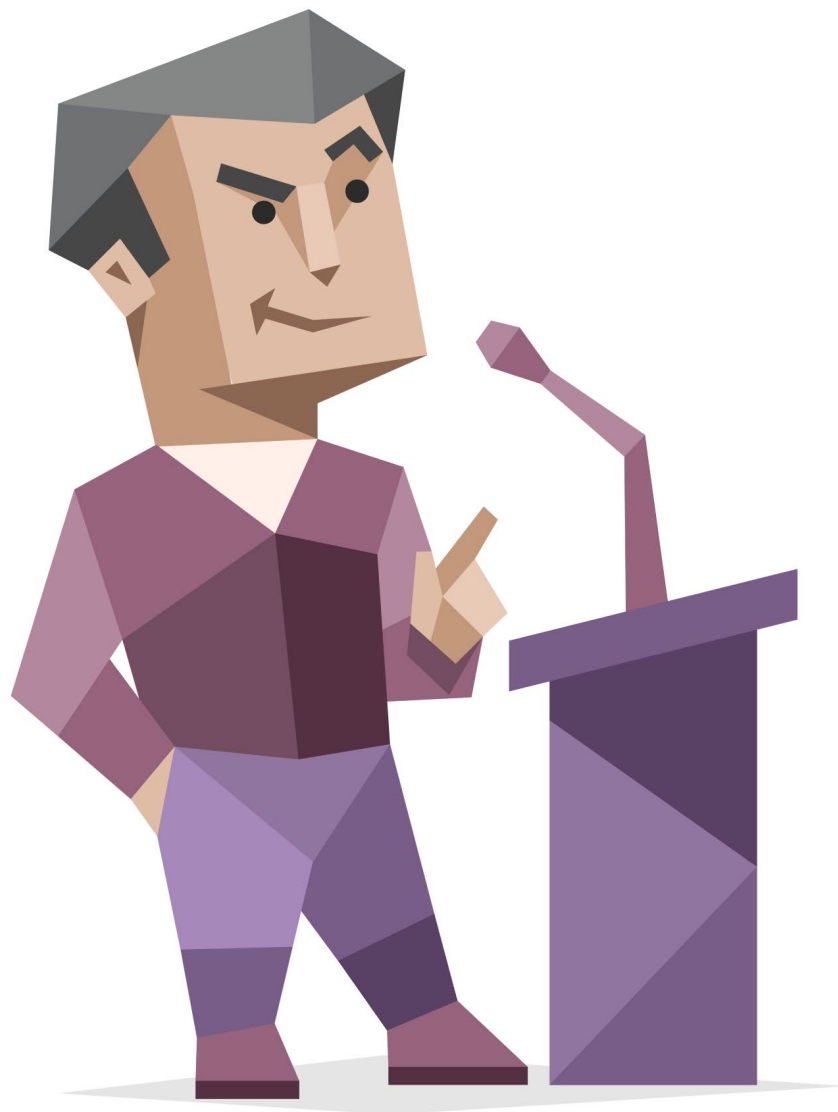


DEBATER

PREMIUM PROFILE



What's in This Profile?

This profile is designed to cover all the main aspects of the Debater personality as it affects different areas of their lives, including Debaters' key strengths and weaknesses, relationships, academic path, career and professional development, as well as their communication and social skills, parenting tips and advice, and much, much more. It combines personality type theory with practical, real-world advice from others who share the Debater personality type.

As Aristotle said millennia ago, "The hardest victory is the victory over self" – and, to this end, personality types have been considered and studied throughout human history, from the four humors of ancient Greece to the work of Carl Jung. The information in these pages provides profound personal insight that can help Debaters handle day-to-day situations in more healthy, balanced ways. Consider this profile a plan for success.

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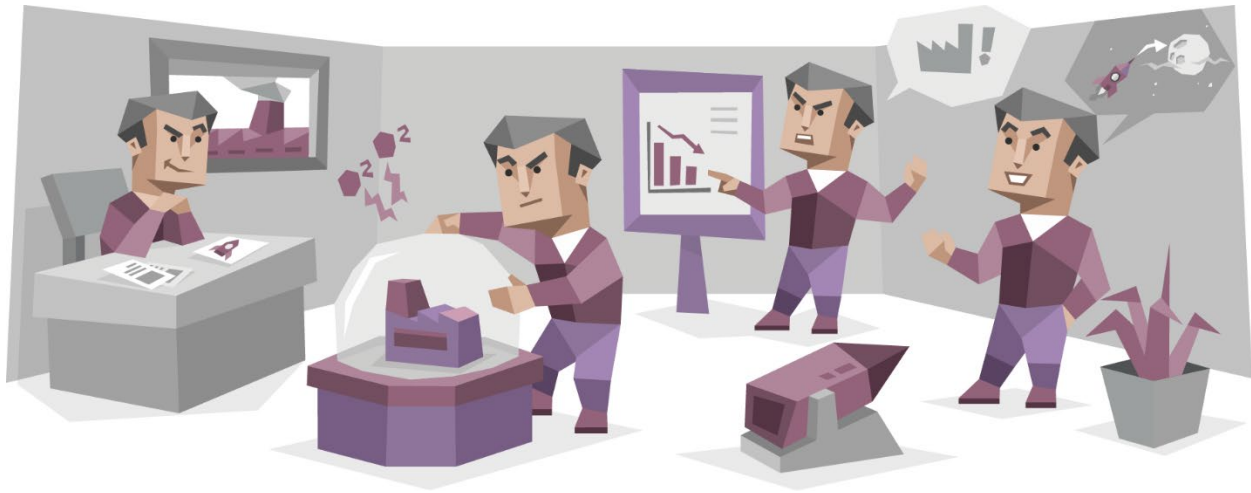
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Who Is “The Debater?”



Throughout this book, we will discuss how Debaters' traits combine to form a complete personality type. The next few paragraphs will summarize the Debater personality type, and the following chapters will explore various parts of their lives in greater detail. The information is not intended to box Debaters into a single, rigid identity – they are likely to challenge any rigid description of who they are, anyway.

To get the most out of this premium profile, remember two things: First, personality types are determined by information provided by people seeking to discover their type. Instead of being told who they are, people exploring personality types are doing the telling. Once they reveal their preferences in life, a well-researched model translates the information into a personality type. The model is descriptive, as opposed to prescriptive, and it is based on the information users provide.

Second, exploring personality types involves the study of tendencies. Rarely are absolutes discussed or offered. Personal histories and life adaptations have significant influences on the way people live, sometimes defying their basic temperaments. No two Debaters are identical. However, they are enough alike to

enable statements about common preferences and styles that are distinct from other types. Such descriptions commonly prove helpful for self-understanding and, from there, decision-making and personal growth. All topics in this book come back to one idea: personal choices based on a more profound understanding that people come to have of themselves.

Personal Growth

The active minds and passion of Debaters can be tremendous assets in all of life's circumstances – and yet that same energy can get in their way. Personal growth involves using what works, and either discarding what doesn't work or turning it into something useful. For Debaters, growth is often the interplay between pursuing their preferred spontaneous intellectual pursuits and succeeding in a world that doesn't always appreciate their style. Remaining true to themselves and developing their sense of self-worth while having the confidence to reach for a better self are the goals for all who wish to grow.

Nurturing and cherishing their passion for intellectual gymnastics are essential for people with this personality type. The full exercise of that passion often requires minding their own limits, as well as those of other people. Debaters sometimes allow their original thinking to place them in unconventional territory. If their novel ideas lead them too far away from what is conventionally useful or meaningful, they risk sabotaging their own success – especially if they push under-considered notions, as they sometimes do. More practical people are often willing to dismiss Debaters' good ideas when they don't fit the time, place, and situation.

Although liking oneself and finding oneself worthy are important, those aspects cannot work alone; they are part of a feedback loop that includes action. Debaters

need a plan, or at least a strong direction, to carry out their hopes for a satisfying life. Because they are idea people, planning and developing theoretical constructs come naturally to them, but the help of other people is often a crucial element to executing their plans. Learning how that works in their lives while exploiting the value of their independent style is one of their challenges to creating an effective strategy for self-development. Fortunately, as Extraverts, Debaters have an impulse to interact with others – clearly an asset when one needs others for success.

Relationships

Debaters don’t always have an accurate sense of their audience or what their audience wants, and they sometimes fall short with their sympathy and empathy. But it would be an incomplete picture to define their relationships by those challenges. Debaters can be stimulating companions and usually have a fresh spin on any topic of conversation. Despite occasionally reacting inappropriately toward other people, they often generously aid those in need and offer practical support to others. As Extraverts, they interact with the world energetically, and their impact reverberates through their social and personal lives.

Their sometimes-blunt way of expressing themselves can give Debaters a hard, insensitive appearance. Other types either find them quirky, exciting, and attractive or feel uncomfortable and become offended. And although Debaters, as a type, may not necessarily want to alienate others, they aren’t always aware of their tendency to do so. The people who overcome initial roughness in Debaters find a steadfast spirit underneath.

Debaters’ style may not be for those who prefer the conventional, particularly those who stay faithful to their fixed ideas. Although Debaters need to be a part of society,

conforming to please others is not high on their list of priorities. This may lead them to passionately argue their unique positions to people who don't want to discuss conflicting and maybe even threatening arguments against their own beliefs. It can become a game for Debaters, who might convince themselves that everybody wants to hash out difficult and complex ideas. For most people who aren't Debaters, though, argument as recreation quickly wears thin.

Academic and Professional Development

Debaters have a nearly unlimited appreciation for theoretical riddles. If there's no easy answer and the topic grabs them, Debaters can spend ages trying to find a solution. People with this personality type can sometimes struggle to explain their thoughts to others. Their theories are sometimes so complex that they aren't easily accessible to the average thinker, no matter how clear the explanation. Debaters may move on to another topic before their coworkers, partners, professors, or fellow students have sorted out the exact meaning of their words.

People with this personality type use their minds in a deliberate way, especially noticeable in their professional environment. They enjoy brainstorming and outlining all the choices. Nonconformists, they love challenging existing rules and routines, which makes them irreplaceable when it comes to improving existing systems and coming up with new, original plans. This tendency is invaluable for creating notable improvement under the right conditions – but it also may cause tension in the workplace. Not everybody is comfortable with shaking up an established system.

Similarly, Debaters are easily bored with routine work or rote studies full of memorization. Their minds are more like playgrounds than factories. They would

much rather tackle difficult theoretical problems than trudge through well-established material, even if following the routine might be more productive.

On That Note...

This introduction provides only an outline of Debaters’ potential strengths and weaknesses. As with any personality type, an outline alone cannot provide enough information to fully describe or classify Debaters. In the following chapters, we will discuss the above topics and more in detail. Each chapter will provide more comprehensive information, suggestions, and resources for improvement. Understanding one’s personality type can be a powerful tool for growth, and we hope this information proves useful as you continue onward. But before we dig in too much there, we’ll do a brief overview of our theory. For a full explanation of the theory and its history, skip to the end – [The Puzzle of Personality](#).

Theory Overview

Five Personality Aspects

Introverted (I) vs. Extraverted (E)

People have long noted that some among them are more outgoing and comfortable interacting with their surroundings, and others are more at ease remaining in quiet solitude with their thoughts. You can see the two types in almost any home, office, or classroom. In our first scale, we focus on the difference between Introversion and Extraversion, which we call the Energy scale.

The Energy scale describes how we see and approach the outside world, including people, objects, and activities within it. There are significant links between this scale and things like willingness to volunteer, boredom, thrill seeking, motivation, and romantic assertiveness, to name just a few. The links may not prove one causes the other. However, it does hint at a relationship.

Introverted People: Attuned Inwards

More Internal: Introverts ground themselves more easily in solitude and derive energy from their own thoughts.

More Selective: Introverts are careful when choosing the people with whom they spend time and prefer a quieter environment when they have a choice.

Slow to Offer Opinions: Within reason, Introverts like a little time to process their thoughts and ideas and are slow to offer opinions, fearing they may be too rash.

Extraverted People: Outwardly Engaged

More Outgoing: Extraverts tend to be outgoing both socially and in their willingness to interact with new and interesting environments.

Energetic: Extraverts have an energy that is almost replenished by its expression. They are energized by being energetic and putting themselves in stimulating situations.

Quick with Opinions: Extraverts are generally more comfortable with a flurry of opinions that typically are a part of casual conversations. It's almost like brainstorming ideas on the spot while saving the editing for later.

Debaters: Extraverted (E) Trait

Extraverts are often energetic and willing to take the lead, especially in social situations. They enjoy pushing themselves to the limit and challenging themselves and those around them. Unlike Introverts, who are more cautious in their approach, Extraverts are likely to feel that they can handle life's challenges without much forethought. Whether that turns out to be true depends on many other circumstances, but overall, Extraverts tend to be more proactive in experiencing – and embracing – the world around them.

Debaters are Extraverted – they tend to feel recharged after spending time in the company of other people, and consequently often have excellent social skills. As Extraverts, Debaters enjoy taking the lead and speaking their mind, often going ahead and voicing their opinion as they develop it. People with this personality trait tend to instinctively connect with others, regardless of their background or personality, making them popular and well-liked in many circles.

Intuitive (N) vs. Observant (S)

The second scale in our model is called Mind and addresses Intuitive and Observant styles. Each trait determines what kind of information we focus on and how it is used. It's the foundation on which all the other approaches are built.

All personality types include either those who favor the Intuitive style or those who prefer the Observant style. But before we start, it's important to say that this has nothing to do with how they take in information. The word "Observant" might suggest it does. But Intuitive and Observant types use their five senses in the same way. Rather than how they absorb information, these qualities show how each of these traits manages it once it's received.

Intuitive People: Living in the World of Ideas

Focus on Ideas: Intuitive people are fascinated by the world of ideas and love to discover the connections between various concepts and realities.

Deeply Curious: Within the realm of ideas, Intuitive individuals have a strong curiosity that leads them to somewhat adventurous discoveries.

Highly Imaginative: Those who prefer this trait typically stretch concepts to include possibilities beyond the obvious. "What if this not only means... but what if it could also mean..."

Observant People: Feet On the Ground

A Practical Focus: Observant people are more in touch with the concrete world and work within it. They favor consistent actions and measurable results.

Facts Over Theory: These individuals leave theorizing and brainstorming to others, preferring to effectively apply established facts.

More in the Moment: While Observant individuals have a respect for the past and the future, they see them through the lens of what they can do now. The task at hand is always the most important.

Debaters: Intuitive (N) Trait

Debaters are Intuitive individuals. This is why they are so good at seeing possibilities and honoring different points of view. People with this personality type spend more time engaging in various internal discussions than observing things around them. Debaters are not that concerned about what is happening; instead, they focus on what might happen or why something has happened. Debaters hone this focus throughout their lives, which makes them passionate and insightful thinkers.

Of course, every stick has two ends, and focus on novelty and change comes at a cost. By directing their mental resources toward possibilities and the future, Debaters inevitably lose sight of what is happening around them. They may have difficulties dealing with practical matters or data. If they aren't paying attention, they may even miss something right under their nose. Because the majority of the population has the Observant trait, Debaters may feel like their connecting things at a different level than most.

Thinking (T) vs. Feeling (F)

The Thinking and Feeling traits determine how we decide matters and cope with emotions. While we all have feelings, there are significant differences in how we react to them and what role those feelings play in our lives. This then influences several

other areas, mostly related to our interactions with other people. This is what our third trait, Nature, focuses on.

Thinking People: Where Reason Rules

Rational and Objective: Thinking individuals are most comfortable dealing with things that come from rational thought and involve proven principles.

Logic Over Feelings: While these types often feel quite deeply, they typically place their rationality and logic above any emotional responses.

Constantly Assessing: Thinking people constantly scan ideas and actions to decide whether they make sense or not. They can be valuable in any process that requires any level of critical thinking.

Feeling People: Those Who Follow Their Feelings

Lead from the Heart: Feeling types listen to their feelings, care about how others feel, and are unafraid of sharing this perspective.

Focus on Morals and Ethics: People and their welfare are usually prioritized above any other consideration with the individuals who exhibit the Feeling trait.

A Different Kind of Rationality: While the Feeling type's way of choosing a direction may not always be totally objective, that doesn't mean that they lack rationality. There is practical wisdom in including feelings and consideration for the well-being of oneself and others in the decisions one makes.

Debaters: Thinking (T) Trait

Debaters have the Thinking trait. These types trust and prioritize logic, and they rely on rational arguments over emotional appeals. They try to keep their true feelings and emotions deep below the surface, and focus instead on what can be assessed, compared, and verified.

Individuals with the Thinking trait, like Debaters, bring tremendous value to enterprises that need careful assessment and calculation to succeed. Unfortunately, for all the good it represents, the Thinking trait may distance Debaters from much of the population, as connecting at an emotional level takes more effort for these intellectual types.

Judging (J) vs. Prospecting (P)

The Tactics scale – Judging and Prospecting – is about how people plan and deal with the options they have. But this definition doesn't just concern what individuals write in their day planners. It's much broader. These traits answer questions like, "Do you prefer spontaneity or certainty?" "Do you feel more comfortable acting only with all your ducks lined neatly in a row? Or does a certain amount of flexibility or chaos excite you and prove motivating?" "Do you need more choices or fewer?"

At its core, this scale determines our attitude toward certainty and structure in our lives, both at mental and physical levels.

Judging People: A Steady Hand

Predictability Rules: Judging types are most at home when there is a clear-cut, well-considered plan that provides sure steps and promotes certain outcomes.

Work Hard: Judging individuals tend to work hard, perhaps seeing strong effort as a way of ensuring predictability.

By the Book: Individuals with this trait usually like to do things by the book and respect reasonable protocols, established techniques, and duties. They sometimes see doing things any other way as “reinventing the wheel.”

Prospecting People: Possibilities in the Moment

Relaxed Spontaneity: Prospecting types tend to deal with life and all its opportunities as it comes at them.

Creative: This trait can promote “coloring outside the lines.” This can lead to discovering new creative solutions.

Serial Passions: Prospecting individuals may find themselves passing quickly through many interests in their lives. Because of these experiences, they can possess a broad array of knowledge and ideas.

Debaters: Prospecting (P) Trait

Debaters are Prospecting individuals, and look for different ways to complete tasks or accomplish goals. Debaters’ vast range of interests may lead to unfinished projects or missed deadlines, but these types would rather risk disappointing others than lock themselves into a position where existing commitments would limit their freedom.

Tending to be removed from the real world, Debaters often pay far more attention to their latest mental exercise than to clutter around the house or dishes piled in the sink. Prospecting types are relaxed about their work or studies, refusing to get stressed about deadlines, templates, or rules when they still have free time.

Assertive (-A) vs. Turbulent (-T)

Assertive and Turbulent – the Identity scale – measures how confident one is and how that confidence influences all other traits. The degree that people move more boldly or more timidly affects the way they make choices. It determines how they express their skills. Whether one is too confident to accept criticism or puts too much weight on the criticism of others because they lack self-confidence can make a major difference. The caution or lack of caution people apply to the things they do can color everything.

Assertive People: A Confident Approach

Confident Style: People with the Assertive identity are self-confident and resist stress.

Often Success-Oriented: Because these individuals don't spend hours fretting, it might be assumed they aren't interested in results. For many of them, nothing could be further from the truth.

Responsive and Proactive: Assertive people may jump into a task quickly, not being as burdened with the need to think endlessly about what may go wrong.

Turbulent People: Always Improving

Useful Worry: Turbulent people often worry and engage in self-doubt. While that might sound negative, the flipside of the coin is that it fuels much of their drive and productivity.

Driven to Succeed and Improve: Turbulent individuals are constantly seeking to do better and be better. This pushes them to put great effort into life.

Problem Spotters: Because of their cautious nature and tendency to worry, those with the Turbulent trait often spot problems early and are able to contain them quickly.

Type Groups

Now you know what each type consists of. But how do they fit together?

In our system, we group personality types in two different ways:

- **Roles** determine our goals, interests, and preferred activities.
- **Strategies** reflect our preferred ways of doing things and achieving our goals.

You can think of Roles and Strategies as two ways of organizing personality types into categories. These two categorization methods each highlight different facets of the types. For examples, Roles can show us why certain types share similar interests, and Strategies can explain why certain types approach socializing the way they do.

We discuss Strategies in depth at the end of this e-book, in *The Puzzle of Personality*. With that in mind, let's explore the importance of Roles.

Roles

There are four Roles, each of which groups together four personality types.

- The **Analyst Role** includes Architects (INTJ), Logicians (INTP), Commanders (ENTJ), and Debaters (ENTP).
- The **Diplomat Role** includes Advocates (INFJ), Mediators (INFP), Protagonists (ENFJ), and Campaigners (ENFP).

- The **Sentinel Role** includes Logisticians (ISTJ), Defenders (ISFJ), Executives (ESTJ), and Consuls (ESFJ).
- The **Explorer Role** includes Virtuosos (ISTP), Adventurers (ISFP), Entrepreneurs (ESTP), and Entertainers (ESFP).

So, why do we organize the types in this way? To put it simply, Roles help us to recognize important common ground between personality types.

The types within each Role all share the same Mind trait – either Intuitive or Observant. As you might remember, this trait is incredibly important because it determines how we view the world. As a result, the types within a given Role are alike in a very important respect: they share similar ways of understanding the world and their place within it.

In addition to the Mind trait, the types within a given Role also share the same Nature trait (Thinking or Feeling) or the same Tactics trait (Judging or Prospecting).

Does this seem like information overload? If so, don't worry. To help you get a better grasp of the Roles, let's go through them one by one and find out what makes them tick.

Analysts: Intuitive (N) and Thinking (T)

The personality types in the Analyst Role – Architects, Logicians, Commanders, and Debaters – are known for their irreverent curiosity. Thanks to the Intuitive trait, these types are rarely satisfied with the status quo. Instead, they'll go deep in their search for ways to make things better, more efficient, and more effective. Meanwhile, the Thinking trait means that they value rationality over emotionality.

Analysts' greatest strengths include:

Driven to learn. Analysts want to know how the world works. In their quest for knowledge, they push the boundaries of their understanding. The result? Their expertise in certain areas can be remarkable.

Questioning natures. Analysts rarely accept things at face value. Ever questioning, they look beyond superficial appearances. This enables them to come up with deep, unexpected insights.

Intellectual energy. Full of fresh, counterintuitive ideas, Analysts know how to spark a lively debate. Conversations with these candid, sharp-witted types can be a breath of fresh air.

Born to improve. Analysts are relentless self-improvers. Once they've recognized a flaw, they apply all their rationality, imagination, and ambition to make it right.

Analysts' forceful imaginations, when trained and focused, enable them to achieve incredible results. But, like anyone, these types can have their Achilles heels, such as:

Lost in thought. Thinking up great ideas gives Analysts a rush. As a result, they're at risk of staying in the realm of thought, never acting out their ideas.

Ever the critic. In the same vein, some Analysts are more comfortable thinking about and critiquing other people's work than jumping into the fray themselves. In time, these types may be frustrated to find themselves outpaced by people with real-world experience.

Hunting for flaws. If taken too far, Analysts desire for improvement can have them hunting down the flaws in everything. As a result, they may undervalue the people and opportunities they encounter.

Emoti-what? Analysts feel more comfortable in the realm of thought than the messy world of emotions. But like anyone, they need to develop emotional literacy in order to deepen their relationships and fully understand themselves.

Fortunately, Analysts have enough creativity and ambition to move beyond these stumbling blocks. When they take action, look for the positive, and train their curiosity on the realm of emotions, these types can grow into their full potential.

Diplomats: Intuitive (N) and Feeling (F)

Diplomats – Advocates, Mediators, Protagonists, and Campaigners – tend to be warm, caring, and generous. Bringing together the Intuitive and Feeling traits, they shine in their understanding of emotions – both their own and other people’s. This ability helps them shine when it comes to diplomacy, counseling others, and communication in general.

Diplomats’ gifts and talents include:

Emotional literacy. Even when it’s far from obvious, Diplomats can often perceive how others are feeling. From the outside, this might look like mind-reading. But in truth, it’s a combination of self-reflection and radical compassion that helps Diplomats understand others’ emotional states.

Only connect. Diplomats don’t use their people skills to manipulate others. Instead, they aim to nurture genuine connections with the people they encounter. Moreover, many Diplomats feel called to serve others however they can.

Do no harm. Deep down, Diplomats want what’s best for everyone. For them, causing someone else distress would feel like a wound to their own psyche. As a result, these types aim to promote cooperation and harmony rather than conflict.

Creators at work. Profoundly creative, Diplomats are always on the hunt for inspiration. Whether or not they take up artistic pursuits, these types tend to enjoy self-exploration and self-expression.

Diplomats have high ideals. For them, kindness and altruism burn as brightly as a fire on a chilly winter's night. But if left unchecked, this idealism can have its downsides, including:

Impractical magic. Tempering passion with cold practicality is a challenge for Diplomats. These types are often reluctant to make tough decisions – especially if those decisions require them to compromise on their ideals or hurt someone's feelings.

Beautiful ideas. Diplomats have the best of intentions, and they have countless ideas about ways to help people. They're at risk, however, of staying stuck in the realm of ideas instead of taking action and sticking to a plan.

Taking on too much. In their efforts to make a difference, Diplomats may overcommit themselves – emotionally, physically, or even financially. If they don't deliver everything they'd hoped, they may feel overwhelmed or disappointed in themselves.

Easily hurt. Sensitive to criticism and rejection, these types may react strongly if other people question the value of their ideals. Disagreement and conflict can leave Diplomats feeling discouraged and hurt.

In all their actions, Diplomats crave a sense of meaning and purpose. Specifically, they feel called to cultivate positive change and gentle beauty in the world around

them. Motivated by intangible rewards felt in the heart and soul, these types have a conviction to serve the greater good.

Sentinels: Observant (S) and Judging (J)

Sentinels – Logisticians, Defenders, Executives, and Consuls – are cooperative and practical. This grounded approach helps them feel comfortable with themselves just as they are. Steadfast and hardworking, these types pride themselves on their character and competence.

Here are some of the ways that Sentinels contribute to their homes, workplaces, social circles, and beyond:

Loving duty. These types feel a deep responsibility for those they care about. Specifically, Sentinels feel duty-bound to keep their loved ones safe and to help them lead good lives.

Always on time. Sure, Sentinels might occasionally fall behind schedule. But most of the time, they pride themselves on being unfailingly reliable. As a result, friends, loved ones, and coworkers can trust that Sentinels won't flake on their commitments.

Keepers of tradition. Sentinels work hard to maintain the ways things are done. In their home life, this means they love to continue family traditions. At the workplace, these types keep track of and defend best practices.

Unwavering diligence. Sentinels aren't afraid of hard work. On a daily basis, they practice their virtues of consistency and persistence, refusing to take shortcuts or stop before their work is done. And in situations where someone needs to step up and take responsibility, Sentinels can be counted on to come through.

Sentinels feel bolstered by having reliable people in their lives, and they make it a priority to hold up their end of the bargain. But even these dependable types can have their challenges, including:

Resistance to change. For Sentinels, trying new ways of doing things can feel wrong – almost like breaking an unwritten set of rules. These types can be skeptical of change, and they may stick with suboptimal choices on the grounds of “that’s how it’s always been done.”

Stubbornness toward others. Similarly, Sentinels may feel personally affronted when other people upset the status quo. What someone else might describe as “experimenting with new ideas” may seem reckless or disrespectful to Sentinels. As a result, these types might dig in their heels, even if that means forestalling progress.

Imposing their values. Sentinels love to give advice and shepherd people toward better lives – at least, what Sentinels consider better lives. It may be hard for these types to accept that not everyone holds stability, tradition, and respectability among their core values. And when other people don’t follow their advice, Sentinels may want to judge them harshly.

Sentinels’ loyalty and steadfastness shine in many situations. When they balance their firm convictions with curiosity and openness, these types can become nothing short of inspirations to the people in their lives.

Explorers: Observant (S) and Prospecting (P)

Explorers – Virtuosos, Adventurers, Entrepreneurs, and Entertainers – are self-reliant and quick-thinking. They’re always ready to tackle a challenge or act on the spur of

the moment. This spontaneity doesn't only help them solve problems – it also enables them to find opportunities for enjoyment in their everyday lives.

Here are a few of Explorers' notable strengths:

Surfing the waves. Many people struggle with change, but not Explorers. These types can adapt to new situations with minimal regret or second-guessing. In fact, they often enjoy change and appreciate breaks from routine.

Socially dynamic. Because of their openness, many Explorers enjoy meeting new people and trying out new social experiences. This helps them to build a network of diverse and interesting friends and acquaintances.

Getting things done. Explorers don't overthink things. Instead, they leap into action and get the job done. These types spend their energy on taking concrete steps, only pausing to consider abstract ideas or nitty-gritty details when it's absolutely necessary.

Picking up techniques. Utilitarian in their way, Explorers love to master new tools and techniques. Whatever their hobbies and passions, these types enjoy the challenge of building their skills and picking up new ways of doing things.

Explorers enjoy being free of obligations, where they can indulge themselves or their interests on their own time. Like most traits, this has its upsides and its downsides. Here are some tendencies that Explorers may need to counteract:

Losing interest. We all lose interest in our activities from time to time. But Explorers often run out of motivation as soon as a project no longer feels fun, novel, or exciting.

What planning? Explorers prefer to deal with challenges on the fly rather than plan ahead. Alas, sometimes an ounce of planning really is worth a pound of cure.

Risky business. Explorers are drawn to pleasure, risk, and – sometimes – risky pleasures. As they grow and mature, however, they often learn that some risks simply aren't worth taking.

Explorers connect with the world in a way that's almost childlike in its wonder and sheer fun. It can be a challenge for them to work for things with a distant or unexciting payoff, but when they harness their passion and administer just enough self-discipline, they can move heaven and earth.

Now, let's talk about you.

Personal Growth



Exploring Possibility

By its very nature, personal growth isn't the "one size fits all" affair that some self-help books would indicate. Personal growth is about expanding beyond what's comfortable or reflexive to explore larger ways of dealing with and defining existence. When the time for growth is clear to individuals, they can start by establishing baselines of their current functions in the world, evaluating the efficiency of their behavior and whether it's satisfying or not. With an objective perspective, Debaters may find room for improvement, and they can try out new actions and attitudes to help accomplish it.

Not all personal growth needs to be the product of deliberate effort. Sometimes it emerges gently from subtle shifts caused by age and maturity, and sometimes life prompts growth through hard times and crises. Debaters possess a wonderful enthusiasm for active experimentation, and when they use it to manage their growth, life's inevitable changes are likely to be positive rather than random. As the old saying

goes, “You’re either getting better, or you’re getting worse. There’s no staying the same.”

Focusing on the Here and Now

For Debaters, personal growth often involves applying their inquisitive engagement of the outer world in realistic ways. To progress in life, many individuals need some orientation tool to help them recognize the right way to go, a sort of map or landmark, as well as the mindset to walk that path once they find it. For Debaters, their enthusiasm for new and interesting paths may distract them from some of life’s important landmarks, and personal growth starts with understanding their unique challenges in this regard.

People with this personality type can hardly wait to see what’s next in life, often becoming lost in excitement rather than grounded where they are. They don’t lack for willpower when something grips their imagination, but learning to maintain steady concentration is just as important. Without stopping to focus on the here and now, they may struggle to carry their grand ideas to fruition. Debaters are bold seekers of truth, and personal growth can help them to balance their tendencies, carefully dividing their energy between their chosen priorities and whatever wonder may be over the horizon.

Abundant Energy for Growth

Debaters possess a wonderful combination of open-minded rationality and ready willingness to experiment – a perfect combination of tools to create personal growth. Debaters seize and are seized by inspiration not merely because of a feeling, but because the lure of potential triggers an intellectual spark. Throughout their lives, they may respond to this calling by embracing academic or professional challenges

or by engaging other people. Although they don't often easily settle on a predetermined path, Debaters are nonetheless doers, acting to chase their ideas, hopes, and curiosity.

Personal growth expands on their outwardly focused energy by inviting Debaters to also look at themselves and see their vast potential for self-improvement. It's more than a quest to understand themselves; it's the idea that conscious change can follow on the heels of awareness. Their naturally energetic approach to any challenge also drives them. Sometimes the greatest use of their powerful minds is to turn them inward, to use objectivity to build joyful respect for who they are and what they might become. In this chapter, we'll discuss how they can pursue personal growth, as well as certain areas of self that Debaters may want to examine.

Motivation and Development

Debaters can consider personal growth in five closely related but distinct areas. The first three relate to internal development of self-regard, and the latter two are more about tactics to engage a more fulfilling life.

Motivation:

- **Self-esteem** speaks to how much Debaters like themselves. Accepting both their flaws and their strengths creates a base of internal appreciation that enables change motivated by desire instead of shame.
- **Self-respect** refers to their sense of worth. People with this personality type value rational creativity, and when they live their beliefs and values, a balanced sense of pride in who they are accordingly follows.

- **Self-confidence** is the energy source that moves Debaters forward in life. When external engagement affirms their belief in their abilities, they can keep moving forward.

Development:

- **Self-evolution** describes processes of conscious growth that Debaters take on to realize their potential. Knowing when to assess and expand themselves enhances their abilities and their happiness.
- **Self-responsibility** is taking charge of their lives by accepting accountability for what they can do to improve things. Being conscious of their behavior helps them create what they want, instead of being buffeted by fate.

Debaters who attend to all five core components are more likely to lead successful and fulfilling lives, but a lack in any of the areas is likely to become a source of persistent difficulty. Insightful by nature, Debaters often benefit from asking themselves whether they're approaching life in balanced ways. Regardless of where their journeys start, every step forward represents a new place, a success unto itself. Debaters can decide for themselves what brings them to a joyful life. It could be anything, from traditional success in the form of great careers or happy families, to lives as globe-trotting explorers who experience everything the world has to offer.

Moving Forward

Conscious personal growth is about more than feeling obligated to change – it also requires the wisdom to seek new ways to be happier and more successful, based on a personalized definition of success. This chapter's goal is to spur that drive with ideas, encouragement, and guidance on some likely problems along the way, in the five areas mentioned above.

In the following sections, we'll first examine Debaters' characteristics in their beneficial form. Using these components in a "balanced" way helps them lead fulfilling, productive, and happy lives. Then we'll describe "unbalanced" tendencies that can emerge. We will address departures from healthy, productive motivation strategies, and we'll explain some adverse effects Debaters may experience as a result. Finally, we'll discuss what may be done to improve or "rebalance" within each of the motivational components. We'll suggest exercises, reflection, and actions to aid Debaters in the process of personal growth and development.

Self-Esteem

It's surprisingly common for rational people to struggle reconciling their intellectual tendencies with the emotional parts of their brains. Yet Debaters who maintain a firm connection to their inner sense of harmony also create strength in the higher functions of their beings, which they can express outwardly. Being at war within inhibits creation of a happy and inspired life, but self-appreciation is a state from which all good things can grow.

Balanced Self-Esteem

The Strength of Inner Harmony

Debaters are inquisitive and observant, and one of the ways they create balanced self-esteem is by being conscious of their feelings and facing them head-on. People with this personality type understand the value of rationally examining things in detail and keeping an eye on their inner workings to stay objective about life. When they look at their feelings honestly, they can let go of negative self-perceptions and discover how their humanity underpins their intellectuality in wonderful ways.

The benefits of working toward balance aren't just internal, as self-esteem tends to manifest outwardly as competence. When Debaters feel happy with who they are inside, many potentially troublesome behaviors can be replaced with productive ones, thanks to that inner security. Those with positive self-esteem don't need to diminish others to prove themselves, for example, because they know that their worthiness stands on its own. It's as if inner harmony flows out to positively affect all areas of life, making self-esteem an important step in personal growth.

Loving Their Minds

Debaters also develop their sense of self-esteem based on how well they can use their agile minds to figure things out, as well as how adept they are at articulating and defending their ideas. They tend to draw connections quickly and think creatively. Over a lifetime, recognizing and practicing these qualities can build an ever-increasing appreciation of self. For a personality type that values intellectuality, being creative is the ultimate self-affirmation. This helps Debaters feel like "sources" of good things, in addition to having clever perceptions.

Because accomplishment and success typically start with an idea, Debaters' self-esteem logically follows on the heels of their sense of their ability to come up with and implement ideas. In their hearts, they feel good about the condition of their minds. When self-esteem is in balance, they don't need to base it on strict or traditional measures of success or comparison to others. Instead, it comes from an appreciation of their fertile imaginations, knowing they can use that power to make their lives better.

Unbalanced Self-Esteem

Dismissing Feelings

The desire to explore is among Debaters' virtues. However, they often dismiss things with which they're less comfortable, such as emotions (in themselves and others), in favor of what they consider to be more worthy pursuits. Such disregard for feelings can result in unbalanced self-esteem because it creates inherent dishonesty – the same seemingly arbitrary, messy, irrational states of feeling that Debaters may decry are also within them. Ignoring emotions to safeguard against their destructive elements can also leave untapped their virtuous sides, such as compassion, forgiveness, and esteem for self.

It's easy to understand why Debaters might seek self-regard through intellectuality rather than emotion: The latter can be confusing and daunting to confront, especially for a personality type that so respects and seeks to embody reason. However, those who deny the complete makeup of their being – both mind *and* heart – are avoiding reality. Without embracing the feelings that are part of the human experience, Debaters cannot make peace with themselves, and their self-esteem may reach an eventual limit.

Relying on Argument

Debaters are aptly named for their ability to vibrantly communicate their opinions, but their expressions become unbalanced when they attempt to validate their self-esteem by dismissing the value of contrasting contributions. Debaters bolstered by such unbalanced exercise of intellectual ability may begin to believe only their press, placing their thoughts high above those of others, even despite contradictory

evidence. Such ignorance, however unwitting, is pure poison for the intellectual capability that often defines Debaters' self-esteem.

If their self-regard is threatened – or simply underdeveloped – they may attack other views, preferring to feel powerful rather than practice respect or decorum. Bluster may win arguments at the cost of facts, but truly rational minds cannot tolerate such falsity without internal recrimination, even if they never show it on the outside. Any self-esteem Debaters build at the expense of a fair exchange with others is highly vulnerable if they should ever truly recognize such arbitrariness in themselves. For Debaters, truth and wisdom are too valuable to trade for a sense of intellectual superiority.

Rebalancing Self-Esteem

Embracing a Complete View of Self

Debaters can vitalize their self-esteem by accepting the presence of emotion instead of sweeping it aside. Becoming comfortable with the emotional side of themselves may take time, but Debaters can capitalize on the enthusiastic flexibility that often comes easily to them. A non-judgmental style is an asset when it comes to rebalancing self-esteem – when their emotions become a source of confusion, they can forgive themselves for simply being human.

Their tendency to engage intellectually rarely leads Debaters into vital internal challenges the way exploring their softer sides would. To help rebalance their connection with their emotions, a simple, direct approach may help them overcome any hesitation. A brief self-review exercise is one way Debaters can learn to be OK with their everyday feelings and balance their self-esteem:

- When preparing for bed (brushing your teeth, etc.), take a moment to envision the following categories.
 - Unhappy self-regard
 - Happy self-regard
- Think back over the day and recall a moment of self-criticism, self-judgment, or self-doubt. Tag it as “unhappy self-regard.”
- Do the same for a moment of fair satisfaction with yourself, and mentally tag it as “happy self-regard.”
- Don’t worry if there isn’t an event to correspond to both categories. Just recall what’s available and proceed.
- Rather than view these feelings as right or wrong, look at them as just part of the brain’s function and, therefore, as much a part of the body as skin. For example, events can produce upset emotional responses in the brain, just as the stomach might become upset by bad food – it’s a natural mechanism like any other, not a sign of a faulty system.
- Without self-judgment, consider how the events influenced the day. What helped or hindered personal goals, progress, and motivation? If there isn’t a recallable event in one of the categories, why not? Is that a good thing?
- Take a moment to forgive any self-created negativity experienced during the day. It would be irrational to be upset if skin got goosebumps in response to being cold, so there’s no need to feel bad about negative emotional responses, either. Just as you would make a conscious decision to move into a warmer room, decide to adjust your emotional state of mind.
- If this exercise reveals an appealing opportunity to do something differently, contemplate some constructive and optimistic ways to do so. That’s a great way to end the review process before bed and set a positive goal for the next day.

Profound action isn't always required for Debaters to feel good about themselves, but regularly accessing their emotions in healthy ways may require deliberate effort. Luckily, the practice of positive feelings often starts to feel like a reward rather than an obligation.

Acknowledging Value and Merit

Instead of assuming their superiority, Debaters can consider worthy wisdom from others, even if it reshapes their views – a wonderful thing for anyone who really values truth and knowledge. Their pride can grow when they find correctness, and their intellectual strength can be demonstrated when they accept being corrected. Debaters create balanced self-esteem when they see their worth as based not only on what they know but also on their ability to learn and grow.

Debaters should also be aware that claiming intellectual triumph doesn't necessarily keep knowledge flowing – it's important to recognize when contrasting facts and opinions contribute to better understanding. People with this personality type can remind themselves that everything they know was once new information to them, and much of it was gained from others. Such realizations may help moderate any flashes of arrogance without harm to self-esteem. To help maintain pride in what they know without losing touch with what the world has yet to teach, they can practice the following:

- Pause whenever a new fact, experience, or conversation teaches something valuable.
- Consciously acknowledge the contribution and its benefits as coming from an outside source.

- When new information contradicts a personal belief, take a moment to think about what's more valuable: the ego boost from displaying knowledge, or the elevation of mind that comes from learning new things.
- Actively and outwardly express appreciation to any source of learning. If it's a book, give it a quick positive review online; if it's a person, thank them sincerely.

Self-esteem always comes into play when Debaters compare their mental output to others', but it doesn't need to be dependent on such comparisons. When they see how their ability to be flexible and absorb knowledge can affirm their mental capability, it creates happiness instead of conflict, as well as self-esteem that stands on a strong foundation.

Self-Respect

Debaters build self-respect when they live in accordance with their values and pursue their ideas. They're inquisitive by nature, so such things may be fluid, as the ongoing process of personal growth reveals new goals and ideas with which to experiment. Whatever shifts may happen, however, Debaters are happiest when they stay true to their underlying set of intellectual principles.

Balanced Self-Respect

Independent Thinkers

Debaters respect themselves when they're able to construct and express their views – they don't feel nearly as validated when they're spoon-fed information. They tend to question everything boldly in their search for truth. Of course, trading thoughts constructively and fairly with others is a natural extension of how Debaters practice balanced self-respect. When they're receptive, they ensure that people want to hear

their views, which in turn helps them see their worth. An open mind earns respect by the very fact that it offers it.

Such healthy expressions of intellectual independence may lead Debaters down the “road less traveled,” introducing them to fresh perspectives and perhaps at times even revolutionary ideas. Finding a balance between pursuing their views and sharing truths back and forth with other people fosters self-respect. Rather than reinventing the wheel, Debaters roll along into new territory. When they exchange contributions with others and the world around them, their value becomes outwardly apparent – a welcome side effect.

Spirited Engagement

The best ideas remain only theory unless they’re put into action, and Debaters are often ready for that next step. Enthusiasm doesn’t always equate proficiency, though. People with the Debater personality type maintain balanced self-respect when they understand that accomplishments take time, and that developing valuable skills may be clumsy at first. They also know that’s no reason to give up: Debaters have a keen ability to adapt to their environment, so they can get what they want from life. They find balance when they employ rational planning and patience, leaving them room to concurrently and deftly think on their feet.

When Debaters embrace balance among originality, vigorous action, and dedication, they’re much more likely to reach their imaginative goals. They love to experiment, and the results can reflect the value of their effort, so their inspired intent doesn’t always need a firm or specific goal to yield respectable results, either. When Debaters accomplish something, they affirm their creative energy, and that’s something they respect deeply in themselves.

Unbalanced Self-Respect

Extreme Defiance

An independent mentality can become destructive when Debaters act arrogantly or aggressively toward the world at large by constantly pushing their bold ideas – all too easy for this meddlesome type. Debaters who mistakenly conflate ego with self-respect may cast off the structure that supports their lives with the assumption they're above it all. When it begins to preclude anything outside their views, their self-respect becomes unbalanced, leading to brash reactions and disregard for otherwise reasonable boundaries.

When Debaters reject conformity to an extreme, they can easily conflict with everyday realities, harming their professional and personal lives. If something doesn't make sense to them, they may refuse to fall in line, brusquely going their own way. When they take these rebellious tendencies too far, such an adversarial stance can destroy many opportunities for changing the way people think through communication and participation. This is far from the active, creative engagement that lets Debaters thrive, be happy, and respect themselves.

Abandoned Ideas

Enthusiastic minds don't always produce usable results. Debaters are thrilled to jump into new things, but they don't always maintain their focused drive; their attention can wane before they fully test a theory or finish a project. Despite energetic initial effort, Debaters often find the consistency and commitment required by their lofty pursuits boring – or find the next pursuit too distracting. Failure to recognize the value of a full process, start to finish, may pull them in too many directions, robbing them of success.

Over time, a mounting collection of unfinished projects, half-met commitments, and unrealized dreams can easily harm their sense of self-respect if they feel they have inadequate results to show for their efforts. Even if Debaters are happy following their inspired instincts into some degree of chaos, the outside world may not be forgiving of what might be seen as inconsistency or a lack of follow-through on important matters, resulting in missed opportunities or increased friction in both professional and personal arenas.

Rebalancing Self-Respect

Seizing Useful Elements

To rebalance rambunctious independence that offers no practical advancement, Debaters must recognize that even if conformity is undesirable, there's value in participation. From a rational perspective, they can examine principles or conventions and utilize only the elements they appreciate. Balanced self-respect includes doing what's best for their growth, even if it requires a little self-control over their abundant energy while they figure out what works.

People compromise to get along in the world reasonably, and patient evaluation is a reasonable compromise Debaters can make before dismissing ideas entirely. In a sense, it's often just a matter of willing engagement and adaptation – both of which are Debater strengths. Adjusting their understanding falls well within Debaters' skill set as well, and their curiosity can be a great motivator. Their independent, assertive spirit can lead to great things, but isolation due to excessive independence isn't so good. When Debaters feel like plowing over something, they can try the following:

- Consider it with an open mind. Sometimes the depth of a concept's value isn't apparent from the outside, and it would be a shame to miss out on a good opportunity. The best evaluation comes out of full immersion.
- Seek the benefit. Debaters are among the most energetically willing types – when they're in the mood. Finding the personal benefits of a convention they initially dismissed can rebalance an overly dismissive reaction.
- Take it apart mentally. The goal is rational analysis, but there's no commitment to maintain the structure of something while you check it out – the useful parts may be more apparent with some clever dissection.
- Improve the concept. Before steamrolling over something with a “superior” idea, determine whether it can be adapted and improved – often a quicker and far more efficient path to something better than starting from scratch.

Debaters can forge their path while still participating in the world. For them, self-respect comes from inspired practices and excellent outcomes, and there's no reason not to incorporate beneficial elements wherever they can find them. Even when they're going their own direction, they can still pick up some good things up along the way.

Focused on Finishing

When people with this personality type experience the power of creativity in enhancing their lives, they see the value of supplementing wide-ranging interests with some narrowed effort. Debaters rarely lack for energy, but they often must work to maintain focus – a worthy path of personal growth. Payoff is a key factor here, as rational minds recognize the importance of practical self-investment as a prerequisite for advancement. No one is better suited to creating their own success

than Debaters, but to do so, they may have to identify – and stick to – some priorities in life.

The mere practice of dedication can be a source of healthy self-respect, regardless of the outcome. Naturally, people also derive much pride when the consistent effort they put forth offers an eventual reward. Even completing a small project can represent major growth, as the point is to practice consistency and achieve a goal. Here are some steps to practice follow-through:

- Pick a small idea to make life happier (for example, a relatively major, long-desired personal purchase).
- Decide on the scale and time involved. We suggest something that can be finished in about a month, but of course, some things have inherent limits. (The aforementioned example might require a savings plan over several months.)
- Start doing it immediately – delay serves little purpose. (In the example, start an “item fund” in a secure place.)
- Automate involvement as much as possible. Schedules requiring pure, focused willpower may not be ideal for Debaters, but a clever system that automatically elicits consistency is (for example, an automatic bank transfer every payday into the fund).
- Use calendar and/or reminder apps to stay on track. Remember, you are practicing the skill of consistent dedication; the project itself is just a vehicle.
- Tell close friends, family, and loved ones about the project. Their awareness and attention can serve as supporting motivation.
- Stick to the plan, focusing on the good things it will bring. (Won't it be great to have that new item?)

Debaters can practice true and ongoing focus by according themselves respect for whatever they accomplish. Self-respect can't be dependent on doing what others want, but it flourishes when Debaters proudly do what they know can help them make progress.

Self-Confidence

Flowing from the concepts of self-esteem and self-respect, self-confidence is the energy to maintain positive self-views in the face of the world's challenges and eventual setbacks in life. Self-confidence allows Debaters to move forward with their ideas and choices, using their energy wisely to be successful and happy.

Balanced Self-Confidence

Applying Rationality

People with this personality type affirm self-confident energy by actively using their ingenuity and sense of reason, with their creative minds serving as a source of motivation to persevere against challenges and achieve their goals. Debaters think that if it's rational, they can do it, and finding ways to implement their ideas in the world is the sure thing that drives them in life. Concepts and principles fuel them more than feelings, and their great willingness to put energy into the products of their imaginations is rewarded when the world recognizes their efforts.

When they also take this view toward their growth, Debaters can construct wise paths forward in their lives. They embrace new knowledge to reinforce their efforts, but they also take strength from knowing they can figure things out, and they're ready to understand whatever may come. Yet part of their energy comes from the fact that they don't need to think an idea to exhaustion before they take action. Debaters

invest in motion, giving them self-confidence that isn't just energetic but also effective when applied in the world.

Engaged with the World

For Debaters, self-confidence isn't about certainty; it's about the lure of potential and the excitement of trying to do things – preferably not alone. Debaters aren't known for being resolute as much as vigorous. Their willingness to try things out, sometimes spontaneously, gives them great momentum in life, and it draws in others. Their tendency toward engagement can also drive personal growth, keeping them open to change and improvement.

Whether a social setting, work method, or entirely unfamiliar activity, Debaters initially find self-confident energy through imagination, but then they easily shift into action, always interested to see where their efforts take them. Such curiosity can easily overcome personal limits or prejudices, and Debaters embody balanced self-confidence by openly seeking whatever the world has to offer.

Unbalanced Self-Confidence

Avoiding Emotion

Debaters' motivation may suffer in realms that exist outside of the rational. This isn't because they lack energy, but because they don't always see the point of putting effort toward areas of life where logic reveals little. Therefore, they may avoid situations they can't comprehend through some rational construct. Deep feelings and emotions sometimes seem of little importance to people with this personality type, and the reasons behind them don't always make immediate sense, defying Debaters' brisk, inquisitive, sometimes raw rationality.

Trying to grapple with such things in the world around them can eventually become tiresome, even to a personality type that enjoys engagement. When it seems that their mentality is ineffective, Debaters may become confused and daunted, especially when trying to deal with other people who don't seem to speak their language of logic. Realizing that they can't always predict the course of emotions can feel disheartening, and without restoring balance, they may simply dismiss such things, much to the chagrin of everyone around them.

Hewing at the Bramble Patch

Rebelliousness is virtually a watchword for Debaters. If their path is blocked by a metaphorical patch of thorns, they may very well take up mental machetes and hack away, excited to test their intellect. However, they sometimes rise to such challenges out of reflexive more than reflective intent, not necessarily applying their abilities to a helpful end. For them, mental challenges themselves may provide the appeal. However, even though they might blaze trails, emerging bloodied in unfamiliar places is hardly a rational use of power, or a reflection of balanced self-confidence.

One downside to strong momentum is that it doesn't necessarily require good direction, nor does it healthily self-correct in response to reasonable resistance. Willful Debaters can easily find themselves tangled in battles of dubious necessity or questionable personal benefit, solely because they want to triumph. Those who perpetually choose onslaught often find thorny opposition sprouting around them, and they may not find much time to enjoy life when they're lost in the weeds.

Rebalancing Self-Confidence

Emotional Experimentation

The solution to a lack of traction can sometimes be a headlong slide forward. Debaters can try an engaged approach when they're initially unable to get their head around seemingly irrational emotion. For a type who so wants to understand everything, just diving in can both leverage and maintain their energetic self-confidence. Avoidance doesn't generate answers nor personal growth, but Debaters can challenge themselves to understand the seeming vagaries of emotion from the inside out.

It's difficult for people with this personality type to accept that some factors are beyond their control and then move forward, but faltering self-confidence is often just the result of feeling as though they lack knowledge. Therefore, some direct, rational engagement with others can help Debaters rebalance a dismissive attitude toward emotion – and help them gain the information that gives them confidence. As an exercise in understanding emotion, Debaters can use their analytical abilities to practice it as a skill:

- Pick someone you know personally and whom you respect who seems to have an “emotional” nature.
- During regular contact (and perhaps by spending more time with them), observe their expressions of emotion.
- Analyze the mechanisms of what the person says or does to create a connection with others. Look for things like kind words to strangers, attentive listening to friends, or a sunny demeanor they willingly share with those around them.
- Try to internally answer the following questions.

- Do they connect with others positively by using emotion?
- Do they seem to feel rewarded by sharing emotion?
- Do other people seem to enjoy the exchange?
- How might you practice this beneficial behavior personally?
- Attempt to sincerely employ the skill with that same person. Reflect to them whatever it is they do to create positive emotional returns. (Use their methods – but your own words.)
- Observe the effects and note any improvements in communication and mood.
- Practice these steps with new people as well.

Debaters may not find the language of emotion to be their native tongue, but when they try to speak it using role models from their lives, they can come to respect, and perhaps even understand, its value in life. Emotional logic is a valid way of living, and its mechanisms have a very real effect on people's lives. When Debaters are willing to step in and try to understand emotion instead of avoiding or dismissing it as irrational, their self-confident energy can remain strong.

Picking a Beneficial Path

Debaters' enthusiastic yet prickly nature has the potential to endear them to others when they use their self-confident energy to be helpful. Debaters are wise to pick their battles, not out to fear but out of a thoughtful desire to achieve something genuinely worth their efforts. They can provide fruitfully from their work, but their personal resources are finite. Some thoughtfulness can help them overcome argumentative reactions, often leaving them more time to enjoy life instead.

One crucial way for Debaters to rebalance their use of energy is to turn their tenacious, inquisitive logic inward and determine what they truly want from life. The

answers can be used as guidance for seeking happiness deliberately and wisely. In addition, Debaters can rebalance their tendency to get sidetracked in the fray by reconnecting with their original desire.

The best time to find a worthy path for self-confident energy is today, and Debaters can try the following:

- Narrow down a few personal skills or abilities that bring you happiness – anything from writing to working with children to practicing carpentry.
- Research ways each of your personal skills could be put to good use in the world, to create personal satisfaction as well as possible broader benefit.
- Figure out what's needed to develop and practice each pursuit (time, money, education, or maybe just a chance to get started?).
- Seek out local places, organizations, or venues where the skills could be used, such as a class, employment position, or volunteer opportunity.
- Ask to sit in and observe how others are already applying similar skills. Get some realistic information and feedback, then let the knowledge both temper and inspire your imagination.
- Think about which pursuit would provide the most happiness and excitement. Be sure to rationally consider all the information available, as well as listen to your heart.
- Having researched options, costs, and potential, decide to try one out – there's not much greater satisfaction than developing a skill that's enjoyable, and it may even turn into a lifelong joy.

Debaters can use their explorative vigor to follow a wisely chosen, joyful path, one where they won't stray into the overgrowth. Bypassing life's richer experiences for

the sake of a fight is typically regrettable, especially when that same self-confident energy can be used to seek happiness and worthwhile growth.

Self-Evolution

Self-evolution is the idea that Debaters can turn their love of engagement toward improving themselves, constantly looking for ways to grow. It's important to note that self-evolution is about personal fulfillment – anything ranging from academic aspirations to something as soul-satisfying as learning to paint. The point of self-evolution isn't marching austere toward a traditional goal, but rather daring to develop potential into reality.

Balanced Self-Evolution

Willing Evolution

Bold seekers of truth by nature, Debaters who want balanced intellectual growth are aware that they regularly need more information and insight at every stage of their lives. Their fertile imaginations keep the door propped open for new thinking about themselves, as well as the world. More importantly, their rational logic requires them to recognize their mistaken perceptions, just as they strive against ignorance around them.

Self-evolution requires more than merely considering new perspectives. Debaters find balance by utilizing principles that were previously outside their intellectual capacity or knowledge base, amending their views, and then acting. Most rewarding is when they find opportunities to share such advancement with others, moderating the frustrations with the world around them. Passionate problem-solvers, Debaters

vigorously seek to expand their capabilities to make life better, and they want to share that mission with other people.

Practical Learning

Given their brightly engaged manner, Debaters often successfully advance their minds by practicing their ideas in logical ways. Although exploring ideas is compelling and worthwhile, Debaters can avoid getting carried away by applying their creativity to the world around them in hands-on ways. Whether connecting with others for intellectual growth and exchange or experimenting on their own, Debaters balance their self-evolution by putting their boots on the ground in the real world.

People with this personality type are the source of many great ideas, and when they explore how the products of their thoughts can fit into reality, they experience a refreshed perspective that can update their thinking and touch off new ideas to pursue. Such efforts breed valuable feedback, serving as concrete points of balance for their inspired narratives and creative flow of thought. Nothing teaches better than experience, and active engagement is a balanced and exciting way Debaters can evolve.

Unbalanced Self-Evolution

Mental Recycling

Debaters want to understand reality, but they sometimes become wedded to their ways, their openness to change clouded by the strength of their opinions. They may even reject good ideas merely because they're too different from their preferred practices. Without objective balance, mental elasticity and sharp insightfulness can be used to justify stale habits just as easily as new experiences. Although wide-eyed

self-evolution has potential for expanding their understanding, intellectual repetition has potential for fostering ignorance.

Nowhere does this become more obvious than when people with this personality type refuse to constructively contribute to other people's initiatives and ideas. Debaters can easily pick apart methods, activities, and goals they don't like, choosing to question their validity before exploring them to form fair conclusions. Debaters may feel quite accomplished by dismissing practical opportunities unaligned with their existing views, not realizing they are among the greatest opportunities for growth.

Bullhorns and Banners

One of Debaters' most cherished abilities is their animated, creative communication style: They typically shine when speaking to an audience, and they often even enjoy it tremendously. However, excessively sharing their thoughts and knowledge can resemble overbearing, unbalanced monologues rather than engaged conversations. In the heat of the moment, Debaters can easily drown out others' voices, both literally and metaphorically, dispensing with their learned communication skills amid the thrill of broadcasting.

When they forget the value of bilateral connections with others, they miss out on the unexpected inspiration and support that people can offer through unique voices, collaborative ideas, and even thoughtful dissent. Intellectual and verbal vivacity is wonderful, but a self-important, unbalanced view of communication inhibits self-evolution and ultimately stifles growth.

Rebalancing Self-Evolution

Challenging Themselves with Change

For Debaters, practicing what they already know isn't the most effective path to self-evolution. Instead, the very definition of balanced self-evolution is tempering their reliance on their existing experience, then following their passion for progress and learning. People with this personality type can handle exposing themselves to contradictory or ambiguous practices in order to grow. Debaters' feisty mindset may tempt them to argue for what they hold dear, but personal growth comes from using that vigor to instead challenge themselves to try things.

Being willing to evolve their conclusions is a huge asset for Debaters, preventing missed opportunities and easing friction. They can decide to be ready to change when needed, building their knowledge from any source they can. Even less than successful endeavors provide information. Openness allows true wisdom to blossom, and Debaters can start by practicing positive change voluntarily:

- Instead of dismissing new views and ideas, decide to try them out. After all, gathering empirical evidence is necessary to either refute something or understand its benefits.
- Ask people who have new ideas for as much detail as possible. Employ constructive conversation rather than critical dissection.
- Ask for a demonstration of how they make these ideas work in their lives, then show positive appreciation for their efforts.
- Apply their approaches sincerely to test their usefulness. Keep in mind that they may end up being worthy, useful methods, so real effort is a wise investment in potential self-evolution.

- Give them more than one chance, and try them under different circumstances.
- Look for ways to hybridize and adapt others' ideas to make them personally suitable. Personal circumstances, needs, and skills differ – and it's not a contest; it's about searching for improvement.

For Debaters, experimentation can be an extremely fulfilling practice, as well as a reliable way to spur self-evolution. Seeing and doing something for themselves not only satisfies their need for rational proof, but it also feeds their active sense of curiosity – an excellent way to evolve their sharp minds.

Hearing What Others Have to Say

If communication is a worthy effort, then comprehending what others are trying to express is the grand fruition of that effort. Learning information doesn't necessarily mean agreeing with it, but without deep understanding, a fair debate can never take place. Before Debaters argue or broadcast their opinions, they owe themselves and others the respect of truly listening. To do otherwise is to invite faulty decision-making, closing a great avenue for self-evolution.

Debaters often speak with wit; to listen as adeptly is a skill they can consciously improve. It may take patience to digest people's intentions, but Debaters can reap the rewards of honest give-and-take by making people feel valued. Asking others about what they know – and respecting their responses – can create a balanced cycle of exchange. Lively, fair conversation is a progenitor of wisdom that feeds Debaters' minds, perhaps even expanding their vocabulary of thought. A basic series of actions can help them practice receptive listening:

- Enter or start a conversation with gentle inquires – and a friendly smile.

- Ask questions and show interest in others' thoughts, validating them with honest attention.
- Give others all the time they need to share their thoughts by waiting to speak rather than interjecting. Silences, not pauses, are the green light.
- Listen carefully to what people say rather than risk becoming distracted as you formulate a response or relate a personal experience.
- If asked questions, try to give answers on the subject at hand that are useful. *Give knowledge; don't just display it.*
- Respond succinctly – don't hold the floor very long.
- Stay receptive by steering things back to questions and listening. It's OK to donate your own fair share of talk time.
- End exchanges with thoughtful positivity, even if not in agreement – "That's interesting. I'll have to think about that!"

Debaters have many opinions to share, but self-evolution requires balancing opinions with careful and respectful listening so that knowledge can flow in both directions. A dialogue, not a monologue, elicits the best from everyone. Their excellent mental flexibility lets Debaters find the value in other people's perspectives, and even a little such insight leads to better communication.

Self-Responsibility

This personal growth facet is about Debaters' decisions and what they value. People with this personality type are capable of great passion, whether caring for family, excelling at their jobs, or breathing life into creative projects. Consciously accepting ownership of all aspects of their objectives is key to personal growth; self-responsibility represents both accountability and capability in Debaters' lives.

Balanced Self-Responsibility

Jurisdiction Over Life

Debaters have a gift for dissecting concepts and events, looking both backward and forward in time to see causes and probabilities surrounding almost anything. Blending that ability with self-responsibility gives them influence over the events in their lives, allowing them to choose how they respond. Debaters are perceptive, but it's not always possible to predict the future. People with this personality type create balance when they use their abilities to adapt to whatever happens and still press forward responsibly with their goals. Balance, for Debaters, is about choosing to take responsibility for their fate.

This can mean different things depending on the situation, and it is more of an *attitude* of ownership than a specific course of action. For Debaters, self-responsibility means using knowledge and willpower to their greatest possible benefits and knowing that dwelling on negative reactions squanders precious time when happiness and success beckon. True greatness and personal growth are found not in the measure of ability – but in *how* ability is used. When Debaters accept accountability for their lives, they empower themselves to create a better future.

Courageous Acceptance

Debaters encounter upsetting situations and people, and acceptance isn't always easy for a personality type that so boisterously loves to argue. But even if it isn't easy, self-responsible Debaters rise to the challenge of moderating themselves. They balance their reactions to seemingly outrageous experiences by recognizing that self-responsibility allows them to choose *not* to engage, especially when progressive

action isn't an option. This allows them to redirect their energy usefully instead; they can find loftier places for their passion than pointless conflicts.

Debaters may have to work harder than most to separate themselves from frustration, but such ongoing efforts lead them toward balanced self-responsibility. Constant agitation rarely brings happiness and success, and Debaters have better use for their heads than beating them against a wall. When they practice acceptance of circumstances, that can instead seek functional solutions. When they accept other people, they often find unexpected cooperation in applying their ideas to make their lives better.

Unbalanced Self-Responsibility

Obsessed with Indictment

The fact that Debaters can see the workings of the world in complex detail is generally a virtue, but when they experience misfortune, their analytical tendencies can lead them into blameful dissection, tearing apart everything that offends them. It's all too easy for such an expressive personality type to dispense criticism when incompetence or mental deficiencies seem so obvious. They may even come off as bullies. Yet they may not readily see their own need for personal accountability, nor take the self-responsible step of transmuting their ire into restorative action.

In fact, Debaters' tendency to express anger toward perceived inadequacy or failure often serves only to feed a vicious cycle of cynicism, even around legitimate complaints. Energy focused on outrage could be used productively, but when Debaters believe they're right and don't see any culpability in themselves, they may assume they don't have any responsibility to remedy the situation. This unbalanced,

avoidant attitude can shift from positive capability into passive negativity, a state where they'll struggle to survive, much less thrive.

Destructive Intolerance

It's understandable to be frustrated: Their keen perceptions see the myriad problems in everyday reality. But attacking everything they see as "broken" is unbalanced – it's simply unrealistic to expect life to conform to their expectations, and holding such opinions can embitter them, a feeling they all too often project. When Debaters let their indignation get out of hand, they may find themselves in a state of anger, which prevents them from embracing opportunities for personal progress.

Allowing such attitudes to persist not only threatens Debaters' happiness and health but also can damage personal and professional relationships. Self-responsibility certainly involves speaking the truth, but Debaters may mistake that for the right to judge others. People with this personality type struggle to be accepting, often putting them at odds with people in their lives. Even if not directed at anyone they know, the force and harshness of Debaters' dissension can be so unpleasant as to disturb or even drive away those close to them.

Rebalancing Self-Responsibility

Taking Responsibility for Their Lives

Blame is hardly an ideal way for these capable and creative types to use energy. Debaters can recognize the logical benefits of building something better than blame when life lets them down. Instead, they can take responsibility – not only to adapt gracefully to circumstances but also to own up to their own involvement. There's

great value in rooting out the cause of any problem, and once it's found, self-responsibility is a gesture of power because it claims an ability to effect change.

Self-responsibility also means learning from problems with an eye toward preventing them in the future. Debaters might accurately fault external causes for certain issues, but participating in a solution, even patiently mentoring those they previously criticized, is a far more satisfying and effective approach. Their energy and cleverness can certainly enable more productive action than mere finger-pointing. When something goes wrong in life, Debaters can use the following steps to help turn their minds toward progress instead of blame:

- Ask, “What happened?” Before assigning blame, seek answers with a cool, analytical mindset. The truth may come to light and provide a useful perspective.
 - Go over the chain of events to uncover the details of what happened. Ask others for their take on events.
 - Map things out on paper, if needed, including others’ descriptions of events. Limiting the analysis to one perspective is almost certainly ignoring additional data.
 - If the root problem can be identified, see if it can be fixed. This is also a great time to seek the counsel of trusted, respected friends, family members, or colleagues.
- Be forgiving. Inanimate objects can’t give apologies, and people can’t undo history. Forgiveness benefits those who give it – stress and anger make life miserable, and they do real physical and mental harm. Calm patience is a rational investment in personal health.
- Move forward. Feelings of blame don’t always go away quickly, but focusing on progressive action is helpful.

- Elevate others. Instead of pointing out how people are wrong, respectfully offer them mentorship – and be graceful if they decline.

The above steps are rational, but frankly, sometimes frustration and the desire to blame can be raw, so consider a classic but always helpful tool that any type can use to release emotion.

- Let it out. Write an unrestrained rant to the source of the problem and then read it aloud in private, letting out emotional energy along with the spoken words.
- Afterward, burn it – literally light it on fire or otherwise destroy it.
- If desired, do it all over again, start to finish. Let the acts of composing, expressing, and releasing negative thoughts and feelings create a sense of relief.
- Then move on to happiness and progress.

By examining how they can improve things instead of blaming themselves, others, or circumstances for their problems, Debaters can balance their sense of self-responsibility.

Being Accepting

Life presents nearly infinite opportunities to criticize. The world is full of flaws and flawed people, and tolerance and acceptance can seem like flimsy concepts to Debaters confronted by things they find offensive. However, practicing these virtues can rebalance frustration that produces no benefit and pushes others away. Debaters can do so by using one of their greatest strengths: inquisitiveness. They'll often find that their reactions are the source of their frustrations. Rational objectivity can reveal that harsh reactions aren't only unnecessary but also within their power to change. With Debaters' adaptability, such a mindset is within their reach.

This practice is about emotional self-control as well as logic, but its core is reason. Debaters can decide to embrace open curiosity, putting aside prejudice in favor of first-hand experience. Many things these imaginative people may rail against are conceptual or distant, with little direct bearing on their lives, but constantly doing intellectual battle may accomplish little to bring about happiness. Here's an exercise Debaters can use to practice tolerance. (It may require a little planning in advance.)

- Enter a social situation antithetical to your personal opinions, and decide to withhold judgment or thought. (For example, a progressive atheist could sit in the back of an orthodox religious service.)
- Quietly listen and absorb for 10–15 minutes (or longer if the subject proves interesting).
- Allow internal judgment (intolerance), but simply observe it instead of delving into it – collect the facts, not the feelings.
- If emotions like anger or frustration come up, feel them for five seconds, then refocus. It's important to respect and allow emotions, even while rebalancing them.
- Try and find the upside, even if it's not personally applicable. What are its positive points? How does it benefit people? Why do people like it, and how is that legitimate?
- Tally up the positives and negatives, then determine whether the positives make the situation more acceptable. Something needn't be enjoyed nor even engaged to be tolerated. If possible, meet up with a friend and discuss your observations out loud.
- Realize that the objectionable situation will always be there – but it's a matter of self-responsibility to focus on it or not.

- Keep this idea in mind every day: Where you place attention and energy is a personal choice.

There's no magic bullet available when Debaters perceive genuinely odious things. However, being right or telling others they're wrong isn't always enough to make life happy. Sometimes triumph lies in recognizing what can ultimately be a pyrrhic victory, as opposed to what can foster mutual understanding and progress.

Conclusion

Choosing Elevation

When it comes to using their strengths, Debaters face a precipice. To put it simply, they tend to be forceful people, and purely following their instincts can cause them real problems. There's a fine line between brilliance and arrogance, between eloquence and bluster. Their tremendous potential just as easily applies to distinguished accomplishments – there's no personality type more capable of waging unconventional warfare against ignorance, obstruction, and villainy. Balanced self-respect and self-confidence can make Debaters magnanimous agents of good.

When they balance their instincts with the clarity of their intellect, Debaters retain their passion and imagination while exercising self-control and wisdom, enabling rational decisions and lofty aspirations to coexist. Leaping into such grand potential is essential to their happiness, and when they learn not to go over the edge – or step on others as they leap – their direction can be as admirable to others as it is thrilling for them. Consciously utilizing self-responsibility doesn't prevent Debaters from engaging their passions in life, but it can help create positive outcomes.

Debaters may never come to admire certain aspects of life, but they always have the option to help themselves thrive within those constructs – or build something better. When they accept the challenge of self-evolution, they may gain the wisdom and ability not only to prosper amid life's problems but also to overcome them. It feels great to hurdle over obstacles, be they external or internal, and once Debaters find their keys to success by growing past their personal limits, there's little they can't do. When they excel to their standards, they and others tend to admire who they are learning to become.

Additional Tools and Tests

Want to dig even deeper into your personal growth? If you have access to the toolkits area of the website, we offer a variety of additional tools and tests to help you explore.

Locus of Control Test

Dig deeper into who or what you feel is responsible for your life satisfaction, happiness, and level of fulfillment.

Emotional Intelligence Test

Find out how good you are at understanding your own emotions as well as paying attention to the emotions of others with this test.

Confidence Test

How much do you believe in your competence and ability to successfully follow through on the choices you make? Let's find out.

Dark and Light Side Test

Your moral choices may not be as simple as you think. This test asks you to go deep and take an honest look at your attitudes.

Resilience and Grit Test

Some people are hard to knock down; some find it easy to get back up; and some are both or neither. Which group do you belong to?

Coping Styles Test

There are four primary ways to cope with crisis. This test explores the dominant and secondary techniques you're likely to turn to.

Optimism and Pessimism Test

This simple test measures your levels of both optimism and pessimism in a novel way. Find out where you fall in each of these areas.

Imagination and Magic Beliefs Test

How does your imagination work? What is your belief about magic? Explore the role of imagination, magic, and belief in your life.

Traveling Preferences Test

This simple test delves into your preferred choices during those times when you leave home to explore the world.

Romantic Relationships



Debaters spice up their romantic relationships just as they add flavor to other areas of their lives: by entertaining new perspectives and indulging in contrarian views. Their cognitive flexibility enables them to enjoy the company of partners who are radically different from themselves – and given Debaters’ relatively unique perspective and their rarity as a type, that means nearly everyone. Their critical thinking skills can be surprisingly useful in romantic contexts. Thanks to their combination of rationality and open-mindedness, Debaters have a solid foundation when it comes to making important decisions in tandem with their significant others.

All that said, people with this personality type often need to moderate their argumentative tendencies with romantic partners. However well intended, a barrage of debates and disagreements can come across as nitpicking, engendering resentment or hurt feelings among their loved ones. Debaters must learn to operate from the assumption that they’re on the same team as their partners, while still maintaining their curiosity about different points of view. It may take time and effort

to achieve such balance. Fortunately, Debaters aren't afraid of a worthy challenge, and love can provide all the motivation they need.

Surprisingly Passionate

It's easy to assume that all individuals with the Thinking trait – including Debaters – are unromantic or unfeeling, yet anyone who's seen Debaters in heated intellectual arguments can attest to their passion. But can that passion translate to romantic relationships? Of course. As Extraverts, Debaters draw energy from spending time with others, and this proves true in matters of the heart as well as the mind.

People with this personality type crave connection as much as anyone, and their inner spark helps them stand out as enthusiastic, captivating, passionate lovers. Compared with most other Analysts, novelty and change stimulate Debaters, and they use that preference to stoke the fires of their relationships. They want to shake up the status quo on a regular basis. The result is that their relationships rarely settle into the stale ruts or tired routines that eventually weigh down many long-term partnerships.

Love Lockdown

However strong their feelings may be, Debaters don't stand out as emotionally expressive. In many cases, they don't see the utility of overtly expressing affection – at least not in conventionally romantic ways. As far as they're concerned, the mere fact that they've devoted time and energy to a relationship should be proof enough of their love. Socially sanctioned expressions of affection – from Valentine's flowers to elaborate proposals – can seem trite or hollow to Debaters, who regard many social norms with a critical eye. When they do go along with such conventions, it's often a calculated maneuver to please their partners rather than a spontaneous

outpouring of emotion. But as their relationships mature, Debaters often learn to express their feelings – including love and affection – more readily and authentically.

Alas, Debaters' reluctance to express emotion runs deeper than social contrarianism. Emotionally blocked Debaters tend to resent situations that make them "lose control" of their emotions, and in the context of romantic relationships, they may inadvertently take out that resentment on their significant others. Although it's perfectly natural to experience intense feelings, many Debaters conflate the experience with abandoning rationality or losing control. Unless they learn to share their emotions in healthy ways – *and* share in their partners' expressions of emotion – Debaters will struggle to build egalitarian relationships that can withstand conflict while allowing for exuberance, joy, and true connection.

Daters Gonna Date

As Analysts, Debaters don't always appreciate the superficial niceties of dating rituals. Whether they're wondering when to text someone they've met or who should pay for dinner, people with this personality type often take issue with the social conventions of courtship. But rituals often have a distinct purpose, however irrational they might seem. Debaters who throw convention to the wind sometimes discourage potential partners unintentionally – they may get better results if they at least respect dating rituals, even if they don't always play by the rules.

Other pitfalls can cause Debaters to stumble early in relationships. Small talk, the stuff of first dates, baffles them. They'd rather dive deep, exploring controversial issues. At times, they might embark on lengthy monologues about subjects they find fascinating, particularly if it gives them the opportunity to show off an unusual stance or opinion. That approach, however well intended, can come across to other types

as aggressive, critical, or tone-deaf. Debaters might walk away from a date thinking they've shared a fantastic, lively conversation, but the other person may complain afterward to a friend, "My date wouldn't let me get a word in edgewise."

That phenomenon can reappear through all stages of their relationships. Debaters' confidence is tied to their ability to put together a winning argument, and when their self-esteem is challenged, they may overcompensate by showing off their analytical prowess. Unfortunately, a brash, cerebral demonstration, especially a showy one, may come across as arrogant or excessive to their dates – and anyone else within earshot. Ironically, Debaters may win people over more easily when they don't try too hard.

People with this personality type can see past superficial traits like physical attractiveness and social status to identify partners who are truly good matches for them. They can spot potential in others, even people quite dissimilar to them, and willingly imagine how a relationship with any given person might play out. Though such predictions don't always hold true, Debaters' incisiveness can save them years of chasing after individuals who aren't a match for them. When they do find someone they like, Debaters favor a charismatic blend of boldness and authenticity to capture the attention of potential lovers.

Keeping the Love Alive – Or Not

Even if they seem stoic or unruffled on the outside, Debaters don't escape pain when their romances struggle – which all relationships do, at one point or another. Those with a balanced, positive approach to their relationships pause to evaluate the situation, using their natural tendency toward open-mindedness to consider what's working and what isn't. They also engage their partners candidly but sensitively,

taking care to listen as much as they talk. Using the resulting insights, balanced Debaters work with their significant others to develop a concrete plan to improve their relationships. Above all, they ensure that they give the connection a fair chance before giving up on it.

Debaters with an imbalanced approach might dissect the situation in unhelpful, blame-oriented ways, focusing on their lovers' shortcomings. Alternatively, they might overreact to misalignments in their relationships, perhaps even initiating breakups right away to avoid future messiness and painful emotions. Again, this tends to stem from a desire to protect themselves. Unfortunately, a "shoot first, ask questions later" attitude comes at the expense of true intimacy.

Once Debaters discover that there's more to life than being right, they're more likely to experience love and romance. It may be hard for them to fully experience the intimacy of love. But if they allow themselves to expand their comfort zones, work on their emotional intelligence, and let other people into their world, Debaters will find a new dimension of life. The act of connecting to a trusted partner on emotionally and physically intimate levels leads Debaters to tremendous personal growth. When lovers reveal those facets of life to them, Debaters give the gifts of loyalty and imaginative insight in exchange.

Potential Pairings

Cultivating lasting relationships isn't always easy, especially for a personality type that so restlessly questions the status quo. Whether in romantic partnerships or other aspects of their lives, Debaters won't settle for something "good enough." As a result, they aren't content with partnerships that, however comfortable or convenient, remain superficial. Fortunately, every personality type has something to

contribute, and as Debaters date and pursue long-term romances, they find many opportunities for meaningful connections.

The following section explains common patterns in relationships between Debaters and each of the different Role groups – Analysts, Diplomats, Sentinels, and Explorers. By understanding the patterns, people with the Debater personality type can approach their romantic lives with insight and strategic awareness, maximizing their chances of finding and sustaining meaningful, loving partnerships.

Debater–Analyst Relationships



It's often said that "opposites attract," as if human hearts were emotional magnets. If that's true, it's fortunate that no two people are exactly alike, even if they share the same basic personality traits, like Debaters and other Analysts. Although their shared Intuitive and Thinking traits lend similarities, different Energy and Tactics aspects also influence each partner's personality, as well as the impact of personal experiences and life lessons. Even with their similarities, these lovers have plenty of nuances and differences to keep their relationships exciting.

Balanced Debater-Analyst Relationships

Expanding Comfort Zones Together

Debaters and their Analyst partners can connect deeply over stimulating conversations, common interests, and their shared intellectual drive. Their dinners together are short on small talk and simple accounts of each other's days. Instead, they might swap big ideas, share clever insights, and dissect hypothetical scenarios. In fact, such couples may regard their interactions as a refuge from the petty world they must put up with outside of their romance.

These couples grow together if they take a balanced approach to their relationships, not only enjoying their shared affinities but also working together to expand their comfort zones. Ironically, for these couples, venturing beyond their comfort zones may entail taking it easy – for example, relaxing or indulging in simple pleasures. Even Analysts need light and spontaneous fun occasionally. Reminding each other of that, through word or action, lightens some of the heaviness of expectations and responsibility.

Above the Shoulders

When any two Analyst types bond romantically, they favor intellectual rather than emotional stimulation. This might seem to indicate a complete absence of spark or passion, but that's not at all true. These couples communicate their passion most readily by sharing ideas and insights rather than by delving into emotional terrain. The dynamic can be perfectly healthy, if both partners recognize such conversations as expressions of mutual esteem and affection.

These couples appreciate frank discussion, which – in balanced relationships – enables them to deal with sticking points in a timely manner. Debaters in healthy partnerships with other Analysts face their issues head-on. They discuss areas of conflict in clear, precise terms, always keeping an eye toward solutions. Provided they see each other as being on the same side, they can find satisfaction and improve their relationships by working together to understand their issues – then solve them.

Unbalanced Debater-Analyst Relationships

Subconscious Expectations

If reliance on reason comes at the expense of understanding, Debaters and their Analyst partners may think their love needs underlying rationales or reasons, rather than accepting that their feelings exist outside of their conscious understanding or control. As a way of hunting for such rationales, Debaters and other Analysts may assess and measure their lovers. Because their expectations tend to be quite lofty, any partners or potential partners, in time, will fall short.

Debaters might feel they know exactly what they need in a romantic relationship. For example, they might believe they would do best with someone exactly like themselves and therefore pursue fellow Analysts. However, that line of thinking has a few logical problems. First, no one can know exactly what sort of romantic partner is best for them. Second, even the most comprehensive checklist can't capture the full complexity of a specific person. Unaccounted-for dimensions of complexity can make all the difference between a successful partnership and an unsuccessful one. Third, Analysts are a diverse group of people, with varying traits and different life experiences. Debaters must recognize their partners (and potential partners) as

unique individuals. If they can't set aside their checklists and expectations, they can expect unhappiness, tension, and disconnection, rather than romantic bliss.

Organizational Meltdowns

Organization can be problematic for Debaters and their Analyst partners. Both are Intuitive – they prefer to think about novel, big-picture ideas, as well as the future. But between the two of them, who puts dinner on the table every night? Who buys the groceries? When visionary types come together, practical matters frequently suffer. As much as they may like the idea of an organized home, the reality of conquering the mundane chores may not be quite as attractive. The issue might never come up during the dating phase, but it can cause tension once they move in together.

Decision-making can also pose problems for these couples, particularly when they must choose from many imperfect or uncertain options. It's easy to imagine harried Debater-Analyst couples spending countless evenings researching, brainstorming, and pacing back and forth in their dining rooms. They may discuss and argue for and against a decision for hours without coming to a final decision. This phenomenon isn't exclusive to major life decisions, either: A Saturday trip to a park can become a joyless affair if these couples can't relax, set aside their checklists, and step out into the world.

Rebalancing Debater-Analyst Relationships

Communicating Appreciation

Even the most rational people have flaws. Debater-Analyst couples may want to experiment with getting out of their heads occasionally and living in the here and

now. Appreciating each other instead of analyzing can strengthen their loving relationships. People are tremendously complex, and even the most astute Debaters may never fully understand everything about their beloveds. But this is a feature, not a bug. The strength of these romances comes when both people enjoy their partners as they are – not try to impose their preconceptions on each other.

Debaters and other Analysts may not be fluent in the language of the heart, but that doesn't mean they shouldn't attempt to talk about their feelings – including their appreciation for their lovers. Any relationship can suffer if partners fail to share what they admire about each other. Debaters can take a more proactive stance by doing the following:

- Grab a piece of a paper and write at the top, *"I feel loved when my partner..."* List specific actions that trigger feelings of being loved, respected, and understood.
- During the list-making process, pay attention to other emotions that arise, such as happiness, contentment, peace, love, joy, warmth, or gratefulness. List the emotions next to each entry that elicits them.
- The next time your partner does one of the things on the list, comment on how you feel and express appreciation. For example, "I feel grateful when you make coffee for me in the morning. Thank you."

The goal is for Debaters to notice and express gratitude for the everyday things they appreciate about their partners, which can be a powerful antidote for preconceptions and expectations. By demonstrating how to communicate emotions, Debaters can break open their relationships with Analysts, creating an environment where both partners feel secure sharing how they feel.

The Dreaded Chore Chart

Practically speaking, it is wise for Debater–Analyst couples to address chores and responsibilities head-on. If they ignore everyday to-dos, they will find themselves mired in unnecessary stress, which inevitably takes its toll on romance. Something as trivial as having nothing to cook for dinner can trigger an argument at the end of a long day.

Fortunately, these couples don't have to spend all their free time on chores – nor should they. Instead, they can create calendar reminders for recurring tasks such as picking up groceries or dry cleaning, as well as establish automatic bill payments. They also can consider outsourcing certain tasks such as maintaining the lawn and cleaning the house, if resources permit.

These lovers also may want to avoid taking on too many projects or products that require routine maintenance, from “fixer-upper” houses to additional cars – unless they truly love such things, that is. Keeping their material world simple is the name of the game. By minimizing the number of claims on their time and attention, they can free up time to learn and grow together. To accomplish this, they can try the following exercise:

- Set aside 30 minutes to discuss household responsibilities. Program a half-hour into a timer or alarm clock – and be sure to finish the exercise before it goes off.
- Discuss each partner's vision for a well-run, well-maintained life. How clean does the home have to be? How often must laundry be done?
- List every recurring chore, sorting them into the following categories: finances, cleaning and laundry, home maintenance, shopping and errands, and

miscellaneous. If relevant, add child care, yard maintenance, car maintenance, and any other responsibilities specific to your lifestyles.

- Circle every item that can be automated, such as paying bills or setting aside a certain amount of money from each paycheck for retirement. Decide which partner will set up the automations and mutually determine a deadline for doing so. If possible, tackle such tasks in the moment, while the inspiration to do so is fresh.
- Cross out sources of “chore stress” that can be eliminated, such as underused tools, unworn clothes, or unloved clutter that just fills up the cabinets and accumulates dust. Plan how to dispose of the items appropriately.
- Divide the remaining tasks, mutually agreeing on who will take care of what and how frequently they will do so. Set aside some chores to do together, and find ways to make them relatively enjoyable – such as putting on music or pairing a trip to the hardware store with a visit to a pizza parlor.
- Every week, revisit the list and decide which tasks will be prioritized for the days ahead. Schedule time to take care of them.

This simple 30-minute process can reduce chore-related stress and help couples create systems for tackling practical responsibilities. The result: more time to enjoy each other’s company and fewer distractions as they work toward their missions.

Debater-Diplomat Relationships



Comfortable with ideas and abstractions, Debaters and Diplomats share a visionary, open-minded view of the world. Despite their mutual interest in creativity and inspiration, however, they aren't identical – in romance, each offers capabilities that don't come naturally to the other. Whereas Debaters excel at improving systems and assessing lines of thinking, Diplomats enjoy profound human insight. As time progresses, their differing perspectives can enable Debater-Diplomat couples to balance each other's weaknesses and bring out the best in each other, creating loving bonds of mutual respect and trust.

Balanced Debater-Diplomat Relationships

Embracing Thoughtfulness

Like Debaters, Diplomats are attracted to bold, original thinking. Neither has much patience for small talk – their romantic connection thrives when they get past formalities. Some might say, "We don't discuss religion or politics at the dinner table," but these Intuitive types might both respond, "Then what's there to talk about?" Diplomats delve into the human side of issues, and Debaters push for thorough, logical understanding. When they value their differing perspectives as

complementary rather than incompatible, the result is lively, meaningful conversation – and lasting attraction.

Given their creative, imaginative minds, these lovers find endless subjects to discuss. Topics that combine technology and human progress – using social media to apply pressure to oppressive regimes or corrupt institutions, for example – can have them talking for months, as can more personal discussions about goals and dreams. Far from idle chit-chat, their conversations reignite the spark, fostering respect, affection, and mutual curiosity even as the relationship progresses.

A Balanced Team

Debaters often struggle to bring warmth and emotion into their relationships, and Diplomats balance that out beautifully. Leading by example, Diplomats can help Debaters better understand not just sensitivity and romance, but also the value of human connections that transcend the realm of intellectual respect. They also may inspire Debaters to recognize the value of being altruistic and prioritizing others. With Diplomats' help, Debaters can reap the rewards of an emotional attunement that surpasses intellect alone.

In turn, Debaters often impress their Diplomat significant others through their ability to wrangle with big ideas in rational ways. In healthy relationships, Debaters offer reasoned, thoughtful stances on difficult, complex decisions – from which house to buy to the merits of a different political view. They also remind Diplomats to be realistic when it comes to committing their time and energy to helping others. Unlike some other types, Debaters can offer reason without curtailing these couples' shared sense of progress and possibility. The result is a beautiful counterpoint to Diplomats' idealistic – and at times unrealistic – fervor.

Unbalanced Debater–Diplomat Relationships

Emotionally Unprepared

Debaters' idealization of rationality and pragmatism can chafe against Diplomats' emotional attunement. It can become especially prominent when Diplomats want to release pent-up emotion by venting about their problems to their lovers. In such situations, rather than express sympathy or compassion, Debaters typically jump in to offer solutions. They might even take a devil's advocate approach, trying to talk Diplomats out of their negative emotions.

In many cases, that backfires, making Diplomat partners feel invalidated and unheard. Diplomats may misinterpret Debaters' suggestions and advice as a cold lack of empathy, perhaps even a lack of caring. When Diplomats talk about their problems, they often want their loved ones to listen to them and acknowledge their pain, not to "correct" their thinking or offer an action plan.

The dynamic works in both directions. Diplomat partners may instinctively offer empathy to Debaters, who are often looking for rational solutions rather than "touchy-feely" sentiments. Debaters may be bewildered by Diplomats' willingness to engage directly with emotions in conversation. Diplomats are willing to say, "Are you feeling OK?" or "You seem down. What's going on?" Although they believe they're offering warmth and compassion, such inquiries are sometimes heard differently by Debaters, who may perceive such directness as overly dramatic or emotionally provocative. Diplomats, in turn, may feel dejected when their Debater lovers don't seem to understand their good intentions, whereas Debaters may remain frustrated by unwanted injections of emotionality into their problems. As a result, both can miss

out on the intimate understanding that's one of the most remarkable aspects of romantic relationships.

Different Concepts of Romance

Debaters and Diplomats think differently when it comes to romantic gestures and emotional expression. Diplomats enjoy hearing words of affirmation and sharing affectionate touch with their significant others as indicators of love, and they may feel neglected when their partners don't express their love in emotional ways. Debaters, however, may prefer to express their romantic feelings in more practical or rational ways – for example, by offering guidance or simply being present. However, Diplomats might not understand such actions as indicators of affection, craving more emotional expressions of love instead.

During the dating stage, Debaters might successfully “fake” some of the sentimental rituals of courtship. Soon enough, however, Diplomats detect when a gesture doesn't come from the heart. In such a circumstance, they may feel disappointed, much to Debaters' chagrin – when Debaters perform romantic gestures, they do it solely to make their partners happy; if they've gone through the motions of buying flowers or writing a lovey-dovey message in a greeting card, they expect their beloveds to feel pleased, not disappointed. The gap might seem like a superficial obstacle, but demonstrations of emotional support and connection mean a great deal to Diplomats – something Debaters may struggle to understand.

Rebalancing Debater-Diplomat Relationships

Focusing on Understanding

When Diplomat partners come to them with a complaint or a problem, Debaters might be tempted to offer guidance, advice, and ideas for solutions. If Diplomats are hoping for support and validation rather than feedback, however, a significant disconnect can arise. The consequence is that neither feels valued or understood; as a result, they lose out on the opportunity to truly understand each other.

In such conversations, Debaters can suppress the instinct to suggest a solution immediately, starting instead with a validating statement – for example, “That really does sound difficult.” By engaging in active listening rather than leaping in with advice, Debaters can help their Diplomat lovers feel heard and understood. At some point, once Diplomats have had an opportunity to share their feelings, it may be appropriate for Debaters to ask whether they want some suggestions. However, they should actively resist offering any advice until they receive the go-ahead. Here’s how Debaters can effectively listen:

- Eliminate all distractions – power down the cell phones, close the laptops, and turn off the television.
- Invite your Diplomat partner to speak their piece.
- Participate in the conversation with clarifying questions: “When you say ‘X,’ what do you mean?”
- Don’t try to “correct” or minimize how your Diplomat partner is feeling. Instead, express validation by acknowledging their emotions.

- While listening, refrain from attempts to “solve” the problem, whether internally or aloud. All attention should be focused on listening, understanding, and validating.
- Check any interpretations by saying, “What I’m hearing you say is that you feel [feeling] because [trigger or activating event]. Is that right?”
- When tempted to offer a solution, ask, “Would you like me to offer support, or are you looking for solutions?” This not only allows your partner to clearly state their needs but also reminds them that you are ready to offer practical advice if it’s needed.
- If the summary is correct, take some time to think about a response. If the situation calls for it, ask what steps could be taken together as a couple to remedy the situation.

A well-known saying goes, “Do you want to be right, or do you want to be loved?” Debaters might roll their eyes at this line of thinking, but the truth is that they sometimes need to temper the need to prove themselves right (or prove others wrong) to foster healthy romance. Although diplomacy may not be Debaters’ most natural tendency (statistically, they much prefer “negotiation”), it can be learned. Being more of a small “d” diplomat can be helpful in creating bonds, especially with capital “D” Diplomats.

Sharing Love Effectively

Relationship expert Gary Chapman theorizes that people feel and express love in five ways: words of affirmation, quality time, acts of service, physical touch, and gifts. Different people prefer different modes of expressing love, which Chapman refers to as “love languages.” Unless partners share their love in ways that their beloveds understand and feel, couples can become increasingly isolated and resentful.

What does this mean for Debater–Diplomat couples? In many cases, Debaters must recognize that their Diplomat partners’ love languages – which might include words of affirmation, physical touch, and gifts – are just as valid as the love languages that seem more rational, such as acts of service or quality time. In that light, Debaters can work to understand what makes their significant others feel loved and respected, and – just as importantly – they can learn to take joy in doing whatever elicits positive feelings. With time, Debaters might find that expressions of love that used to seem frivolous or pointless, such as buying a birthday card and writing a personalized message in it, become pleasurable because they bring so much happiness to their Diplomat lovers.

Here’s how Debaters can effectively express love to their Diplomat partners:

- Investigate how your partner expresses love. What gestures do they use? Do they say kind things, offer foot massages, give gifts, help with pesky chores, or plan quality time together? Chances are that their actions reflect their preferences for how they’d like to receive affection.
- Keep a running list of such gestures, perhaps in a notebook or a mobile device.
- Reciprocate affection daily by offering one of the gestures to your Diplomat lover. Using your powerful intuition, you can deduce what your partner could use in the moment, and you can harness your natural spontaneity to act right away.

By learning how to share their love in ways their Diplomat partners can feel, Debaters can focus their energy and attention on gestures of affection that truly make a difference in their relationships.

Debater-Sentinel Relationships



What happens when those who are fascinated by disruptive ideas fall in love with those who value stability? Debaters and Sentinels might not seem like an easy match, but they have much to offer each other. Debaters are often amazed by Sentinels' resilient effectiveness, and Sentinels who long to break out of their shells may fall in love with the way Debaters open themselves to new experiences and new ways of thinking. In these romances, Sentinels' persistence and pragmatism can inspire Debaters to deliver on their big ideas, and in return, Debaters can help Sentinels throw off the weight of social expectations and needless obligations.

Balanced Debater-Sentinel Relationships

Clear Desires

Even in the dating phase, Debaters' and Sentinels' shared interest in effectiveness can help them find common ground. In general, Debaters hold rationally developed expectations for what they'd like to find in potential mates. Sentinels' requirements tend to be different, gleaned from their upbringing, their life experiences, and societal expectations. That said, both recognize that the other has strong opinions as

to what they want, and for them, few traits are more seductive than that kind of clarity.

If they allow *some* room for the illogic of love, these couples can easily recognize how their strengths complement each other. Debaters' no-nonsense analytical skills can appeal to Sentinels' desire for a partner who offers a well-reasoned life. In turn, Sentinels may appeal to Debaters through their organizational abilities, their attention to detail, and their acuity when it comes to community building – three areas where Debaters may at times feel inadequate. Provided their life goals are aligned, these lovers have what it takes to articulate their desires and work together to achieve them – *and* find the process surprisingly enjoyable.

Never a Dull Moment (Seriously)

When we think of exciting personality types, Sentinels might not be the first to come to mind. But in relationships, Debaters and Sentinels can provide each other with just enough novelty to keep things spicy. Debaters bring an influx of new ideas to romance, keeping Sentinels from settling into ruts and drudgery. Sentinels may roll their eyes at many of the things their Debater partners say and do, but if their relationships have a solid foundation of respect, Debaters might find this pushback a turn-on rather than a deal-breaker.

Over time, Debater–Sentinel couples turn new ideas into lasting traditions together – a blend that satisfies both. For example, if these lovers talk about news stories over breakfast every morning, Debaters can delight in engaging with fresh perspectives and information with their partners, whereas Sentinels can enjoy the stability of a shared routine. This might not sound like much fun to other personality types, but for these two, it's the stuff of lasting connection.

Unbalanced Debater-Sentinel Relationships

Misalignments

If Debaters dismiss the things their Sentinel partners enjoy as “boring” or “staid,” they risk feeling bored in their romances. Debaters enjoy constant stimulation, but Sentinels crave predictability, often returning to the same routines and activities. Something as seemingly trivial as arguing over whether to try a hip new place for dinner or return to an old standby can cause real tension for these couples, leading Debaters to feel stifled and Sentinels to feel judged or misunderstood.

Debaters who don’t cultivate an open mind might assume that their Sentinel partners’ hobbies or preferences are boring, without even trying them. Sentinels’ interests might not be as edgy as Debaters’, and Sentinels may even enjoy staying home on a more regular basis than their Debater significant others. Debaters may not share their loved ones’ interests, but if they allow this to erode their respect for their partners, they will put the relationship at risk.

Taken for Granted

Clashing over practical matters can be a regular occurrence when Intuitive and Observant types spend time together. Debaters can appear absent-minded – or mentally overstimulated – in the light of Sentinels’ concrete pragmatism. Debaters might like the *idea* of organization and planning, but Sentinels live it. Conflict comes when Debaters don’t marry their idealized version of planning with reality. Such organization is the core of Sentinels’ very being and grounds them, but Debaters may shrug it off as “not *that* important.”

Debaters might fail to value the practical, small-scale contributions their Sentinel partners make to their shared lives. Taking out the trash, paying the bills, or even booking restaurant reservations might seem like trivial or even unnecessary affairs to Debaters, but the actions take work and are integral to a smoothly functioning relationship. Like anyone, Sentinels enjoy being valued, and when gratitude isn't forthcoming, they may veer into passive-aggressive terrain. This triggers vague, hard-to-pin-down tension in their romance; consequently, Debaters might not even realize that their lovers feel disrespected or taken for granted.

Rebalancing Debater-Sentinel Relationships

Heal Thyself

A common mistake between romantic partners is to see one's own traits as superior to those of the other person. Attempting to remake a significant other into one's own image is rarely successful. Debaters need to appreciate that Sentinels won't always be comfortable with their big ideas and their constant attempts to reimagine things. Without such awareness, trying to force Sentinels to "get it" can become a futile obsession.

However, before Debaters criticize their partners (or even indulge in internalized judgment), they can take a hard look at whether they even meet their own standards of broadmindedness. Have they opened themselves to the unfamiliar ideas and approaches their beloveds have embraced, such as setting weekly routines or joining a civic group?

For an exercise, Debaters can try "going along for the ride:"

- Participate in something your Sentinel partner enjoys (e.g., a television show, the tennis club, drinks with friends).
- Actively seek out the good in each activity and determine whether the reality of each situation matches your preconceived expectations.
- Gather empirical evidence with the intent of observation, not to prove something wrong.
- Use what you've observed to suggest new activities that satisfy your partner's preferences. This will give your lover a familiar base, even as you push into new territory.

With a few steps and the right attitude, the differences between these two can be the spice that makes their romantic relationships more flavorful. Debaters might even reframe it as an adventurous excursion into someone else's world.

Patient Action

Debaters' wilder theories and concepts are often just that: theories and concepts. But when they offer vague ideas about dinner or muse about some weekend activity (and then forget 10 minutes later), their lack of follow-through may create day-to-day frustration that erodes romance. Alternatively, they might push so hard for their new ideas that they don't allow their Sentinel partners the time they need to weigh the options.

Although Sentinels don't hesitate to take action once they've made a decision, they need adequate time to make decisions in the first place. One solution: Debaters can ensure they allow their Sentinel partners enough time to muse over new ideas and adjust to the possibility of change. If Sentinels give the green light, Debaters can prove their reliability by promptly and predictably launching into action.

Here's a system Debaters can use to effectively share ideas with their Sentinel partners:

- Keep a whiteboard in a frequented part of the home. Divide it into two columns.
 - After you suggest an idea to your partner, rather than pushing for a response, jot down the idea in the left-hand column (for example, "Trip to France?").
 - Your Sentinel partner can record their thoughts in the right-hand column when they're ready (for example, "Trip to Nice in the spring" or "Maybe something more budget-friendly."
- Once your Sentinel partner has weighed in, it's time for a conversation about next steps. Who can do what to put the idea into action?
- Finally, take prompt action on the tasks that fall under your purview, as a way of demonstrating your trustworthiness and commitment.

When Debaters record their ideas on a whiteboard, Sentinels can take their time to weigh different options, adjust to possible changes, and respond once they're ready. By embarking on the exercise, Debaters can gain a system for preserving their ideas that otherwise fade away ("Remember that time we talked about...?"), and Sentinels can gain time to reflect before they pass judgment on their partners' ideas.

Debater-Explorer Relationships



Debater-Explorer couples know how to steer clear of the ruts and routines that put a damper on so many long-term relationships. They don't agree on everything, but they share a willingness to explore alternative options and to shake up the status quo. In balanced romances, that willingness fuels their initial attraction – and enables them to move on from arguments and develop fulfilling, lasting relationships.

Balanced Debater-Explorer Relationships

Problem-Solving Pair

What sets Debater-Explorer relationships apart is the way curiosity fuels their ambition. In the early stages of their courtship, Debaters might fall in love with the way Explorers gladly tackle big challenges and the unknown, such as learning a new musical instrument or mastering a new tool – all without making a big deal of it. Meanwhile, Debaters' relentless desire to solve problems and improve the status quo speaks to Explorers' renegade hearts.

As these couples evolve and mature, they become problem-solving teams, trusting in their ability to tackle whatever is in their way – and, most importantly, to do it

together. Debaters develop deep gratitude for Explorers' willingness to jump in and get their hands dirty, recognizing that trait as an important counterbalance to their tendency to analyze rather than act. In return, Explorers develop abiding respect for Debater lovers who manage to connect their ideas to something practical and immediately useful, especially if it improves their shared lives.

Seriously Open

During the dating phase, Explorers' unusual combination of spontaneity and practicality can fire up Debaters. Owners of adventurous imaginations themselves, Debaters aren't quite as comfortable in novel, real-time situations as their Explorer lovers. To offset their hyper-analytical nature, Debaters may indulge in some of Explorers' loose, fun-loving attitudes – particularly if they can find a good reason to do so.

As romance develops and these couples face major life decisions – like getting married, buying a house, or having children – the two grow to appreciate each other's comfort with disregarding social conventions. These couples don't wither under the weight of traditional gender roles or measures of success, and they aren't afraid to grant each other some space. This comes in handy when they become so obsessed with their individual projects that they seem almost entirely detached from their home lives. These couples enjoy their time together as well as their time apart.

Debaters and Explorers think on their feet in different ways. If they can tap into both ways in service of their love for each other, they're more likely to find satisfying romantic lives together. Debaters bring fresh, exciting ideas to the table, whereas Explorers bring their kinetic versions of ideas to life.

Unbalanced Debater-Explorer Relationships

Who Knows Best?

Despite their independence, Explorers aren't impervious to slights. Debaters must take care not to talk down to Explorer partners, particularly in their explanations. For example, Debaters might assume that their lovers aren't informed about given topics, and ensuing explanations can have the unintended consequence of making Explorers feel disrespected. Debaters must also watch out for any tendency toward harshness. Particularly when Explorers refuse to engage in lofty, abstract discussions or muse about the future, Debaters may unintentionally – or even intentionally – convey to their significant others that their interests lack depth or meaning.

That dynamic can chip away at the emotional bond that holds Debater-Explorer relationships together. Debaters who assume, even subconsciously, that their partners are somehow “lesser” are doing their relationships a disservice by effectively blinding themselves to everything their significant others can offer. As in all relationships, love and respect are essential to longevity.

Whose Responsibility?

Once again, household maintenance rears its ugly head. In Debater-Explorer relationships, household chores and bills may frequently fall on Explorers' shoulders. Alas, Explorers' preference for living in the moment may not necessarily make them the most consistently responsible people, either. They'll deal with persistent issues, but only when they become absolutely pressing – for example, an overdue bill or a total lack of clean clothes. The result is chaos and unpredictability, which create unnecessary stress, even for these relatively easygoing souls.

Interestingly, these partners have their own unique strengths when it comes to household responsibilities. However, the differences between their approaches mean they might not recognize their lovers' contributions. Because they're relatively future-oriented, Debaters might focus on pre-empting future problems; for example, by paying bills before they come due. They might feel that their Explorer partners aren't doing their fair share, while simultaneously ignoring what Explorers are pitching in (e.g., tackling overflowing laundry baskets as they arise). Meanwhile, Explorers might feel as if they're the only ones doing chores, not noticing or appreciating that their Debater partners keep the water running so the laundry can get washed in the first place.

Rebalancing Debater-Explorer Relationships

Good Complaining

When Debaters assume that their Explorer beloveds are superficial or unknowledgeable, they are invoking one of the “four horsemen of the apocalypse” identified by relationship researcher John Gottman. Specifically, they are using criticism – among the most toxic communication styles in romantic relationships. Paradoxically, if Explorers resist (or roll their eyes at) such judgment, Debaters might feel more inclined to criticize their partners, doing so with greater frequency or force, as well as more damaging effects. That will pave the way for Explorers to react defensively and volley their own recriminations.

Fortunately, their romance isn't doomed. According to Gottman, the antidote to criticism is to complain without blame. For example, “You never want to talk about anything deep or meaningful,” might become, “I love to share my ideas with you because you mean so much to me. Up for talking through a big idea?” That way, these

partners can still express their feelings and their frustrations – after all, it is never good to bottle those up too tightly – without wounding each other. The other benefit is that this type of communication opens the door for hands-on fixes, something Explorers can happily identify and implement. Here are some steps to practice “good complaining.”

Consider whether a complaint is necessary. Some things simply don’t need to be said. When in doubt, wait for one minute before speaking. (Note that this is different from repression. If frustration grows rather than diminishes with time, it probably needs to be expressed.)

- When in doubt, use a casual, good-humored tone. If a complaint is made in a friendly tone, Explorers are more likely to be amused about being called out than offended.
- Make a positive request. In other words, ask for something specific in positive terms. “Can we stop talking about the party?” might become, “Could we talk about an idea of mine for a few minutes?”
- Bear in mind that Explorers crave *doing*, not talking. When appropriate, go on a hike or take a scenic drive to offer a better backdrop for meaningful conversation than hanging around home – fortunately, it’s something that appeals to both.

As positive conversations come to outweigh criticisms, Debaters will reacquaint themselves with their Explorer lovers’ strengths and gifts. Whatever their challenges, the immediacy and tangibility of Debater–Explorer relationships create deeply moving moments, which can overcome challenges of all scales.

Procrastination Begone

When these couples sense a lack of connection with each other, the issue may have surprisingly tangible roots. Even for these two, heaps of unopened mail, half-finished home-improvement projects, and overflowing trash cans create stress. Add some tension over who should do what, and there's a recipe for frazzled, disconnected lovers.

The time comes, sooner or later, to sit down and pay the bills, and Debaters can actively encourage their Explorer partners – and themselves – to attend to such practical matters. Fortunately, between Explorers' bias toward action and Debaters' ability to plan, they are more than capable of tackling their to-dos. These partners may be more focused on higher personal goals than laundry, but by forming an understanding and following through, they can support each other's attention to mundane responsibilities.

Here's how Debaters can take an action-oriented approach toward tackling chores with their Explorer partners:

- Choose an item of unfinished business, from dirty dishes in the sink to cluttered surfaces.
- Be spontaneous, seizing small pockets of time such as TV commercial breaks to tackle pressing matters together.
- Set a timer and see how much can be done during that time. (For example, how many shirts can be folded, or how many items of trash can be collected from various surfaces and thrown away?)
- Next, set a timer for an even shorter amount of time and see whether the previous benchmark can be exceeded.

- Commit to tackling the tasks as a team – even creating a team name, if desired. Doing the dishes together can transform it from a tedious chore to a chance to bump shoulders, dance, and laugh.

Powering through chores can be remarkably refreshing, and these couples may find that with the kitchen clean and their bills settled, they suddenly feel freer to live the lives they want.

Conclusion

Clear-Eyed Love

In Debaters' search for romantic connections, they are rarely swayed by superficial factors such as potential partners' attractiveness, social status, or wealth. Nor are they blinded by infatuation or beholden to convenience. Instead, they dive into love with their eyes open, willing to brave uncertainty in pursuit of a relationship's ultimate potential.

It's a common assumption that Thinking types, including Debaters, lack a romantic side, as they endeavor to take an analytical approach to relationships. But Debaters' capacity for love should not be underestimated. They don't end up in relationships by accident, though they may unfold more organically than would be expected of many Judging types. Rather, they choose partners whom they deeply respect, admire, and trust.

At times, they might struggle to express their feelings through conventional means. Fortunately, by learning what makes their significant others feel loved, they can communicate how much they care in targeted, effective ways – whether by listening actively, making romantic gestures, tackling chores, or trying new activities together.

To communicate their affection, Debaters might have to venture beyond their comfort zone, but they're more than up to the challenge.

The Head and the Heart

Going into romance with preconceived expectations may give the illusion of control, but alas, it's only an illusion. No matter how much Debaters might expect their partners to be just like them, the expectation is illogical (not to mention unhelpful). No two people are alike, and relationships are about delighting in differences, not imposing similarities.

Fortunately, whether they find themselves with other Analysts or completely different types, Debaters can use their open-mindedness and their incisive imaginations to better understand and embrace their lovers. When built upon a foundation of love and respect, their relationships flourish in beautiful ways. Through romantic partnerships, Debaters can explore new experiences; embrace diverse points of view; and foster mutual understanding, support, and esteem with the people they love.

Additional Tools and Tests

Want to dig even deeper into your romantic relationships? If you have access to the toolkits area of the website, we offer a variety of additional tools and tests to help you explore.

[Get to Know Your Partner](#)

Would you like to get to know your partner a little better? Try this simple, but very fun and effective, game.

Couple Analysis

A great tool for couples. Learn how your personalities are likely to interact, and how you can connect on an even deeper level.

Type Guesser (Romance)

Are you trying to figure out what personality type your partner belongs to? You may find that this simple tool helps.

Romantic Fulfillment Test

Grasp the roles that confidence and optimism play in your relationships, as well as what makes someone a good match for you.

Intertype Test

Do you have a partner? Do you want to understand your relationship better? Learn more about it with our easy Intertype Test.

Loyalty Test

With this test, you will find out how you build relationships and loyalty in four major areas: Romance, Work, Friendships, and Family.

Friendships



Energizing Engagement

Debaters seek friendships that offer mental engagement and the chance to share new experiences. They want intellectual friends who understand their creativity and keep up with them; they tend to become disenchanted by those who can't. Debaters do best with friends with whom they can explore ideas, bouncing them briskly – and sometimes competitively – back and forth like a game of mental basketball. People with this personality type are always thinking, searching, and contesting what is or might be, and they feel most comfortable with friends who can not only hold their own in conversation but also appreciate Debaters' mental gymnastics.

For those who can keep up, Debaters are a delightful and exciting presence, offering fantastic storytelling, vivid conversations, and spirited debates. Experiences are also crucial to this type, whether drinking wine on an Italian beach, hanging out with friends in the bright lights of a large city, or camping in the calming quiet of a forest. They want to hop around the world and bring their friends along with them.

However, the key to Debaters' social development is moving beyond sheer excitement and friendly intellectual sparring toward authentic connection.

Refreshingly Honest

Debaters enjoy spending time with people they respect. Some friends build each other up with ego-stroking, but Debaters unabashedly share their truths with little concern over any resulting emotional impact. Their blunt behavior is intended to be beneficial, though. They challenge their friends to improve and happily offer them constructive observations to help. In an age of gossip, false social veneers, and worship of appearances, Debaters' sharp honesty can be refreshing, if slightly abrasive – like a good scrub.

Although Extraverted, Debaters have no taste for social jockeying or emotional games. They prefer to argue and sway people, and they call out others' faulty facts and logic rather than use emotional manipulation. That can be a positive quality, for even though Debaters may not be the gentlest communicators, their sincerity earns them their friends' trust. By taking time to understand things on a factual level, people with this personality type often serve as logical mirrors for friends and as potent assets in times of trouble. Often seeming to be above the raging waters of emotion, Debaters can lift their friends out of such floods with intellectual and emotional clarity.

Habitual Line-Steppers

Debaters' sarcasm and humor aren't for those who struggle to read between the lines, nor for the faint of heart. Some consider societal norms to be strict rules, but Debaters consider them more as recommendations that they can take or leave. Even when it comes to explicitly stated rules and boundaries, Debaters may find

themselves crossing lines if they're inspired to do so. They take things that others deem taboo or incorrect and turn them around, making them interesting, thought-provoking, and worth further exploration.

Although that mindset is amazing when it comes to invention and creation, it has its pitfalls when applied to friendships. It's up to Debaters to act as their own moderators, ensuring that they hear their friends' voices with fair consideration – after all, more than opinions are at stake. Debaters' friendships are at their best when based on intellectual reciprocity, respect, and keen insight, and they'd be wise to put some effort into maintaining such relationships. If their goal is proving personal superiority, deep comradery is unlikely to flourish, as competitiveness and kindness are at odds. On the other hand, when the aims of friendship are to improve and learn, Debaters and their friends can focus on a supportive tone during their exchanges. Then they can create a road of mutual growth on which they can happily walk together for a long time.

Playing to Strengths and More

When discussing Debaters and friendship, the goal isn't to force them into being warm figures open to all emotions or to make them seek countless heart-to-heart encounters. That's just not who they are. Their strengths lie elsewhere.

Their skills involve appreciating rationality and using it to cut to the chase, and there's no reason to abandon that by favoring more emotional components of friendships. Debaters who want to grow their friendships need not change their essential selves. In fact, trying to deny their strengths is likely to backfire in the long run. Growth is about expanding one's comfort zone. When they add factors to balance out their sometimes less-than-diplomatic social impulses, Debaters can remain true to

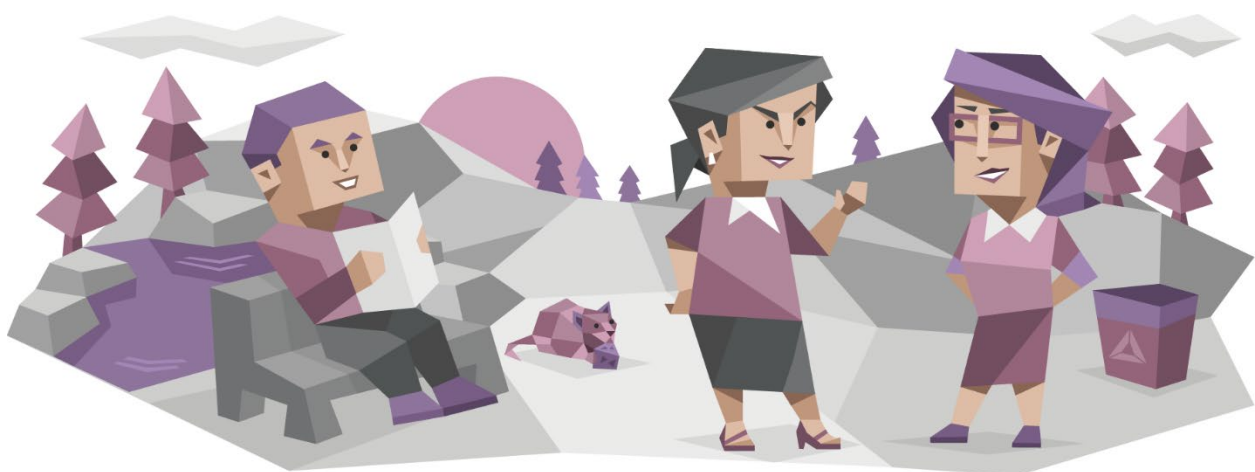
themselves while they grow as friends. The following sections will discuss multiple ways they can improve.

Debaters and Friends from Other Role Groups

Debaters tend to have inquiring natures, and their analytical yet adaptable minds help them relate to different people in different ways. Although some aspects of the Debater personality can be more help or hindrance when they make and maintain friendships with other personality types, with a little flexibility and patience, everyone has something to offer through any friendship.

We will now examine the tendencies that are most likely to affect Debaters when they are relating to friends in all four Role groups – other Analysts, Diplomats, Sentinels, and Explorers – and look at some ways of balancing their interplay to help create beneficial, fair, and fulfilling companionships.

Debater-Analyst Friendships



Debaters and other Analysts share the Intuitive and Thinking traits, lending to a kinship that mitigates whatever might otherwise hinder their friendships. Combining a preference for a rational approach plus a passion for big ideas can create a platform for potentially powerful camaraderie. Such attachment may feel like “home” to Debaters. However, having similarities is no guarantee of a seamless bond. Having friends who are too like themselves can narrow their focus and reduce opportunities for growth. Being too comfortable with only the familiar can obscure development – something that Debaters strive toward.

Balanced Debater–Analyst Friendships

Mutual Invigoration

In friendship, other Analysts are a quick fit for Debaters, sharing their passion for new ideas, knowledge, and unconventional thought. Such friendships are based on intellectual engagement more than social or emotional support, which is how Debaters like it. They may have grown accustomed to feeling frustrated or bored with the world’s conventional ways, so friendships with other Analysts are a breath of fresh air.

That fresh air comes in handy because these friends never run out of things to talk – or argue – about. Debaters’ minds are always buzzing with analyses, questions, and ideas, and few other types besides Analysts can keep up, much less hold up their own counterarguments. In balanced friendships, Debaters and Analysts love bouncing ideas back and forth, and their intellectual prowess enables them to dissect each other’s ideas piece by piece, an oddly enjoyable process. These friendships are characterized by pleasant competition, with a mutual challenge to establish stronger foundations for their thoughts.

Intellectual Partners in Crime

Discussions between Debaters and Analysts who take an open, fair-minded approach are unlikely to revolve around people, feelings, or social status. Instead, they gravitate toward esoteric topics, ideas, and plans, playing together in the theoretical realm. They also usually have compatible senses of humor, making hours of fun and laughter very likely as they improvise, joke, and comment on the world around them. Analyst friends let Debaters be themselves and pursue their interests with little or no inhibition – and perhaps enthusiastic support.

The two also support each other well when seeking answers to life's problems, bringing their greatest creativity together for the sake of mutual well-being. When Debaters and Analysts form healthy, balanced friendships, they can go far together.

Unbalanced Debater-Analyst Friendships*Talking Instead of Communicating*

Sharp minds don't always agree, and when Debaters and other Analysts differ on core issues, it can incite a war of words. Debaters' Prospecting trait helps them adapt to new information, but even these curious, discerning people may find themselves in dispute with Analyst friends in less-than-friendly ways. When taking an unbalanced approach to communication, Debaters adapt to their opponents' arguments in ways that allow them to constantly undermine the opposition while sidestepping their own flaws. But doing battle with statistics and philosophies can quickly turn from stimulating to frustrating.

The ensuing fallout can look different depending on their Analyst friends. If their Analyst chums have the Judging trait, Debaters' constant derailment of a topic can

frustrate them, or they'll find it irritating when Debaters take every sound idea and add superfluous "what ifs." Analyst friends with the Introversion trait may find that because they take their time to speak, Debaters leave them behind – either out of impatience or because they mistake their Introverted friends' deliberate thinking as an unwillingness to respond. Overeager Debaters sometimes turn a dialogue into a monologue.

Intellectually Bonded, Emotionally Isolated

Communication can be challenging on more than an intellectual level for Debaters with Analyst pals, as both tend to guard their emotions, and they're unlikely to open up to each other about personal matters. When emotionally charged situations do arise, whether tension within friendships or personal problems, Debaters don't crave or offer profuse apologies, pity, or hugs. In many cases, they appreciate a matter-of-fact exchange of ideas. But Debater-Analyst friends who have yet to decide to address their emotional isolation may wonder how to offer each other adequate support when it's needed – and even the most rational people do need it from time to time.

Debaters, and Analysts in general, are more likely than other types to objectify matters that need emotional intelligence rather than clever solutions. However, they are as vulnerable as anyone else to life events that assault the emotions. They are just as likely to need a friend in times of distress as anyone, and this dynamic, no matter how badly needed, may be absent in Debater-Analyst friendships.

Take, for example, a death in the family. People can examine and discuss death and create many models for grieving. However, all the explanations and solutions in the world won't lessen the pain or the difficult adjustments to a new normal. Mourners

must experience grief and pass through its stages. As friends, Debaters might attempt to explain suffering away, but sometimes only time and friendly support will do.

Rebalancing Debater-Analyst Friendships

Shifting to Greater Cooperation

When engaging with a friend, Debaters may ask themselves, “What can I learn from this person?” Debaters can approach interactions with Analysts (or anyone of a differing mindset) as learning opportunities instead of threats to their own settled perspective. If there’s one passion Debaters undeniably have, it’s their zeal for discovering new ideas and perspectives. They’re intrigued by people who shed new light on their assumptions and advance their thinking, which leads to easy companionship with other Analysts. Their open method means Debaters aren’t obliged to accept what doesn’t make sense to them. Instead, they can examine other Analysts’ points of view for useful nuggets of insight, respectfully coexisting with people whose opinions differ.

When it comes to disagreements, one excellent way for Debaters and their Analyst friends to evolve past conflict is shared experimentation. These friends can support each other’s attempts to bring ideas into reality and gain the resulting useful experience. Working with open minds, Debaters and Analysts can shelve arguments about “ideal solutions,” then discover the empirical evidence together. Debaters love to experiment and learn, and chasing data with friends may be doubly enjoyable, providing useful knowledge and building stronger bonds through cooperation.

One experiment Debaters can try with a friend they frequently disagree with: Play a game to help each other build an argument from a non-adversarial perspective:

- Choose any topic to explore with a friend.
- Strike the right attitude by deciding to expand on the topic without dissenting or taking a contrary stance. Just for this exercise, suspend disagreement. Think of it as the opposite of a debate.
- Start with a single proposition. It can be a serious topic or a light-hearted one. Some examples:
 - “Owning pets is a form of slavery and must be abolished.”
 - “Pineapple on pizza isn’t appropriate.”
 - “Artificial intelligence puts humans in danger.”
- Flip a coin to decide who is Player A and who is Player B.
- Set a timer for five minutes.
- Player A makes the first statement about the proposition. The first statement can be “pro” or “con” and should be no longer than a single sentence.
- Player B then responds by expanding Player A’s statement. To ensure this, their response must begin with, “Yes, and ...”
- Continue developing the original response until the timer runs out.

Although this game won’t test a proposition to its full extent, pushback is often a productive way to arrive at a substantive conclusion. Testing ideas against opposing ones can be a powerful means of arriving at truth. But a friendship can become exhausting if that’s all it’s about. Taking a breath and finding a cooperative tone can help friends remain positive, and it balances debate with a healthy sense of camaraderie.

The Role of Emotional Intelligence

Debaters and other Analysts might argue in favor of Descartes’ famous quote, “I think; therefore, I am,” but a common counterargument alleges that it’s severely

limiting to say that people are no more than their thoughts. Intellect is important, but strict rationality has its limits. When individuals recognize and nurture their emotional sides, they can fortify their friendships and understand themselves – and life itself – better. It's a mistake to construct a false dichotomy that claims a strict separation between rationality and emotions. The overlap is too great, and emotions contain their own logic and usefulness. Dismissing them can inhibit growth, both personally and within friendships.

To build higher emotional intelligence requires being in touch with one's own emotions and acknowledging and respecting the emotions of others. Friendship can strengthen both. It's a mistake to consider Debaters and other Analysts unfeeling. Although they are often less comfortable or less fluent in expressing emotion than other types are, they're no less capable. That said, learning to "speak the language," even within such an intellectual friendship, can add another dimension to their bond.

Here's a game they can play to raise emotional awareness.

Equipment:

- A dart
- A dartboard
- Post-It notes (or any other adhesive labels)

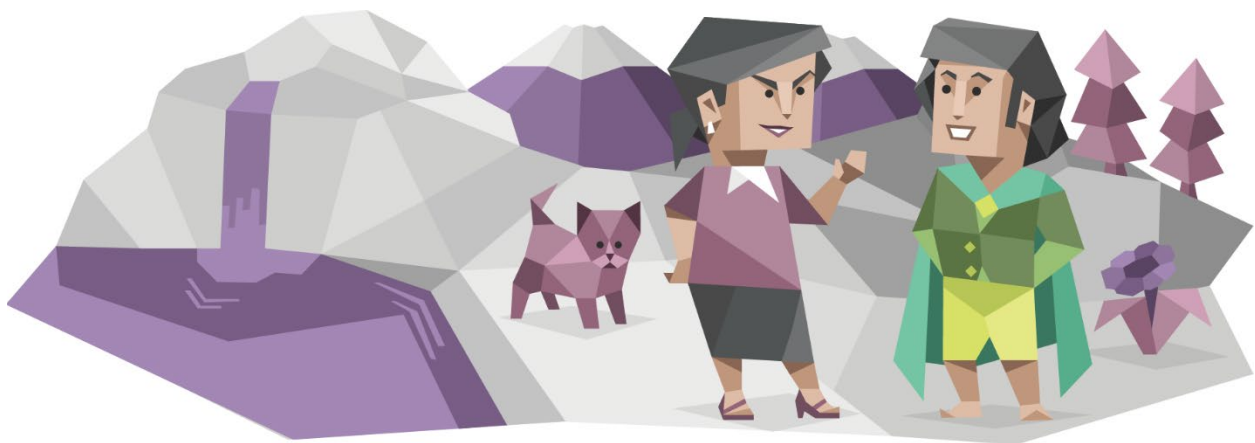
How to play:

- Arrange a list of "emotion" words on the board in any fashion. The words might include: hope, trust, fear, joy, surprise, disgust, anger, sadness, remorse, love, anticipation, frustration, or any number of others. (This is also a great chance to play with a nuanced vocabulary.)

- From an eight-foot distance from the board, about the regulation distance for an official game, throw the dart. (Throwing with your eyes closed, using adequate safety precautions, will increase randomness.)
- The player should tell a story or anecdote about a time they felt the emotion they hit with the dart, including what they did in response to it. Avoid judging or analyzing anything. The only goal is awareness through observation.

Emotional intelligence isn't static. People can cultivate and increase their empathy, mostly through awareness and a willingness to grow. This game can serve to raise awareness. Debater and Analyst friends can "up their game" by realizing there's more of value in life than endless intellectual discussion and debate, and their camaraderie can reflect that truth. Neither is in danger of losing their love for the rational – but they can still acknowledge that they do indeed *love* it.

Debater-Diplomat Friendships



The common threads in Debater-Diplomat friendships are their passion for ideas and their drive to imagine improved lives. Neither binds themselves to the world as it is, and both love to explore unrealized potential. They may have dissimilar concerns – Debaters cling to rationality, whereas Diplomats prefer compassion – but their

imaginative styles still offer plenty of commonalities, often more than enough to create companionship.

Balanced Debater-Diplomat Friendships

Imagination and Idealism

Debaters can find ways to take Diplomat idealism and bend it toward something they can implement, as well as coax their Diplomat friends out of their shells. Sharing the Intuitive trait, Debaters and Diplomats see beyond the superficial and enjoy ideations about a better world. The main difference between the two is that Diplomats view the world in terms of humanism and hopeful ideals, whereas Debaters, even though still focused on humans and what they're doing, are less interested in the emotional aspect of humanity and more interested in the optimization of it.

Debaters who choose to be accepting often find that Diplomats are full of fresh ideas, and to encounter a new perspective as insightful and creative as their own, yet very different, fascinates them. Debaters efficiently illuminate whatever might work best, and Diplomats add a humanistic dimension to bring people together for the greatest possible outcome. When these friends use their strengths in tandem, mixing rational ideas and high ideals, they become a mighty force for the common interest.

Learning Compassion

On a more personal level, Debaters who are open to developing life skills can exchange some truly significant qualities with their Diplomat friends. With their enthusiastic logic, Debaters can be a wonderfully contrasting influence in Diplomats' lives, offering reasoned thinking that helps them focus their passionate energy. From their Diplomat pals, Debaters can gain revelatory dimensions of emotional insight,

helping them explore the complex mysteries of human interactions – and themselves. These friends have the potential to lead each other to tremendous personal growth.

Efficiency without compassion is a lonely and hard thing. Compassion without rationality meanders from one unbridled feeling to another. Friends who complement each other in these areas are valuable companions, and there's much potential for camaraderie between Debaters and Diplomats.

Unbalanced Debater-Diplomat Friendships

Constant Tension

When choosing to be unaccepting (or, as happens to everyone, when being a bit thoughtless), Debaters think of strong emotional expression as extraneous – something to be dealt with rather than honored. Such a mindset can be confusing or even offensive to Diplomats, who consider emotion a vital part of living and connecting with others. Unfortunately, Debaters are unlikely to give their Diplomat friends the emotional support they need.

These differences affect unbalanced Debater-Diplomat friendships in very personal ways: Debaters have little desire to discuss their feelings, and Diplomats sense this with regret, leaving them wishing for closer friendships. On the other hand, Diplomats' freer emotions strike Debaters as unnecessary, immature, imprudent, or just a bother. Conflicting, unbalanced approaches to the human experience may cause Debaters to criticize their Diplomat friends and Diplomat friends to question Debaters' hearts.

Unintended Consequences

If riled, Debaters may do unintended damage. With an unbalanced approach, Debaters can disparage Diplomats' gentler view of the world with their typically unrestrained arguing. The resulting rift may penetrate deeply and become difficult to repair. Debaters may be thoughtless with their words, unaware of the impact their observations can have on Diplomats. Likewise, if Diplomats lash out at Debaters in a moment of pique, their rash words may be taken as enduring statements of fact, making Debaters resistant to later apologies. Both can be wounded, although in different ways.

Both can also take themselves too seriously. Debaters need to be free to express their thoughts. They don't necessarily want others to agree with their concepts – they gladly accept criticism (and often enjoy it!) from people they judge worthy to offer it – but they won't accept someone minimizing or questioning the quality of their efforts. Diplomats' underlying sense of moral virtue radiates like a halo behind their outlooks, which can give their criticisms the weight to challenge not only facts but the very morality of their Debater friends. If either disrespects what the other holds dear, it's likely to result in a grave injury to their friendships. Luckily, these friends can avoid most serious conflicts if they maintain a heightened perspective, which is easily within their abilities.

Rebalancing Debater-Diplomat Friendships

From Tension to Understanding

Understanding is the key to managing any tension that arises between Debater and Diplomat friends. Respecting each other's distinct styles is important, but before one can develop respect, it's necessary to know exactly *what* they should respect. For

Debaters, they can develop a healthy understanding of the humanistic and emotional aspects of life that their Diplomat friends care so much about. Until they do, their affection will remain superficial, and they will likely find it difficult to sustain what one calls “friendship.”

Debaters favor logical reasoning over emotional appeals; that being said, they can develop the ability to validate their friends’ humanistic strengths and see the value in gentleness. To do so, they must put themselves in situations that require emotional exposure and confront their own feelings. Debaters might consider volunteering to serve the disadvantaged (e.g., a soup kitchen) or mentoring children through standard tutoring or job shadowing. When they interact with more vulnerable individuals, they need to understand that emotions may play a part in fulfilling their role.

Here are some steps these friends can take toward emotional validation.

- Together, find a volunteer role that matches the descriptions above.
- Coordinate your schedules to ensure that you volunteer at the same time.
- Go about your duties.
- If faced with a difficult or emotionally confusing situation, ask for assistance from your Diplomat friend.
- Observe how your Diplomat friend responds to the situation.
- Ask yourself:
 - What are positive takeaways from your friend’s response?
 - How can you integrate these positive takeaways into your own response style?

There's a practical benefit to this exercise, as Debaters can use it to bolster their résumés. However, the best takeaway is that, in the end, they will learn to value the emotional insight that Diplomats can lend. Many situations deal with complex and raw emotions, which Debaters sometimes struggle to interpret. Once they come to understand the value of Diplomats' perspective, they can look to strengthen their friendships with them based on genuine admiration.

Grasping Alternate Perspectives

Debaters and Diplomats strive for similar results: to develop ideas about a better world and make them reality. Respecting such shared values may help these friends balance out their differing approaches and their consequent sensitivities.

Friendships are likely to flourish if Debaters and Diplomats each honor what the other brings to the table. Diplomats' warm care can be a balm to the intellectual – and, at times, self-destructive – conflicts in Debaters' lives, and the thoughtful insight and logic offered by Debaters may be a lifeline to Diplomat friends who struggle with indecision caused by their humanistic qualities. Most of all, the two can share an unending dance of inspiration, grasping different sides of an idea as they raise it to the heights of creativity together. To do this, Debaters can step into the shoes of their friends and try to understand the world from a different perspective. Here's an exercise that can help:

- Ask a Diplomat friend (or friends) to recommend a news story that interested them, then read or watch that story.
- Using what you know about Diplomats, step into their shoes for a moment and explore how they might respond to the story. How might a Diplomat react? What

would be their focus? What solutions might an Intuitive, Feeling individual come up with?

- Then ponder: How might a Debater react differently? How might a Debater influenced by a Diplomat respond?
- Consider: What would be a balanced response be (combining Thinking and Feeling reactions)?
- Then take the exercise outside of the theoretical and run your findings past your Diplomat friend.

If nothing else, this exercise can lead to fascinating conversations about both the news story and the reflections. The goal isn't to turn Debaters into Diplomats. Even if that were the goal, that sort of change isn't possible. But Debaters and Diplomats alike can enrich their lives and respond more effectively to their surroundings if they adopt some of each other's characteristics. After all, growth comes from expanding beyond one's comfort zone.

Debater-Sentinel Friendships



Debaters are likely to dive right into friendships with Sentinels, particularly those with the Thinking trait. Sentinels, however, may need to warm up to Debaters' exuberant and energized persona, which is why the two often take time to develop a rapport. Friendships between Debaters and Sentinels often emerge due to circumstance – they are coworkers, for example. When they first meet, they don't always understand what seem like obvious limits in the other's approach to life. However, Debater friends can expand Sentinels' thinking with their opportunistic tendencies, and Sentinel friends can anchor often-impulsive Debaters in the practical. Mutual appreciation of the gifts each brings to the table can produce long-lasting and satisfying friendship.

Balanced Debater-Sentinel Friendships

Inspirational Perspectives

Debaters may find that Sentinels complement them well as friends. Sentinels are often impressed by Debaters' insight, their compulsion to make everything work better, and their cleverness at imagining the broader mechanics of a solution. They might look to Sentinels for practical advice on a step-by-step path toward their grand ideas and, in turn, help Sentinels expand the scope of their thinking.

When Debaters and Sentinels befriend each other, it isn't some partnership organized around their different strengths. Friendships are more organic. But their personalities naturally influence all that they do, and friendship is no exception. A conversation between the two might find Debaters exploring ideas that are refreshingly novel to their Sentinel friends. Conversely, Sentinels can help Debaters enjoy reality in a casual, friendly way, with questions and propositions ranging from

“You know what would be interesting to do today?” to “The world would be a better place if ...”

Trading Mindsets

Debaters poke and prod by nature, and they will turn over every stone in the name of innovation. They're bound only by the rules of rational potential. For them, ideas become stale quickly, and their need for revision leaves their thinking in constant flux. They seek adventure and action. Meanwhile, Sentinels are happy to tend the hearth, metaphorically – they maintain order at home. Generally, Debaters can be considered “fierce activators,” whereas Sentinels are often “organized doers.”

Debaters might shake up Sentinels' settled thinking by questioning their traditional values and ideas. If Debaters are gentle and respectful enough in their challenges, and if they don't attempt to convert their friends to their latest ideas or opinions, it is a valuable exercise. Sentinels might even enjoy new perspectives on things they've taken for granted. Debaters also benefit from looking closely at those very perspectives, gaining insight into a grounded world. The purpose of friendships isn't for companions to transform each other. Nonetheless, it's common to say friends can be “good” for each other. This speaks to the growth potential available through exposure, and there are plenty of chances for such growth in Debater-Sentinel friendships.

Unbalanced Debater-Sentinel Friendships

Inconsiderate of Sensibilities

When Debaters and Sentinels decide they like each other, it doesn't mean they always *understand* each other – their foci can be very different. Debaters love to

discuss things with convoluted humor, to execute wild ideas and improbable schemes. Sentinels are likely to focus on more direct, substantial experiences, even when it comes to something as light and friendly as recreational pursuits. These friends may need to compromise when sharing casual time together – and they need to be willing to work hard to expand and stand together on any common ground that naturally exists between them so that they can keep things lively and engage in ways that are accessible to both.

This can make a difference on a typical night out. For example, when watching a movie for entertainment alone, Debaters may not take it at face value and focus more on pointing out inconsistencies. Although they may consider dissection of the film entertaining, their Sentinel friends may not agree, finding it annoying when Debaters pick apart a film that was never meant to be a think piece. When Debaters are reluctant to be respectful of Sentinels' sensibilities (in this case, a form of entertainment), it's likely to raise tensions and dampen any enthusiasm these friends have for each other. Insisting on one's own preferences or judging the preferences of others can create conflict in any kind of relationship, including friendship. There's enough difference between these two that overplaying one's own traits at the cost of the other's preferences can be damaging.

The Responsible Friend

Even though a friendship can be as casual as "hanging out," it's still a relationship, and relationships sometimes fall into roles. Because Debaters lag behind Sentinels in organizing and carrying out plans, Sentinels often dutifully assume the role of the "responsible" pal. It's fine if both accept and embrace the roles. However, any division of labor between them may look like Debaters have saddled their Sentinel friends with the mundane work. After all, securing a reservation at a popular restaurant

takes time and effort, and it can be frustrating when Debaters ignore the behind-the-scenes efforts that go into making such things possible. Debaters may imagine a “spontaneous” night out on the town, but Sentinels plan ahead by researching venues, considering budget, arranging transportation, and more. Feelings of inequity can unexpectedly seep into these friendships.

In their excitement ahead of a good time, Debaters can forget the groundwork needed. Sentinels don’t mind doing their part, and they often even insist on it. But nobody likes to do *all* the heavy lifting. Although Debaters are engaged and insightful types, they sometimes get carried away with what’s going to happen – but miss important details. Their focus simply remains on bigger ideas at the expense of more practical matters. But unless the difference is communicated effectively, it may look like an abdication of responsibility – especially to duty-sensitive Sentinels.

Rebalancing Debater–Sentinel Friendships

Respecting Sensibilities

When judgment harms the relationship between Debaters and Sentinels, repairing their bond may require acknowledging the boundaries between their shared and private lives. Each person has the right to live as they see fit and need only be concerned with compromise when they spend time together. What seems like a limited existence to Debaters may, in fact, bring great joy, prosperity, and personal growth to Sentinels, and what looks like idealistic chaos to Sentinels may be a life of satisfying accomplishment for Debaters. Arguing over who’s “right” is a fruitless endeavor when each may need different things to be happy.

Neither needs to accept the other person’s ways for themselves, but it’s important that they respect their friends’ preferences and avoid imposing their own choices

upon them. Conflicting styles only clash when they meet, and reasons for friction disappear when these friends take care to contribute positively to each other's lives. It's also important for them to quash any judgment with honest communication, before things get snide or heated. Expressing critical concern for each other is different from dispensing judgment; both should feel empowered to speak up when they feel that line has been crossed.

A simple exercise for Debaters and Sentinels to ease judgments over their differences is to overlay them with positive actions that recognize each other's virtues, even if they are dissimilar. Here are some helpful steps:

- Privately, write five to 10 beneficial things that the other friend brings to the relationship (e.g., great humor, willingness to drive, a sense of caring, fun ideas for activities, always reliable, keeps secrets between them, gives good advice, buys coffee, cooks great food, solves problems).
- Watch for instances of these positive acts, adjusting the list as needed.
- Show verbal appreciation for each instance.
- Mention the feelings created by each positive act; keep it brief and casual.

Debaters and Sentinels have some inescapable and marked core differences, but there's no reason they can't enjoy deep and happy friendship together where their interests overlap. Caring for each other gives them a reason to compromise and to respect their need to be themselves.

Mutual Responsibility

Rebalancing their different approaches to activities requires a little compromise and tolerance. Sentinel partners can learn to be more flexible when their Debater friends want them to join in an inspired idea, and Debaters can make sure Sentinels have a

say in how they engage in the activity together. Sometimes Sentinels just need a moment to get their heads around an idea before they proceed. If they're given that time, they may gladly follow their Debater friends into the fun.

Highly adaptable, Debaters can use their go-with-the-flow energy to give Sentinels leeway in planning out such activities together, including accepting some scheduling. Patience doesn't always come easily to Debaters, but they may have better results when they are easygoing instead of pushy. They can lead with ready energy and ideas – but respect the pace of their Sentinel friends. Below are some steps that can help enable workable compromises:

- Pitch a fun idea and inform your Sentinel friend that the experience must be “spontaneous.”
- Agree on a timetable that suits both.
- Communicate needs clearly and cheerfully.
- If suggesting a change to a plan, be respectful, and don't force the issue.
- Try and adapt to each other's needs when spending time together.

Both can take a step into each other's timeframes now and then – they each have a good approach for certain things. When it comes to having fun, Sentinels may find unexpected relief when they let go of rigid control, and Debaters can appreciate the benefits of staying on schedule when it comes to important matters.

Debater-Explorer Friendships



Although Debaters and Explorers can be dissimilar, those who become friends share a similar energy based on spontaneity. One entertains borderline-obsessive ideas springing from theories, whereas the other pursues a succession of novel experiences. The Prospecting trait provides the energy for both, influencing them to constantly change direction or find new facets of their existing interests to explore. Understanding and harnessing these tendencies can provide common ground for lasting friendship as the spontaneous thinker joins forces with the spontaneous actor.

Balanced Debater-Explorer Friendships

Spontaneous Collaborators

Debater-Explorer friendships have much potential, especially if the two share common interests. Debaters often struggle to let go of their intellectual poking and can sometimes be overwhelmed by all the things they cannot do. When this happens, they can look to their Explorer friends to help them let it go so they can follow their hearts (and Prospecting tendencies) with unworried enthusiasm. As Debaters are

pulled into the fray, they can add their trademark “What if we try...” attitude to the mix, expanding their Explorer friends’ options even further.

This is the real beauty of Debater–Explorer friendships: Debaters have so many ideas about what’s possible, and spontaneous Explorers can prompt them to act without becoming mired in theory or hamstrung by the scope of their vision and ambitions. Explorers are masters of “one step at a time.” If these friends share a common hobby or field of interest, even better. They can collaborate with their unique contributions and share endless fun.

Beyond Obvious Usefulness

Differing types can encourage personal growth for their friends. This goes beyond just being useful and balancing each other in obvious ways. Explorers typically hate theory – yet there’s value in ideas. Debaters don’t always think about fulfilling their ideas to completion. However, bonds between Debaters and Explorers can involve influencing each other and nudging by example.

When both go along for the friendship ride, they pick up subtle changes to their own styles that reflect those of their friends. Rather than overt utilitarian compromise leading to distinct actions, sometimes the gifts of their relationships are their contributions to their companions’ growth. Some speakers in the self-help field claim that individuals are composites of the five individuals with whom they spend the most time. The number is subject to debate, but it’s hard to deny that the prominent people in one’s life can be a significant influence. Debaters aren’t likely to change Explorers into members of their own type or the other way around – nor should anyone try. However, an almost subliminal influence can be part of personal growth.

Unbalanced Debater-Explorer Friendships

Differing Levels of Engagement

Debaters may see Explorers' tendency to live in the present and follow their compulsions as shortsighted, and they may disapprove of Explorers' decision-making in general. Even though Explorers might entertain the riskiest adventures, their forward-thinking imaginations usually forestall disaster. Debaters rely on a great deal more discussion ahead of their actions, though more for fun than need. But a steady stream of talk can wear down Explorers, who are more intent on getting their hands dirty right away.

With shared activities, Debaters can become baffled and concerned when Explorer friends get caught up in the drama or pleasure of the moment, taking no time for critical reflection. However, they'll likely find no rational explanation from Explorers, who simply move on to the next thing before the dust settles. If Debaters spend too much time thinking without jumping in, Explorers may just leave them in the dust. A lack of foundation for communication can lead these pals to become out of sync with each other.

Misinterpreted Humor

Debaters value seeing "above" things; therefore, they tend to have a sense of wit and humor where boundaries are made for breaking. Rather than serious-minded pontification, Debaters more often make light of the "little" things that Explorers take seriously. For instance, if an Explorer spends a lot of time tinkering with their car, they won't have much patience for Debater friends joking about the expense and inefficiency of such a hobby, nor wry comments about the pollution that cars cause.

Because Explorers take things at immediate face value, any jokes that belittle their passion can endanger a friendship. Debaters, gregarious though they are, may find that their humor proves to be a double-edged sword.

Rebalancing Debater–Explorer Friendships

Knowing When to Be Permissive

In their desire for progress, Debaters often try to impact as many people as possible, but even the most social of Explorers tend to focus on satisfying their own goals, even while they enjoy the company of other people and care for their friends. Neither should be made to feel judged for this difference. It's important for Debaters to realize that not everyone shares their boundless ideation, and the difference is acceptable. Although Debaters can always invite Explorer friends into their broader efforts toward their ideals, it's not fair to make it seem obligatory. Debaters can use their great ability for forward thinking to see when Explorer friends simply don't share their interests, then decide to let them off the hook.

In turn, Explorers can tap into their famous curiosity and try something new, even if it doesn't initially seem very interesting. "Why would I bother doing that?" is a common question; the answer comes from the realization that good friends are worth extra effort – and that together anything can be fun. Explorers often have great success once they set their sights on something, and they can tune in to Debaters' enthusiasm and pitch in with their company. Such efforts are very meaningful to Debaters and affirm these friendships.

Allowing each other their own directions in life, especially when it comes to perceived societal obligations versus personal priorities, is a necessary and fair manifestation of respect in these alliances. Ultimately, how they feel when they spend time together

is more important than doing everything together, so independence is sometimes the best option. To help preserve balance, both Debaters and Explorers can use these tips:

- Invite each other into personal priorities with enthusiasm. Highlight the possible fun and benefits for each other: “We could” instead of “You should.”
- Try and be open-minded about joining in things your friends care about.
- Give things a fair shot at least once before dismissing them as boring or irrelevant.
- When either person declines to do something, be understanding – no need to ask for a reason, but perhaps inquire, “Is there anything I could do to help?”
- Give each other space and freedom to pursue personal priorities without judgment – different strokes for different folks.

These two often become friends thanks to areas of overlap and commonality, and trying to drag each other too far out of that zone can be disrespectful. Instead, they can better spend their energy in areas of common interest, reveling in what can be happily shared together as often as possible.

Explaining the Joke

Debaters have a unique sense of humor that may not resonate with everyone. They can find humor in everything – themselves, their failures, and even difficult and traditionally taboo subjects. Because of this, some people may mistake their attempts at light-hearted poking for ill intentions. Explorers, who find value in things immediately in front of them, can feel hurt should they believe that Debaters are mocking the activities or ideas they care so much about. However, Debaters, with

their quick-acting wit and intuition, can quickly spot a shift in Explorer friends' attitudes or demeanor. If Explorers express their hurt, Debaters can do the following:

- Make a joke about yourself. This shows your Explorer friend that any teasing isn't specific to them – but aimed at everything.
- Explain what you really meant by the joke. This can be along the lines of, “I didn't mean anything by it. I just thought it would be funny to say.”
- Reassure your Explorer friend that you respect their passions and ideas, even if you don't personally like or adopt them.

Debaters and Explorers aren't the same people. Each has their own ideas and preferences, which both highly respect, though they may express their respect and passion in different ways. That is why it's important for Debaters to communicate how they express themselves – often through benignly intended humor.

Conclusion

Social Activators

We've discussed some pitfalls Debaters may face in friendships, but in truth, this personality type is incredibly adept at creating and maintaining social relationships by choice. They can find something to appreciate in any type, valuing people as individuals and reflexively extending enthusiasm and excitement. When Debaters meet worthy people and invest in deeper friendships, their bright, active imaginations; outgoing nature; and uninhibited inclinations give them substantial charm, which they share freely and honestly.

Given their highly adaptable and innovative social abilities, Debaters face difficulties in friendships that are partly their own creation. Like all Intuitive types, they may

become so blinded by their own expansive visions that they lose touch with basic, everyday factors, including other people's perfectly natural limits and differences. Debaters are so good at sharing their energy with others that when someone isn't so easily caught up or influenced, they may view it as a failure – or as a signal that the individual needs a remedy for who they inherently are.

When Debaters grow enough to accept other people for the unique qualities they bring to friendships, they themselves spend less time contradicting and more time having fun with people – and learning from them. When they project the underlying tone of fun and excitement that comes so naturally to them, they can enjoy the company of anyone: Dreamy idealists, reserved traditionalists, and self-assured gadabouts are all equally charmed. Truly, Debaters have the potential to create fulfilling social relationships in their lives, if that's what they choose.

Additional Tools and Tests

Want to dig even deeper into your friendships? If you have access to the toolkits area of the website, we offer a variety of additional tools and tests to help you explore.

Type Guesser (Friendships)

Are you trying to figure out what personality type your friend belongs to? You may find that this simple tool helps.

Personal Authenticity Test

Can you be your true self with your friends and family? Let's explore how you feel about your authenticity in those circumstances.

Parenthood



Enjoying a Challenge

There are few things in life more challenging than raising children to be productive, positive members of society, and people with the Debater personality type love a good challenge. They enjoy fixing problems – even their own personal weaknesses – and taking charge of another person’s life can reveal weaknesses quickly. Debaters who understand the importance of their influence take the role of parent seriously, and they’re often profoundly affected by this aspect of their lives.

People with this personality type enjoy the personal challenges of parenthood. They often believe that the best way to promote their kids’ growth is through intellectual challenges of their own, so they tend to eagerly provide their children with learning opportunities in hopes of sparking their thoughts, ideas, and beliefs. By presenting challenges in loving and informative ways, Debater parents can help their sons and daughters become better informed and encourage them to seek knowledge – even if it’s to prove a point to their parents.

Promoting Independence

Debaters' preference for avoiding rules and regulations is evident, and they give their children the freedom to explore on their own. Independence is one of their greatest needs, and they believe that no one is complete without an independent mind. At their best, these parents create relaxed, unorthodox environments for their children, founded on enthusiasm and the joy of discovery through the development of reason – not heavily structured settings designed to be safe.

They encourage their children to think independently and voice objections, opinions, and alternatives. Debaters teach their kids to approach everything from a position of impartiality, to distinguish what is efficient and reasonable from what feels good, and to argue their position fairly and effectively. Even if emotional intelligence isn't their strong suit, Debaters who realize the importance of a healthy emotional understanding in their decision-making process encourage their children to do the same. They recognize that honest discussion comes from understanding.

Strained Emotional Intelligence

As their children grow and work to balance healthy emotional expression with logic, Debater parents who don't take the time to incorporate emotional understanding into their own repertoire may find themselves exasperated. Although they are always up for a debate on almost any subject, they may need help to manage their children's outbursts of feeling. Although they're more permissive than most, even Debaters have their limits and rules when it comes to vocal conflict.

Criticism is one area where Debaters' insensitivity becomes apparent. As parents, they're prone to impatience when their children don't pick up on seemingly obvious ideas or concepts. They may overestimate their kids' abilities and level of

understanding and become frustrated when their children don't meet their sometimes-unrealistic expectations. Such criticism can be especially hurtful to children who are sensitive to harsh words. If they don't reign in their tendency for critical commentary, Debaters may struggle with developing close emotional bonds with their children.

Building Emotional Intelligence

Debaters want their children to grow up to be smart, independent, and open-minded. But if they want them to be well-adjusted, too, they must try to provide emotional support, even if it means learning entirely new skills. Though Debaters may struggle to teach empathy alongside rationality, doing so will help their children grow into confident adults who ask questions, think constructively, and take care of themselves no matter what comes their way.

To build their emotional intelligence, Debaters need to take inventory of their strengths and weaknesses, then balance them effectively. In terms of parenting, they benefit from practicing empathy, gaining perspective on their own emotional behavior, and controlling unhelpful impulses. Debater parents, specifically, often need to learn to curb their impulsive criticism when their children don't meet their expectations.

One of the most important things parents can do is take time to realize and accept how their emotions influence their children. By focusing on understanding their kids in a developmentally appropriate way, and by making patience and kindness goals in all interactions with them, Debaters make the best of their role as parents.

Parenting for Each Stage of Development

Each of the stages of children's growth presents unique challenges and exciting milestones. Learning how to navigate the stages can seem daunting, but the opportunity to build healthy attachment and create meaningful memories makes it worth the struggle.

Renowned psychologist Erik Erikson proposed a theory of psychosocial development that identified eight stages, five of which take place between birth and 18 years of age. Keep in mind that the ages listed for each stage are approximate. It's normal for children develop at their own pace and meet each milestone in their own time, sometimes even skipping stages, achieving them in an unexpected order, or trying one milestone and falling back to an old one – especially common with walking. (When it comes to questions about delayed developmental stages, we recommend consulting a pediatrician.)

The following paragraphs discuss what to expect at each stage of development, as well as how the strengths and weaknesses of the Debater personality type affect parenting at each stage.

Building Bonds (Birth–1½ Years)

According to Erikson, the stages of infancy and early childhood last from birth until approximately 3 years of age. Children in these stages are very dependent on their parents. This is when parents can create the bonds of attachment by meeting their children's needs, developing trusting relationships, and eventually promoting autonomy.

The priority for infants on their journey to attachment is having their basic needs met. This is a sensitive time in a parental relationship: From being fed to receiving affection, infants need to learn to trust that their Debater parents can provide for them. If their basic needs are not met, it can lead to a sense of mistrust in all their subsequent relationships.

When parents are inconsistent in providing for their children, their infants may have difficulty creating positive, trusting attachments. On the other hand, attentive and affectionate parents, especially those who engage in consistent physical contact, such as snuggling or baby wearing, encourage trusting, hopeful relationships that help their children to build positive attachments with others.

Balanced Parenting During Infancy

Intrigued and Inspired

The awe and beauty of bringing new life into the world aren't lost on Debaters, and the birth of their own children is often profoundly interesting to this generally intellectual type. Much like their desire to debate the mysteries of the cosmos and other such lofty concepts, these parents look upon their infants as enigmas wrapped inside onesies. With limitless potential and possibilities, they're thrilling and inspirational little humans.

Intrigued and inspired, Debaters who take the opportunity to appreciate this stage for the fresh start that it is are likely to be rewarded. Figuring out what makes their babies tick is like a scientific endeavor for parents with this personality type. They gather information and conduct experiments as they observe their infants during this stage of rapid growth and development. Involved Debaters find that they have

front-row seats to one of the most fascinating case studies: the transformation of a gurgling, cooing, helpless baby into a walking, talking, functioning person.

The “Anti-Helicopter” Parent

Many parents find themselves hovering over their newborns, fretting over every gurgle, cough, and cry, but Debaters can be remarkably relaxed when it comes to parenting. This isn't due to a lack of concern: Confident Debaters who have prepared for their parental roles see no rational reason to get worked up over every little thing. Taking care of their babies to the best of their abilities is their priority; worrying about everything that could go wrong only gets in the way of that goal.

Avoiding excessive worry is only one part of their laid-back approach to parenting during infancy, however. Their strong live-and-let-live mentality means that parents with this personality type, at their best, interact with their children without feeling a need to control them. During this stage, they revel in engaging with their babies through caretaking activities like feeding and bath time, as well as through play. They're less likely than others to feel as though they must attend parent-baby yoga sessions or schedule play dates for their non-verbal, not-yet-crawling infants to “properly socialize” them. Promoting their children's development is good, but Debaters are unlikely to obsess over it.

Unbalanced Parenting During Infancy

My Kid Is Smarter Than Yours!

It certainly is exciting to see a baby roll over for the first time, sit up on their own, or expertly stack their periodic table element blocks, but trying to push children to achieve milestones early usually only causes frustration. Just because an infant isn't

saying their first words at the same time as another baby doesn't mean they aren't as intelligent. Development, especially at this stage, isn't a measure of parents' or newborns' intelligence. Debater parents and their infants tend to be much happier and more relaxed if their sons and daughters can grow and develop at their own pace.

Having kids who appear to be advanced or exceptionally intelligent is certainly a confidence boost for parents of all personality types. However, parents who focus on achieving milestones over building bonds (which, paradoxically, have more of an impact on children's achievement than educational activities) can be detrimental to their infants' overall development and their parent-child relationships. Babies who trust that their Debater parents will meet their needs can comfortably focus on gaining the new skills that naturally develop from their interactions with loving, attentive caregivers.

Rebalancing Parenting During Infancy

Focusing on Support Over Achievement

At this stage, Debaters should understand that developmental milestones are approximate, and they're meant for evaluation and not comparison. Children who attain certain milestones earlier aren't always "advanced," those who achieve them later aren't necessarily "delayed," and labeling children in such ways can be detrimental to their development and their self-esteem throughout their lives. The expectations that come with labels easily influence people's behavior, often in negative ways. There's absolutely nothing wrong with having high expectations of children, if parents temper expectations with understanding, acceptance, and patience.

Children of all ages, including infants, need unconditional love and acceptance from their parents. Debater parents should turn their attention away from achievement and toward support of their infants' growth at their own pace. At this stage, support consists of meeting their sons and daughters where they are developmentally and providing regular and consistent encouragement. Infants who receive this type of unconditional love and support learn to trust their parents, and they are likely to have greater success developing healthy, trusting relationships with others in the future as well.

The following are ways Debaters can organically encourage their infants while still accepting their current limitations. The activities should be done with as much physical contact as possible: for example, holding their children while reading or playing with interactive toys rather than just setting them down to play on their own:

- Use items that encourage interaction (with the toy *and* the parent) rather than just providing passive entertainment. Try blocks, rattles, puzzles, and age-appropriate musical instruments (like a plastic toy drum.)
- Talk to infants frequently – explain how food is being prepared, talk about the weather outside, or describe what is happening with a toy they're playing with. Conversations, whether infants understand what is being said or not, promote language development and create a special bond between parents and children by increasing engagement.
- Read to babies at every opportunity. It's one of the easiest and most meaningful ways to interact, while also encouraging language development and promoting visual stimulation.

Encouragement and acceptance aren't mutually exclusive – it's possible to promote their infants' growth while still accepting (completely normal) limitations. However,

in such instances where parents should be concerned about their children's development (or lack thereof), they should have conversations with their family physicians or pediatricians to identify issues and develop plans to address them.

Testing Boundaries (1½–3 Years)

Once they're mobile, young children become very interested in exploring their environments with their senses. Crawling, walking, grabbing items, putting things in their mouths, and communicating verbally are just a few of the ways toddlers learn about the world around them.

During this stage, Debater parents must provide a safe harbor for their children while still allowing them to experience and explore their surroundings. Toddlers who can test boundaries while still receiving parental support and encouragement develop a sense of autonomy. Children who are overly restricted, criticized, or made to feel guilty for their desire to test boundaries ultimately will experience a sense of shame and may suffer from feelings of incompetence or low self-worth. Such feelings can last throughout their lives and may ultimately jeopardize their ability to achieve goals and develop positive character traits such as decisiveness, reliability, and confidence.

Balanced Parenting During the Toddler Stage

Eagerly Encouraging Learning

Learning is a priority for Debaters, so they're always encouraging their children to engage in educational activities. The exploration stage is an exciting one for parents and children alike, as they witness meaningful milestones such as talking, walking, and learning how to use and manipulate toys, tools, and utensils. Debater parents

provide their daughters and sons with plenty of stimulation and opportunities for exploration.

From reading science-fiction bedtime stories to outfitting the nursery with a planetarium night light, conscientious Debaters are likely to incorporate learning into everything they do with their children. Such experiences not only increase their toddlers' knowledge, they create deeper parent-child bonds. Additionally, the more positive experiences that kids have learning with their parents, the more likely they are to seek out educational experiences in the future. Debaters who invest their time encouraging growth and learning with their toddlers are laying the foundation for them to feel safe and confident in their educational (and life) endeavors.

Curious and Questioning

Debaters are one of the most curious personality types – they're just as interested in exploring and questioning the world around them as their children are. These parents have no problem understanding their kids' desire to test boundaries. This shared eagerness to explore can provide incredible opportunities for bonding both intellectually and emotionally.

Many parents feel frustrated by the endless questions and outspoken opinions of toddlers. Less so for Debaters, who likely feel a tinge of pride when their children show their desire to learn more. Although they certainly expect their sons and daughters to respect their authority, Debaters are more than willing to entertain questions or challenges if they deem them legitimate. And toddlers who believe that their parents can always provide them with a safe harbor from which to question and explore are more likely to develop a healthy sense of autonomy – something Debater parents proudly encourage and support.

Unbalanced Parenting During the Toddler Stage

Impatient with Irrationality

Debaters understand that toddlers have limited cognitive abilities because of their developmental stage, but that doesn't always prevent them from becoming impatient with the toddler brand of "reasoning." Irrational arguments are a pet peeve for people with this personality type, and toddlers are masters of that form. Some personality types can overlook the inanity of children at this age, but Debater parents may be more susceptible to frustration, which can quickly devolve to criticism or even anger, guaranteeing that the situation will escalate rather than improve.

Toddlers are notorious for lying and arguing about ridiculous things. Three-year-olds may yell at their parents, insisting they aren't pouring their cereal on the floor even as they're in the process of doing just that. Even though this may be a sincere act of exploration ("Maybe the dog is hungry – I'll feed him some of my cereal!"), Debaters may see it as frustratingly illogical or irrational. If they choose to deal with misbehavior in a critical way rather than using it as an educational opportunity ("Time to learn how to use a broom!"), their children are likely to become frustrated, withdrawn, resentful, and even more likely to misbehave.

Rebalancing Parenting During the Toddler Stage

Consider the Context

To be fair, rarely, if ever, do toddlers misbehave out of malice or conscious disrespect for their parents. At this stage, arguments and lies are generally results of their desire to be understood, a failure to realize the significance of their actions, or simply an effort to avoid getting in trouble. With their limited ability to communicate their

thoughts and feelings, children at this age act out in ways that defy logic. If Debaters fail to see such behavior in the context of development and let their irritation get the best of them, they may resort to punishment over more constructive and educational disciplinary practices.

Improving their patience is key for Debaters who are looking to address their toddlers' behavior in positive and productive ways – but this is certainly easier said than done. Patience improves when parents can adapt to their children's evolving needs, abilities, and, yes, even their ever-changing attitudes. Developing a mindful presence can help frustrated Debaters to refrain from reacting negatively any time their kids' behavior becomes challenging.

The following activity can help Debater parents to press “pause” and reassess a situation before a downward spiral begins:

- Stop and breathe. Whatever is taking place – whether a toddler temper tantrum or a potty-training setback – take a step back from the situation (when safe and appropriate) and take five deep breaths.
- Take a moment to remember that children at this stage aren't behaving negatively out of spite or as a personal attack.
- Consider things from their point of view. Perhaps they're sleepy, hungry, overwhelmed, misunderstood, or just plain frustrated themselves.
- Think about what can be done to turn the situation into a “win” for everyone. Maybe Junior could use a nap, which would also give parents some quiet time. Perhaps they could have a nice snack together.

The goal of this activity is to remain present and focus on the best outcome for both parties involved while keeping toddlers' intellectual, emotional, and behavioral

capabilities in mind. Debaters understand what it feels like to be misunderstood. Learning to put their children's behavior in context provides the understanding needed by themselves and their children.

Thirst for Knowledge (3–5 Years)

The preschool years, from approximately 3–5 years of age, are a prime time for brain development, and children at this stage accumulate knowledge at an extraordinary rate. They absorb information like sponges through constant activity and a seemingly infinite stream of disparate questions. Learning at this stage takes place through play, especially the unstructured and imaginary kind, as well as lots of social interaction with family and peers. Creativity is also exercised extensively through make-believe games and stories.

Preschoolers who lack opportunities to practice initiating activities and get annoyed reactions to their constant questions or childish make-believe games may feel guilty, frustrated, and powerless. Consequently, they may suffer from poor self-control or a lack of initiative. Debater parents who wish to navigate this stage successfully must give their daughters and sons the opportunity to make some of their own decisions, initiate activities, ask questions, receive answers, and lead others in exploratory play. Preschoolers who are encouraged to take initiative are likely to be more confident in their actions – and much more likely to independently pursue their own goals in the future as well.

Balanced Parenting During the Preschool Years

Competent Mentors

Debaters are known as enthusiastic, quick-witted, confident, and original individuals who excel at solving problems, and they often model such behaviors for their children. They're likely to encourage their kids to initiate and engage in imaginative play and practice creative problem-solving through activities like board games and puzzles. As stated in the previous section (and it's very important, so it bears repeating), Debater parents encourage learning and often gladly answer their children's incessant streams of questions. In fact, they take great pleasure from explaining concepts, especially complicated ones, and they enjoy their role as informers.

Although educational activities are important to Debater parents, they value many topics. They aim to instill into their children curiosity, independent thinking, and an ability to look at the world objectively – qualities that are just as important as any set of skills. With the same energy they use for brainstorming points and counterpoints for their next conversation, Debaters can encourage their preschoolers to see learning opportunities everywhere, to value chances to experience or create something.

A simple walk around the neighborhood, for instance, can be an impromptu lesson on the basic physics behind a falling acorn and the geological make-up of interesting rocks. Trips to the grocery store are perfect opportunities to practice counting money and making healthy food choices. Debaters enjoy prompting their preschoolers to question and consider everything – for better or worse! – and they instill a deep curiosity and a love of learning from a very early age.

Independence as Empowerment

Debaters don't care what anybody thinks of them, a perspective they encourage in their children as well. For them, dependency is discouraged; Debater parents work to pass on the skills their sons and daughters need to be independent, confident individuals. Knowledge is power – which is exactly what Debaters want their children to have and project. The more they can teach their kids, whether facts or age-appropriate skills, the more they feel they've prepared them to succeed.

In the preschool stage, they encourage their little ones to develop their own critical thinking skills. For example, these parents might expect their kids to use their problem-solving skills to deal with any difficult children they encounter. They're unlikely to pander to their preschoolers' desire for them to interject themselves and solve any issues they may encounter. Instead, Debaters are likely to work with them to figure out age-appropriate solutions to their problems.

Unbalanced Parenting During the Preschool Years

Believing Tact and Compassion Are Unnecessary

Some of the behaviors Debaters model aren't always positive or productive. Objectivity is more important to them than empathy, so some Debaters may find it unnecessary to teach their children how to communicate with compassion or tact. Parents with this personality type are often more interested in seeing their kids pursue ambitious goals than in helping them to develop positive relationships with others. Grappling with life's mysteries, which at this stage may entail learning to use scissors and mastering the ABCs, may take precedence over social niceties.

In fact, social niceties may not even register on the radar of less-than-sensitive Debaters. Biting criticism is often a hallmark of this personality type, especially during “passionate discussions” – typically arguments in all but name. When frustrated or annoyed by their little ones’ antics, Debaters can be especially cruel in their commentary. Negative criticism can be damaging to children at this stage, who are especially sensitive to it. Frequent, harsh confrontations may provoke feelings of guilt that are difficult to overcome. Calling their questions “dumb” or their ideas or concerns “illogical” can be crushing to preschoolers during this phase. Without the context or clarification to understand such comments, children can feel unimportant or inconvenient to their parents, which sets them up for future resentment.

Rebalancing Parenting During the Preschool Years

Increasing Compassion and Understanding

For Debater parents to promote their children’s initiative and self-confidence, as well as to teach them healthy social skills, they need to practice being compassionate and understanding themselves. Being critical is especially damaging to children who, at this stage, are just beginning to develop confidence in their abilities and the initiative necessary to pursue further learning of their own accord.

To prevent the guilt and withdrawal that may evolve when kids constantly feel as though they’re wrong or unimportant, Debater parents need to reassess how they’re communicating with their preschoolers. Are they modeling compassionate communication? Are they patient during stressful conversations, or do they quickly become critical? Do they promote empathetic behavior, such as concern when someone is sad, angry, or hurt? Or do they tend to avoid other people when they’re

expressing emotions? If Debaters find that they aren't communicating in a way that models compassion or understanding, they can try the following activity:

- Identify a situation that triggers an angry or critical response – perhaps your preschooler throwing toys instead of picking them up.
- Consider the “default,” normal response. Yelling? Threatening to take away (or throw away) toys that aren't picked up? Possibly sending the child to time-out? Maybe telling the preschooler they're lazy, disrespectful, or naughty?
- Consider – maybe through discussion with a friend or partner – why the situation elicits an angry or critical response. Is it a question of respect? Do you fear that your child doesn't like you (because otherwise they would surely listen)? Do you worry that the child is just plain “bad?”
- Instead of taking the preschooler's behavior personally, look for ways to respond to the situation with understanding. They may not want to pick up their toys because they're having too much fun, or they may be tired.
- Respond in a way that addresses the behavior with compassion rather than frustration, such as, “I know you're tired, but we need to pick up the toys before you lie down. Here, let me help you.” Or, “I know that you're having fun, but we must go to the grocery store, so we need to pick the toys up now. Don't worry, you can play with them again when we get home!”

Understanding is the root of compassion, so when Debater parents take the time to figure out how their perception might differ from their preschoolers' intention, they gain opportunities to connect with their children in intentional, meaningful ways.

Creating Competence (5–12 Years)

The early school years are an important period of skill development for young children. Not only are they still constantly absorbing new information, but they're also working on becoming proficient in increasingly complex areas, from relationships to mathematics to athletics. Children who are both challenged and supported flourish in their abilities and their self-confidence.

If they don't receive consistent support, kids at this stage can begin to feel inferior to their peers and may be less likely to develop long-term goals or work toward achieving them. On the other hand, children at this stage who aren't sufficiently challenged can begin to feel overly confident in themselves and their abilities, perhaps eventually lacking modesty and compassion toward others.

Balanced Parenting in the School-Age Years

Encouraging Deep Learning

Challenging others is one of Debaters' greatest strengths. They have no trouble challenging their daughters and sons to improve themselves as well, helping them set and achieve increasingly ambitious goals – though those goals may not always take expected forms. Taking bold, positive risks is of utmost importance to Debaters, and they take every opportunity to promote their children's desire to increase their knowledge and skills. Are their kids passionate about dinosaurs? Debater parents are likely to provide books, educational videos, and museum trips galore.

Not ones to settle for merely "learning about something," Debater parents place a great deal of importance on actively exploring and deeply understanding their children's passions. The enthusiasm they have for ideas and passion projects often

inspires their kids to learn more about whatever they pursue, especially in areas related to their intellectual development. Although they prize intelligence, Debaters are no strangers to hard work, and they encourage children of all levels and abilities to achieve their personal best.

Setting Up for Success

Children at this stage are learning to set and achieve goals, and Debater parents can be excellent models of the brainstorming ability and determination needed to reach goals. School-aged kids face increasing expectations in terms of attaining skills and knowledge, and they benefit from parents who can teach them how to strategically meet expectations. Debaters find great joy in helping their children to brainstorm plans and figure out what they must do to achieve their goals – academically, socially, and personally.

Developing long-term goals is a challenge for children who are only just learning to effectively engage in future planning. The skill becomes increasingly necessary during the school-age years, and Debater parents can draw on their own goal-setting experiences to help their children successfully navigate this stage. They can use their skills to help their young scholars approach projects (“OK, you want to make a solar-powered toilet for the science fair? Let’s figure out what you need so that you can make the best toilet possible.”)

Unbalanced Parenting in the School-Age Years

Excessive Ambition

Ambition is an impressive trait, but when it becomes a cornerstone of their identity, Debaters may find themselves unintentionally eroding their children’s confidence

with criticism. Kids at this stage are just being introduced to topics, not taking a deep dive into theoretical implications or foundational underpinnings. Expecting their children to understand the collegiate-level algebraic theories behind their elementary-level math homework is unrealistic. This doesn't apply only to intellectual pursuits; cognitive development, which includes intellectual and psychological components, is still in the beginning stages, making logical understanding difficult (if not impossible.)

An excessively ambitious approach that fails to account for children's feelings is unlikely to go over well with them at this stage. School-aged children who are sensitive are even more likely to react with behavioral outbursts or refusal to engage with others out of fear of rejection. Debaters who are unable or unwilling to connect with their children on an emotional level because they fail to see the logic in that approach can have difficulty promoting the confidence their sons and daughters need to become self-assured, competent adults.

Rebalancing Parenting in the School-Age Years

Listen Up

It's important for Debater parents to balance their ambition with compassion and understanding. Peers and teachers exert increasing influence on school-age children, but parents still have the lead role in helping their sons and daughters develop their skills, goals, and, ultimately, self-esteem. Debaters who push their children too hard need to dial down criticism and focus on empathizing with them. As forward-thinking as they are, and as successful as they hope their children may be, Debater parents must learn to temper their motivations with something more sensitive.

Active listening is one of the most effective ways to practice compassion with children. The following steps can help Debater parents to develop active listening skills to communicate with their children in more empathetic and effective ways:

- Take time to listen to your child's concerns, questions, and frustrations without focusing exclusively on how to solve their problems. It helps to use a specific non-question statement that indicates they've been heard, such as, "That sounds like a great idea," or "That sounds really frustrating."
- Once you have taken time to improve understanding of the situation, focus on helping the child to find solutions (if necessary) by asking questions, such as, "What do you think might help?"
- Practice non-judgment when actively listening. Resist the temptation to form or offer any opinions; just listen.
- Be aware of body language. Debaters tend to use dominant or aggressive posturing in conversation. Instead, coming down to your child's eye level can help. If the child is standing, crouch to meet them. If the child is sitting, sit as well. These acts lend a sense of equality to the conversation, helping children to feel more confident in voicing their thoughts.

In most circumstances, more than well-meaning advice and opinions, kids just need someone to listen – a helpful skill for Debaters to learn for their communications with children and adults alike. Debater parents who support their sons and daughters with positive communication and sincere interest in what they have to say can get to know their children better and bolster their confidence. Confidence that their parents love them, and at least try to understand them, gives them the support they need to take on the world.

Find Thyself (12–18 Years)

Adolescence is the transition from childhood to adulthood, when children focus on developing their own distinct identities. This transitional period centers around their realization of what their roles are in their relationships with themselves, others, and society in general. To determine their roles, adolescents at this point begin the all-important process of identifying their personal values and beliefs.

At this stage, educational and future career goals form and relationships develop based on values and beliefs – making this a pivotal, foundational stage for the rest of their lives. Teens who navigate this stage successfully move from dependency on their parents for direction and support to an interdependence that allows them to rely on their own values for guidance while maintaining respectful, loving relationships with others.

Balanced Parenting During Adolescence

Encouraging Exploration

As adaptable, energetic individuals, Debaters are naturally prone to exploration and investigation. No topic is off limits, and no question is too big or obscure to be thoroughly discussed (and possibly dissected). These qualities take on even greater significance for Debater parents during their children's adolescent years, when conversations become more complex and have fewer clear-cut answers. Their fearless approach to addressing even the touchiest of topics can help to instill confidence in their teenage sons and daughters, who may be overwhelmed by the mature issues they're beginning to face.

Debaters' passion for exploration is especially useful for encouraging their kids to take the initiative in their personal growth and education. Parents with this personality type who model personal vision and a passion for learning new skills teach their teens *how* to learn – not just *what* they should learn. Learning a new skill or exploring a new topic takes curiosity and determination, both of which motivated Debaters have copious amounts. Their natural desire to learn and improve is palpable, and their kids witness such behavior on a regular basis. They encourage their children to explore any interests they may have, regardless of how “practical” they may be, which can be just the confidence boost adolescents need to pursue their passions.

Promoting Development of Personal Objectives

During this stage of identity development, adolescents need their parents' support and understanding more than ever. One of the most important aspects of personal growth for Debaters is their development of personal objectives, which are used to support various aspects of their identities. Those who remain open to others' individual perspectives and needs encourage their children to develop their own unique codes of conduct that resonate with them and aren't purely influenced by external factors. If their teens' objectives require hard work and the pursuit of a passion, Debater parents let them create their own plans to meet their personal needs and desires.

Debaters can encourage their children to develop a code of conduct by promoting and modeling such positive values as objectivity, creative thinking, independence, and lifelong learning, while providing a supportive environment. Parents who demonstrate an involved but unimposing interest when assisting with their children's

personal development also empower their teens to discover their own distinct identities and express themselves confidently.

Unbalanced Parenting During Adolescence

Permission to Do ... Whatever

The more independent their children become, the more likely Debaters are to relinquish previously enforced control or structure. Permissiveness that goes too far – by failing to set or enforce any boundaries, even actively encouraging “bold” behaviors – can result in adolescents who engage in unsafe behaviors: drinking, having unprotected sex, driving recklessly, experimenting with drugs, etc. Though they may seem mature, teens are cognitively incapable of fully understanding the potential consequences of their behavior. It’s up to parents to help them, or they risk seeing their kids make decisions that cannot be reversed.

Debaters, who themselves despise feeling controlled by others, may view any rules or guidelines that interfere with free will be too detrimental to autonomy. There’s a significant difference, however, between being *authoritative* as a parent – being trustworthy, reliable, and considerate – and being *authoritarian* – focusing on strict obedience to authority regardless of personal circumstance.

Rebalancing Parenting During Adolescence

Promoting Self-Discipline

Understanding is crucial as Debater parents navigate their adolescent children’s changing needs and growing independence. This stage requires a constant rebalancing of responsibility and expectations as teens become more capable, responsible, and mature. It can be difficult for Debaters to enforce the boundaries

their adolescent children need at a stage when they seem so capable. These parents pride themselves on their own autonomy and want to help their children achieve the same level of independence as soon as possible. But too much freedom at this stage can lead to tragedy, so their parents must help them understand that their choices come with consequences.

Debater parents who wish to encourage their children's personal growth and independence while still maintaining the structure and boundaries necessary at this stage should focus on promoting self-discipline. Adolescents who work to actively develop self-discipline – persevering through life's trials and delaying gratification to set themselves up for future success – are much more likely to be healthy, independent, and accomplished adults. Authoritative parenting helps children practice self-discipline, teaching them to regulate themselves rather than rely on parents for correction. One way to foster self-discipline is to teach adolescents how to control their emotions (an especially difficult task at this stage) using the “ABCDE” method:

- A: Identify an **a**ctivating event (for example, failing their driver's license test).
- B: Determine the irrational **b**eliefs that resulted from that event (in this example, believing that the test was impossible or that they were “too stupid” to pass it).
- C: Consider the emotional **c**onsequences of those beliefs. (Anger, frustration, and sadness may result in teens yelling at their parents over an issue that's relatively minor, even though it seems major at the time.)
- D: **D**ispute or challenge the irrational beliefs. (Discuss the irrational belief that the test was impossible or that they're too stupid to pass, then determine whether the issue was more likely caused by a lack of study and practice, leading to test anxiety or knowledge gaps.)

- E: Replace irrational beliefs with new, effective beliefs that result in positive behaviors. (Studying and practicing before retaking the driver's license test can increase knowledge and improve confidence, hopefully preventing test anxiety and resulting in a passing score.)

Debaters can help their adolescent children walk through the ABCDE process a few times before they're comfortable practicing it on their own. The idea behind the activity is that teens can learn how to handle their emotions and, in turn, gain the foundational skills that support self-discipline. Debater parents who practice those skills with their kids help them develop the tools they need to function most effectively on their own.

Conclusion

Parenting is one of the most challenging experiences that anyone can face, regardless of their personality type. Debaters have their own unique strengths they can leverage – curiosity, originality, enthusiasm, and quick-wittedness – as well as weaknesses they need to understand and balance to build positive, proactive relationships with their children. There's tremendous potential for personal development when one becomes a parent, and Debaters can gain a much deeper understanding of themselves and others if they use the opportunity to do so.

The advice provided in this chapter is based on general growth stages for children and basic strengths and weaknesses that many Debaters share. All children are different, and parents are the best judge of what their kids need. The information above should be used in a way that works best for each family without adding additional stress, frustration, or burden. For special situations, such as behavioral or

medical issues, it's best to consult with professional pediatricians or pediatric psychologists to come up with plans that work best for everyone involved.

Additional Tools and Tests

Want to dig even deeper into your role as a parent? If you have access to the toolkits area of the website, we offer a variety of additional tools and tests to help you explore.

Parenting Styles Test

Whether you have children already or hope to become a parent in the future, this test offers you useful insights into your parenting style.

Type Guesser (Parent)

Are you trying to figure out what personality type your parent belongs to? You may find that this simple tool helps.

Type Guesser (Child)

Are you trying to figure out what personality type your teenage child belongs to? You may find that this simple tool helps.

Academic Path



Few types are as adept at picking up on complex concepts as Debaters are – which is both a blessing and a curse for these inquisitive and, at times, argumentative types. Academia can be a wonderland of exploration and intrigue, but endless curiosity can also cause issues for this precocious personality type. Classes may seem too structured, preventing them from following their ever-evolving tangents. Many teachers bristle when they're inevitably criticized, questioned, or downright ignored by Debater students. Whatever dynamics might arise in the classroom, however, Debaters are hardwired to learn, so they go out of their way to create the education they truly desire.

To maximize their academic outcomes, Debaters can explore some of the opportunities and obstacles they might face throughout their academic careers. The following paragraphs will discuss how they learn when they're at their best, as well as what challenges they may face if they struggle to rein in some of their less-than-helpful behaviors. Additionally, we'll discuss how Debaters can influence their academic paths through high school and beyond with intentional actions and reflections.

How Debaters Learn

Adept at expansive thought, Debater students possess a wealth of intellectual curiosity, which gives them a good chance of enjoying their schooling. That said, they may experience significant tension with their instructors, as highly structured learning environments pose challenges for these independent-minded – and verbose – types.

Fortunately, if frustration doesn't turn into arrogance, Debaters' love of learning and discovery can sustain them throughout their academic careers. Education can represent an opportunity for them to pursue their passions, as well as develop the skills required to respectfully collaborate with others and see the value that others bring to the table – skills that can serve them for the rest of their lives, even if they don't realize it at the time.

Balanced Learning Habits

Capable Minds

Debaters are unlikely to follow social conventions that they believe are fundamentally irrational; regardless, they are often delightfully charming in their interactions with others. Generally, their desire to be knowledgeable is just as strong as their desire to be well-liked. When they can align the two in healthy ways, Debaters can engage with peers and teachers alike in entertaining yet elucidative conversations.

Their often-adversarial view of study can at times frustrate parents or teachers who see their incessant “why” questioning as defiance rather than sophisticated curiosity. However, educators who are up to the challenge of matching wits with Debater

students find that nothing is more intellectually rewarding than dialogue with these loyal opponents whose ultimate interests are to enlighten, not humiliate.

A Rising Tide Lifts All Boats

At their best, Debaters challenge those around them to pursue ever-increasing levels of knowledge and accomplishment. Their gregariousness is as alluring as the proverbial flame, drawing in people who want to improve their ability to absorb and relate information in the seemingly effortless way Debaters do. Following in the footsteps of the great teacher and philosopher Socrates, their mentorship often revolves around hearty discussions that challenge preconceived notions and refuse to entertain willful ignorance.

In an educational setting, Debaters' tendency to fearlessly – and frequently – ask questions inspires their more timid peers, and it also encourages teachers and professors to elaborate on topics for the benefit of everyone involved. Classrooms that contain curious, respectful Debaters are some of the liveliest, most engaging learning environments for both themselves and their peers.

Unbalanced Learning Habits

Lacking Consideration

With their wealth of intellectual resources, Debaters can use their talents for the betterment of their lives, the lives of those around them, and even people they'll never meet. However, if they're unable to overcome personal frustrations with the perceived ineptitude and short-sightedness plaguing the bulk of humanity, they may decide that others aren't worth their time and choose to expend their energies with little regard for the consequences to others.

Debaters who believe in their superior intellectual prowess typically struggle to appreciate the different perspectives offered by those they deem less intelligent. They may have little patience for teachers and peers alike because they believe that their own knowledge and experience supersede whatever information anyone else provides – especially when the input of others contradicts what they believe is more logical. Rejecting other viewpoints is dangerous because it prevents Debaters from challenging their own possibly irrational beliefs, and it precludes them from experiencing the wealth of knowledge that’s available only when they’re open to other points of view.

Always Right – No Matter What!

Some Debaters struggle mightily with their need to be right. When their identity is too wrapped up in appearing smart and capable, they can’t afford to be wrong: Giving an incorrect answer makes them feel incompetent or unintelligent. Consequently, when their confidence and ego come into play, Debaters put every ounce of brainpower into arguing for their answers or discrediting the answers of others. Although this can be incredibly frustrating for those on the receiving end of a Debater argument, it’s important to remember that the overconfidence they attempt to display often belies a lack of personal confidence.

Confidence is a worthy quality, but without compassion to keep it in check, it can easily turn to arrogance. In their educational pursuits, Debaters may find themselves overly confident in their knowledge, to the point where they skimp out on the work necessary to properly complete projects or assignments. Reading a book on astrophysics certainly increases their understanding of the topic, but it by no means makes them experts, even though they may feel that way. Cutting corners, making

assumptions, and putting in as little effort as possible are all potential hazards when Debaters believe they always know what is right.

Rebalancing Learning Habits

Considering Other Ideas

When learning, Debaters may disregard others' opinions for any number of reasons; for instance, because they deem the other person less intelligent. However, it's important to understand that the best way to learn is to understand different perspectives – ironically, refusing to consider the viewpoints of supposedly ignorant people leads to more ignorance. When people with this personality type open themselves to new views, no matter how illogical or unrealistic they may seem, they also open themselves up to a greater wealth of knowledge.

Debaters' desire to figure out the world from a purely logical perspective can be a little rough on those around them. Others may not learn best by the same direct, hard, rational processes. Consequently, in group environments, Debaters may feel – and cause – friction.

To simultaneously address both problems, they can practice taking on another person's idea with the intention of seeing it from the other person's perspective *and* finding value in an idea they wouldn't have previously considered. This goes beyond just playing devil's advocate – taking on another viewpoint as though they believe and want to further it is much different from using it to merely argue a point. Debaters can practice sincerely considering someone else's idea by engaging in the following exercise:

- Take an idea that's intriguing but may be difficult to accept at face value, such as an alternative political viewpoint.
- Interview a friend, coworker, or family member who holds the view. Ask questions: "What about this idea do you find interesting?" "What is your reasoning for supporting this idea?" "How does this idea align with your personal beliefs?" Use the opportunity to determine why the idea is important and what reasons the person has for accepting it.
- Now consider the reasons the idea has been difficult to personally accept. Was information previously unknown or unavailable? Did the idea seem illogical or impractical, even though it may not be? Is it possible that the idea contradicts other ideas or beliefs that are personally important?
- It's not necessary to accept or support the idea that's being considered. Just listening to the reasons others support it and questioning your own preconceived notions are vitally important to remaining (or becoming) open-minded and objective.

Understanding the different ways other people exchange and process information fosters cooperation and expands Debaters' abilities by leaps and bounds. The benefit of developing cooperative skills can prove enormously valuable to Debaters in their educational careers, in work, and in life.

Being Dedicated to Truth

Being proven wrong is unpleasant for people with this personality type, even more so when they're stubborn about being wrong. Yet that may be the result when Debaters impatiently take shortcuts to learning or completing assignments. They can fall into the trap of believing that they're right no matter what, even if they haven't proven it yet. However, when Debaters circumvent prescribed learning processes,

they weaken their grasp of information, leaving themselves vulnerable to ignorance that others may reveal.

That fact alone provides strong motivation for them to be both studious and conscientious. Feeling as though they're at the head of the class is no excuse to shirk the work. When Debaters force themselves to focus, they build a solid foundation of knowledge that makes their opinions and arguments strong as well. A sharp wit can carry Debaters only so far in life; dedication and time are the only ways they can gain true knowledge. Luckily, they absorb facts like sponges when they maintain dedicated attention. The following exercise can help them hone their focus and attack their studies in an effective, efficient way:

- Create a study schedule with specific goals and a realistic, detailed timeline to achieve those goals.
 - For example, becoming fluent in French in 30 days isn't realistic, but becoming proficient in French in six months may be achievable.
 - The timeline should include specific time(s) set aside every day for study, as well as markers to check progress, such as passing level one French tests online after three months of study.
- Use multiple forms of accountability, such as reminders on a cell phone as well as a friend or family member who checks in to make sure goals are being achieved.
- Build flexibility into your plan to avoid burnout. Take breaks for self-care, and don't neglect other areas of life, such as relationships, hobbies, and work.

Schedules may seem restrictive, but Debaters who learn to utilize them effectively – and with plenty of built-in flexibility – find it easier and more enjoyable to meet their educational goals.

Debaters in High School

Following their endless enthusiasm and wide-ranging interests, Debater students pursue opportunities to increase their learning, albeit on their own terms. This is especially true if they view their years in high school as a valuable learning experience – or, at the very least, as an obstacle to overcome as quickly as possible. If they value what they're learning, they're more than capable of being competent students. However, those motivated by a desire to escape an uninspiring curriculum or unengaged instructors will undoubtedly approach high school with greater animosity than those whose teachers and coursework respect Debaters' insight.

Even Debaters who are adept in their studies may find the high school experience to be challenging. Tedious homework assignments and interminable lectures wear on them over time, and they may allow their boredom to overwhelm their desire to maintain a decent grade point average. When it comes to the social aspects of high school, Debaters may struggle to connect with peers and teachers in and outside the classroom if they challenge the status quo too much. Playing devil's advocate is certainly useful at times, but incessantly challenging others' perspectives can garner more ill will than respect.

Balanced High School Learning

Exploring Ideas

Many Debaters, with their desire to explore and expand upon the world around them, find themselves drawn toward classes, projects, and extracurricular activities that encourage free thinking and innovation. Creative writing assignments, robotics competitions, and student council meetings all provide opportunities for the

challenge and exploration they crave. When they focus their energy on a topic of interest, Debater students are capable of genuinely excelling.

If they utilize their traits in truly open-minded ways, Debaters can do well even in classes and activities that don't directly correspond to their interests. For instance, they may not be particularly excited about chemistry, but deeper understanding of the periodic table can be just as valuable as any other skill. Simply the ability to learn new information, fascinating or not, is itself a desirable and necessary skill to develop. Debaters who can overcome their disinterest in certain subjects or topics tend to excel in the classroom and master the skills necessary for future success.

Plotting Their Own Course

Like many high school students, Debaters may find themselves drawn to the competitive spirit of sports or the artistic challenge of music and theater – although they may find that their intellectual approach lacks the immediacy that so many seek in athletics and the arts alike. Other Debater students may find it more intellectually fulfilling to participate in gaming clubs or other specialized interest groups more in line with their nature.

Spurred on by their curiosity and sharp wit, Debater students may consider many sports, clubs, and other extracurricular activities until they find the ones that resonate with them the most. They understand that finding an activity that enthuses them takes time. And when things don't work out, resilient Debaters simply tuck away the knowledge they've gained and try something else. This mentality serves them well later in life, as they delve into the exploratory process of determining a college major and/or potential careers.

Unbalanced High School Learning

The Class Showoff

Debaters seek attention. Although not inherently a bad thing, this tendency can easily distract them from their studies during their teenage years. When these students are more focused on gaining their peers' approval than focusing on schoolwork, teachers and administrators may have difficulty tolerating their rambunctious behavior. If Debaters lack consideration for others, they may ignore the genuine concerns of such authority figures.

This can carry over to their fellow students as well. As dominantly cerebral types, Debaters can lack warmth and deeper connections with their peers. They sometimes use their wit and mental agility to impress people – or put them down. Jokes, sarcastic comments, and witty retorts about people in charge are go-to maneuvers for teen Debaters. They may dismiss subjects and people that strike them as boring, and they often wear their contempt openly. Although these students are generally more than capable of academic success, the trap of being “too cool for school” can hinder their academic development.

Anything but Homework

Popularity often comes with distraction – and it borders on addictive for Debaters if they can't extricate their identity from their social standing. When the center of attention is their favorite place to be, Debaters may find themselves neglecting their studies to socialize.

Though they aren't necessarily adrenaline junkies, Debaters are often high-energy individuals. When their natural energy is combined with teenage hormones and an

active social life, they may find themselves seeking out adventure rather than focusing on their education. When school is unable to engage their attention or stoke their passion, Debaters tend to confidently shirk their studies to pursue interests outside of school.

Rebalancing High School Learning

Putting in the Effort

To combat a lack of sincere attention to academics, Debaters who feel they're above the work can prove it by excelling. Nothing demonstrates their superiority better than a concrete example – after that, there's nothing wrong with poking fun at the system. Debaters who use their minds fully and more efficiently earn the right to stand up and declare their ability, and if it wins the admiration of others, that too is deserved.

These students should keep in mind that drawing attention to themselves sometimes means pulling focus from the education process for other people. There's room for showing off their knowledge and even making a few well-placed jokes, *if* they respect the fact that a classroom is first and foremost a place of learning. One way they can get their work done and let others get their work done as well is to intentionally set goals for themselves. Setting aside specific times for work and play can help Debater students stay focused on accomplishing their goals while ensuring plenty of time to cut loose. Specifically, they can try the following:

- Address the tendency to be distracted by setting small, achievable schoolwork goals.
- Once the goals are accomplished, take some time to goof off a little.
- Confine the latter to breaks or between classes to avoid friction with others.

Debaters are much more likely to be taken seriously as knowledgeable individuals when they prove their ability to focus on and accomplish important tasks. Rather than relying on wit and well-timed humor, they can work toward being legitimately well-prepared – something that can earn them more respect with teachers, classmates, and future employers alike.

Find Something to Get Excited About

With their inconsistent attention span, argumentative nature, and sharply logical tendencies, Debaters often struggle to care about something that seems as arbitrary as homework. In high school especially, it can be difficult to balance their desire for intrigue with the necessity of meeting educational goals. One of the most effective ways these students can fuel their passion for peer interaction while also engaging with schoolwork is to join a group. While providing the social component that Debaters so thoroughly enjoy, groups often provide a measure of accountability as well: Many groups require students to maintain certain grade point averages to remain involved.

Debaters may join any group that represents their interests. Volunteerism is an excellent way to jump into dynamic learning environments. Any place from a machine shop to a zoo might be willing to take on an apprentice. A charity or even a political club that speaks to Debaters' views is the perfect place to learn and practice such skills as focus, perseverance, and positive communication. Learning activities look good on college applications, and, more importantly, they help Debaters practice skills that give them an edge in school and later in life. Participating in activities outside school gives them a chance to learn in a more versatile environment. Here are several criteria Debaters can follow to accomplish such balance:

- First: Find something that piques your interest enough that you want to engage and explore it further.
- Second: Choose a place that values participants.
- Third: Ensure the activity represents learning, not just entertainment. Social skills and cooperation likely will play a part, as they will significantly enhance Debaters' ability to learn.

As an example, Debaters who enjoy sports could create informal peer leagues – even if it's only two teams, they can come together and organize. This is an excellent chance to practice the follow-through this personality type sometimes lacks. Alternatively, Debaters could run tabletop game campaigns, making a dedicated effort to ensure that everyone is respected, the rules are observed impartially, and fun abounds.

Mastering an equitable yet powerful balance between participation and observation can take Debaters far in their education and beyond. Additionally, being involved in groups that allow them to practice positive interactions but also gain skills and knowledge is invaluable. Such skills look good to colleges and potential employers but, most importantly, set Debaters up for healthier relationships as well as more effective social and technical skills.

Deciding Whether and When to Attend College

Many reasons factor into the decision whether to go to college, including personality type. Not long ago, most thought of college or university as the quickest path to success and security. Some of those same people now vigorously argue against

higher education for everyone, having seen college graduates struggle in their careers and having seen college dropouts succeed on a grand scale in our technological age – Steve Jobs and Bill Gates being two famous examples.

Indeed, some individuals have been highly successful despite their lack of a college degree. However, even though a college degree may not be *necessary* for success, it makes one much more likely to find work that pays well. Many careers, even entry-level positions, require some sort of college degree or certification even to apply. In addition, studies show that individuals who have a diploma from an institution of higher education earn, on average, as much as \$1 million more over a lifetime than those with only a high school diploma.

There's a niche for everyone, and college is just one possible path to finding it. So, what should Debaters consider when thinking about college?

"Will a degree be necessary for the work I want to pursue?"

Debaters who pursue college are often drawn to professional careers that demand the specialized expertise represented by a degree in those fields. Enterprising Debaters might find occasional loopholes that allow them to pursue such careers without years spent in academia. However, those who desire a profession in science, engineering, law, or a variety of other fields may find that a degree is the most expedient – and sometimes the only – route to their destination, regardless of how much they might resent the delay.

Debaters who find college to be too restrictive or too slow-paced may find success by striking out on their own, which is admirable. However, even the most brilliant may have difficulty demonstrating their ingenuity without the necessary paperwork to back their claims.

“Will I gain something intangible, yet valuable, from going to college?”

For Debaters, higher education can have value beyond the certificate granted. Those interested in technological fields may have trouble finding the necessary resources to pursue such interests – computer equipment, lab apparatus, and database access – a problem that college may remedy.

University professors are also valuable resources for Debaters. Even if they're inclined to view their instructors as adversaries rather than mentors, the friction of classroom debate is a powerful means of strengthening untested ideas.

Finally, Debaters can use college as a means of deferring work to determine what they truly want in a career. By using scholarships, loans, or other financial safety nets, Debaters can use the relatively unfettered time and space that accompany higher education to realize their intellectual potential.

Debaters live for exciting challenges, and higher education offers an excellent environment where they can test their limits. Those who had a positive high school experience are likely to find that college provides even greater opportunities for their intellectual growth. Debaters who found high school to be too conventional and lacking in meaningful choices may be pleasantly surprised by their newfound ability to shape a curriculum to their liking.

Balanced Decision-Making

The Search for Knowledge

Students with a reasonable perspective understand that no matter how much they know, the amount left to learn is always far greater. A formal education not only helps satisfy their thirst for knowledge but also provides hands-on learning. When deciding

whether and when to attend college, Debaters do well to allow their passion for learning to lead them wherever they can gain the most useful experience.

Debaters don't just want knowledge; they crave challenges and excitement. They know they need more than just logic to make their arguments, that it takes a well-grounded sense of reality and the ability to draw on vast stores of personal experience. People with this personality type don't only want to convince people they're right, they want to *be* right – and for that, there's no substitute for dedicated learning. Whether this means a traditional education, on-the-job learning, or lifelong learning, Debater students wisely place themselves where they can continuously learn, grow, and feed their intellect with solid facts.

Knowing When to Get an Education

Some Debaters who place themselves in a work environment too early run the risk of entering a cycle of rehashing what they already know. However, because they love obtaining knowledge, they can sense when they're stuck intellectually. Also, they tend to understand it's never too late to go back to school to gather more knowledge. People with this personality type have little trouble seeing when they're stagnating, and their Prospecting trait helps them to move in a different direction when necessary.

This is just as true for Debaters who engage in traditional education and find it limiting. Although it can be risky in the long term to abandon early efforts toward a degree, sometimes alternate opportunities appear. If a job opportunity comes along, or a chance for unconventional education, Debaters understand that they're allowed to put college on hold to try something else. Their independent viewpoint provides them with the flexibility to see and embrace such opportunities.

Unbalanced Decision-Making

Decision Paralysis

It may seem beneficial to survey a multitude of opportunities for formal and informal education on top of vast career options. However, Debaters who struggle with setting realistic, achievable goals may find themselves unable to form thoughtful academic and career plans. What may start off as initially exciting ventures can quickly be tossed aside for newer, seemingly better ideas once the first ones get too difficult.

Frequently switching majors, for example, not only puts students behind in terms of courses they need to take, it also often leads to more tuition bills. Potential employers (and even romantic partners) tend to pass on people who are unable to finish what they start. Though the world may be their oyster, Debaters still need to determine which sea to fish in, or they may spend their lives floating aimlessly through choppy waters.

Opinions Take Precedence

Debaters can easily lean on opinions rather than knowledge. It takes little learning for people with this personality type to *seem* wise because their agile minds often make the best use of information and facts. This can cause some to have a drastically inflated sense of their own knowledge, which can make college seem useless. Yet such overconfidence can be a mistake that poisons a lifetime of potential achievement.

Bypassing college isn't automatically harmful, but Debaters should beware of doing so out of a false sense of intellectual accomplishment. Whether enrolling in school or choosing immediate entry into the workforce, those who decide they already know

enough may cement their lack of knowledge. They may give themselves a false sense that they aren't stagnating by drilling down on what they already know and exploring the same intellectual ground – creating a veritable echo chamber for their current knowledge and opinions.

Rebalancing Decision-Making

Knowing When to Stay

Other personality types might struggle with deciding to jump and change their approach if they find that work or college isn't what they expected. Debaters may experience the opposite issue, reassessing their choices so early and so often that they make themselves miserable. Beneath their opinionated exteriors, Debaters with imbalanced self-esteem or self-respect may second-guess themselves, with painful results. This internal unease can lead them to give up on the path they chose – whether a career or college – before they've given it a fair chance.

Developing a philosophy that values the importance of focus and perseverance can be especially valuable for anxious Debaters. Instead of deciding a path is “wrong” as soon as it doesn't “feel good” – or when another path looks more appealing – perhaps a better approach is to look at the experience as a worthy experiment, taking time to examine it rigorously before leaping to a conclusion. To do this, here are five groups of questions Debaters can ask themselves:

- What are the consequences of staying this course for another year? What are the opportunity costs? What is the best-case scenario?
- Is there potential for growth? Am I learning new skills, or am I gaining new knowledge and understanding? What opportunities will I have for growth and learning by staying this course for another year?

- Do I have a sense of connection or purpose on this path? If not, how can I find and cultivate a sense of purpose?
- Do I have a clear vision of where this current path will lead? If so, do I like it? If not, what does the lack of clarity mean, and how does it impact my decision-making?
- Am I pushing away or ignoring mentors, peers, or others who could provide encouragement or advice? If so, what concrete first step can I take today to connect with them?

By writing down answers to the above questions and ideally sharing the insights with trusted friends or advisors, Debaters can break out of the mental cycle that leads them to question their decisions reflexively rather than reflectively. It can help them gain the insight and strength required to take a positive next step – whether that means staying the course or moving on to something new.

Opening Perspectives

Debaters can't decide on the right path without an idea of what makes a path "right." Sometimes they struggle because they assume they already have the information they need. People with this personality type may need to free their minds to take in a greater breadth of information. One way is to humbly seek out those more advanced along their chosen academic or career path and ask them for insight and wisdom that come only from experience. Knowledge is powerful when it comes to decision-making, and the more knowledge Debaters have, the broader their perspectives can be.

Perhaps they might even "adopt" mentors; after all, nothing provides perspective like witnessing possibilities through the eyes of people who have already lived them.

Such perspective might even inspire Debaters to project themselves onto a successful trajectory as they view potential paths through the lens of their mentors' self-confidence and experience. This can help with work, college, or graduate degree considerations. Here are some guidelines Debaters can use when finding mentors to help with the decision-making process:

- Decide before starting that making such an important decision is dynamic, and that concrete answers are likely to form only after an extended period of exploration. In other words, there are no easy answers – so good mentors don't typically provide them.
- Talk to – or read about – a variety of experienced people to help develop a specific direction.
- Check whether any organizations provide mentoring to students considering careers. It can be daunting for someone not yet in college or in a career to connect with mentors, but an ever-increasing dialogue between schools and businesses means that organizations on both sides often work together to help.
- Summer internships or work-study opportunities can be immensely helpful to Debaters trying to determine whether they need a college education.

Mentors provide the knowledge and accountability that Debaters crave, and they also serve as fantastic sources of otherwise difficult-to-find information – either through their own knowledge or through the vast networks of other experts to whom they have access. When it comes to deciding something as important as whether to attend college, resources like mentors who can provide information and support are absolutely invaluable.

Debaters in College

For Debaters who choose to attend college, higher education offers an excellent environment in which to test their limits. People with this personality type live for a good challenge, and college can certainly offer gratifying opportunities for growth and development.

Balanced Approach to College

Endless Opportunities

In college, Debaters' wide-ranging curiosity serves them well. Thumbing through a course catalog can be a fascinating exercise for them as they discover plenty of course offerings and extracurricular activities to capture their interest. College environments that encourage interdisciplinary or entrepreneurial studies can be especially gratifying for people with this personality type. By bridging different disciplines, such studies offer Debater students an opportunity to think outside the box and make unexpected connections – two of their favorite intellectual maneuvers.

If they carry this sense of engagement to required courses and prerequisites, Debaters stand to gain even more from the college experience. Although they'll likely prefer the courses they elect over predetermined requirements, those who take an open-minded approach allow their imaginations to be sparked by *all* their classes, even those that lie outside their interests. Looking at every course or activity as a learning opportunity can set Debater students up for more positive learning (and social) college experiences.

Kindred Spirits

With the plethora of fresh faces and new resources available at most college campuses, Debaters are likely to be thrilled with the social and educational opportunities available to them. This is especially true if they find people who share their less-common interests. Debater students are also likely to delight in encountering people who *don't* share their interests, as they can open Debaters' eyes to new thoughts and fascinations and provide opportunities for entertaining debates and conversations. New connections can evolve into friendships and collaborations that offer Debaters the inspiration and exposure to fresh ideas they so crave.

In addition to providing companionship, new relationships can expose Debaters to new academic ideas, knowledge, and beliefs. Truly open-minded Debaters are excited to find new information, regardless of whether it supports their previously held beliefs and opinions. With their unique backgrounds and personal stories, new acquaintances are a wealth of new knowledge. From lively debates to study groups to game nights, Debaters can find ways to engage peers and professors alike in intellectual discourse that feeds their curiosity and desire for human interaction.

Unbalanced Approach to College

Narrowing Horizons

If they decide to pursue college, Debaters with outsized egos can inadvertently limit their academic horizons. They may allow their strong views to limit their choice of courses, leading them to focus on what they've decided is "worthwhile" while ignoring what could unexpectedly become so. They might also blow off required courses that don't align with their personal interests.

To put it bluntly, Debater students who regard required courses with resentment – or write off entire fields of study – waste potentially important learning experiences. Required courses, when approached in the right spirit, can lay the groundwork for skills that can serve Debaters throughout their lives. Such skills might lead to future professional opportunities, or they might simply be interesting to learn. Unless they force themselves into unknown terrain – which entails opening their minds to fields of study that don’t immediately seem “useful” or “rational” – Debaters stay stuck in their comfort zones, severely limiting their personal growth.

Questioning Everything, Respecting Nothing

When facing new ideas in college, Debaters who get stuck on past conceptions often exhibit a confrontational, argumentative style that interferes with learning. Fixating on minor fallacies, which abound everywhere and rarely matter in any material way, can cause Debaters students to miss the bigger picture. They may be so caught up in competitive intellectual sparring over principles and semantics that they miss bigger truths with less-defined edges. Debaters whose confidence depends on how others perceive their intelligence may endlessly argue over details, but teachers and peers may simply move on without them.

Ego is often the source of such imbalance. When Debaters feel a need to prove themselves right, they can go to great lengths to attack or impress others. Given the nature of logic, it can easily be misused as a weapon; when Debaters do so, they often win. However, what they win is merely an inflated sense of self, as beating people in arguments does little to advance their own minds or bring in new knowledge. Teachers and fellow students alike quickly tire of Debaters who focus more on speaking their minds – or dominating others – instead of fairly considering contrasting opinions or new information.

Rebalancing Their Approach to College

Learning from Everything

For Debaters, there are concrete benefits to finding the value inherent even in subjects that seem dull or pointless – including seemingly arbitrary prerequisites and required courses. Given their increased maturity, people with this personality type are more likely to seek opportunities for personal development and growth in such courses and assignments. The attention to detail and memorization that strictly defined courses require might help Debaters become better at tolerating and dealing with the mundane – a key component of achieving the goals they set for themselves.

With this mindset, many worthwhile things can happen. First, Debaters may gain the discipline that provides much-needed balance to their intellectual enthusiasm. They can learn the value of being stricter with themselves when it comes to life's more insistent details. Moreover, they can view the hours spent in such classes as valuable rather than a useless and artificial waste of time. Eventually, their perception of a class may change from tragically hollow to authentically worthwhile.

To enhance the process, Debaters can try the following exercise:

- Identify a subject that doesn't feel particularly interesting or worthwhile, especially if it's a required course.
- Meet with someone who is majoring in that subject or pursuing a related career. Ask questions: Why would someone become a pathologist, or a geographer, or a marine biologist? What's special or meaningful about the subject? What challenges does the field address, and how can it benefit humankind?
- Befriend someone who has academic interests that are seemingly dull or unnecessary. Take the time to really consider what value that area of focus has,

both for that individual and for others who may benefit from it. For example, accounting isn't just crunching numbers on spreadsheets – it helps to organize financial resources for intrepid Debater entrepreneurs.

Overcoming a tendency to be “right” rather than considerate is a challenge Debaters may face in academics and life. By taking a path of investigation and inquiry, however, Debaters might just discover new passions and develop new friendships they wouldn't have otherwise.

Respecting Other Views

When learning, Debaters may disregard the opinions of people they consider less intelligent, including instructors and fellow students. However, true learning requires gaining perspectives different from those they already hold. Rejecting other perspectives only results in ignorance. Even when others' perspectives are provably false, knowledge and truth can be found in fiction as readily as any documentary. Seekers often find treasures in the least expected places. Openness to others is the key to broadening understanding.

When Debaters open themselves to others' perspectives, they also open themselves up to a greater wealth of possibilities. If they humble themselves appropriately, they can gain well-rounded evidence and insight that make their opinions and arguments stronger. A willingness to prove verifiable ideas is an excellent way to continually learn. Debaters can try the following experiment to apply scrutiny to ideas and beliefs:

- Pick a topic that interests you. The stronger your opinion about the topic (good or bad), the better.

- Find a club, organization, or even religious service to attend, primarily as an observer.
- When attending the meeting or service, look for any comments or discussions that contain information contrary to your personal beliefs. (It's important, however, to resist debating anyone. This exercise is purely for gathering information and observing to challenge your own beliefs – not to criticize or persuade someone else.)
- Rarely are people totally wrong, so there's likely at least one point you can appreciate, regardless of whether you agree with the overall position. Keep in mind that you needn't embrace the point or position; simply acknowledge that the perspective has some merit.
- Consider other ideas you have that might deserve the same scrutiny. The more people test an idea, the more accurate the idea is likely to be – this holds as well for day-to-day disagreement as it does for peer review in the scientific method.

By recognizing that many viewpoints can have valid components, Debaters can learn to respect peers and instructors whose approach to learning and overall understanding of the world around them are different from their own. After all, only by questioning any knee-jerk dismissals of other opinions can Debaters truly earn the right to consider themselves open-minded.

Lifelong Learning

For many, “learning” and “formal education” are virtually synonymous. Both terms are bound by the institutions that govern them: the schools and universities that confer certificates upon graduation. Debaters, who are often ambivalent about the prospect of formal education, are less likely to make this association as easily. They

simultaneously revere the academic world for its potential to further their own interests yet remain acutely aware of its uses as a tool for indoctrination. People with this personality type feel the need to take the world by storm and turn to education only when necessary, gathering from it what they need while trying to rush through the irrelevant as quickly as possible.

To outside observers, Debaters may have strange notions of what counts as “necessary,” as they rely on their own definition rather than that of society. However, Debaters who refuse to admit that there may be different but equally acceptable options tend to continue treading the same well-worn paths. They’ll stubbornly insist that, although they haven’t learned everything there is to know, they know what they consider important.

Debaters continue to learn if their need to innovate continues. If they want to build solar panels, then they’ll strive to be amateur engineers. If they want to market and own companies that sell solar panels, then they’ll take the steps needed to become business magnates. They never stop innovating, so they never stop learning.

Balanced Lifelong Learning

Enthusiastic Exploration

Self-aware Debaters understand that even though they have a strong desire to explore new things, they may need some time to find a way to learn outside the classroom that truly enthuses them. To move things along, they can leverage their sharp minds, trying out many things until they find the right one. Anything from an improv class to a debating society might tickle their fancy, but they won’t know until they try it. When things don’t work out, they can simply tuck away the knowledge gained and try something else.

Debaters are never at a loss for something that grabs their interest and drives them to learn more. When it comes to lifelong learning, they do well to not only thoughtfully follow their passions but also take a rational look at the benefits of varying paths – beyond just initial appeal. Of course, “Because I want to try it,” is a perfectly good reason to sign up for a class or take on a new activity.

Practice, Focus, and Consistency

When well-adjusted Debaters find an area of learning they enjoy – whether composing sonatas or training for memory competitions – they stick with it. This can be a challenge, particularly when they reach a plateau in their progress. At that point, their initial enthusiasm might wane, and other activities might start to look awfully appealing. By forging through that stage, Debaters can cultivate focus; find the enjoyment inherent in applying themselves and testing their limits; and reap the rewards of diligent, consistent learning.

As they mature, Debaters come to understand how precious it is when they find a subject inspiring. As a result, they dig in with both hands and unrelenting curiosity, knowing that they can always go deeper in their learning. They avoid distractions – or incorporate them – and manage their attention, attending to only those things that they can incorporate into their learning.

Unbalanced Lifelong Learning

Living in an Echo Chamber

Changes in society and technology mean that more than ever before, we can teach ourselves. Online videos and web content are a boon for would-be autodidacts. That said, some things are learned much more easily from other people. This can be hard

for Debaters to swallow, particularly if they assume they “know best” and can figure out everything on their own. Even Debaters who recognize the value of others’ wisdom and experience may still only prescribe to the teaching of a very select few, deeming only those they agree with as worthy of their time.

Debaters’ independence can be commendable, but if they focus on acquiring only information that already supports their point of view, they will find themselves living in an unenlightened echo chamber. There are benefits to becoming deeply knowledgeable about a specific topic, but refusing to consider opposing information is dangerous due to the unnecessary conflict it inevitably creates, as well as the narrow-mindedness that follows.

Giving Up Too Soon

When asked what they’d most like to learn, Debaters aren’t hard pressed to come up with at least a few answers. Their wide-ranging enthusiasm is among their greatest strengths, but if it isn’t matched by consistency, healthy self-discipline, and the willingness to stick with difficult pursuits, it won’t get them anywhere. Even worse: A series of “failed” experiences can erode their self-respect.

Most Debaters find it easier to start something than to finish it. There’s nothing inherently wrong with that – in fact, it enables them to stand out as creative visionaries. But if they don’t push past the internal resistance that arises whenever a project becomes difficult – and it’s worth noting that resistance might come disguised as boredom or a sudden interest in a different endeavor – Debaters will flit from one area of learning to another, embracing a succession of short-lived hobbies. After a period of years or decades, they may look back and realize that they’ve scratched the

surface of a great many subjects but never achieved true depth or mastery in any of them.

Rebalancing Lifelong Learning

Breaking Out of the Box

Although they can learn much independently, Debaters may find that their course to lifelong learning runs more smoothly when they involve other points of view. They might consider drawing upon relevant teachers, seeking previously unconsidered learning environments, or simply attending talks and events that cover opposing views. Such avenues can offer Debaters opportunities to hear new ideas and consider new perspectives.

When they drop their biases, most Debaters see quite clearly that they can learn from and enjoy stimulating conversations with all manner of people with all manner of beliefs and ideas. Moreover, they can offer their own insights in return. This creates a model of learning that's informal, egalitarian, and dynamic – three qualities that suit Debaters well and allow them to enjoy the concrete as well as the ineffable benefits of an open-minded approach to learning.

To begin looking at learning from a more open-minded perspective, Debaters can try the following:

- Look for non-traditional learning opportunities, such as local meet-ups, talks, and events.
- When considering and evaluating instructors, keep an open mind. Take on the intellectual challenge of figuring out everything they *can* teach, rather than the easier track of focusing on their limitations.

- Prioritize learning experiences not previously considered. Honoring personal beliefs is important, but so is stretching comfort zones to add dimensions to life, and new perspectives often provide such stretches.
- Seek out opportunities to learn and grow during each of the experiences.
- When taking classes, look for interactive options. Lectures from podiums and somewhat passive audiences often limit the ability to hear others' opinions face-to-face. Activity-based classes provide great opportunities for communal learning, which is more inspiring for Debaters.

For Debaters, there's nothing wrong with taking an in-depth, independent approach to learning, if they feel they get what they need out of life. However, if they want to expand their lives and accelerate their learning, they may want to explore other ideas, information, and opinions that can bring more dimension to their knowledge and their lives in general.

Making Space for Learning

When a learning experience loses its initial gleam, Debaters may feel frustrated, uninspired, or vaguely disappointed. That's natural, but unless they reclaim their initial enthusiasm for the subject, they run the risk of giving up entirely. In such situations, many Debaters find themselves falling into the rut of trying to distract themselves or numb out by repeatedly absorbing themselves in other forms of entertainment – such as partying, playing video games, or even impulsively flitting from potential hobby to potential hobby without every fully engaging in any of them. Although such activities are gratifying in the moment, they can crowd out learning and other experiences that Debaters would find more enriching.

To be sure, there's nothing inherently wrong with indulging in other forms of entertainment. In fact, hanging out with friends and exploring (multiple) different hobbies can offer copious inspiration. But when Debaters fail to set boundaries around such activities, idle engagement can absorb time and energy they might otherwise spend on their passions. And when they've spent enough time away from an activity or project that once mattered to them, Debaters might find it surprisingly difficult to get back on the horse.

To make more time for learning in their lives, Debaters can experiment with an "entertainment ban:"

- Identify a form of entertainment that takes up more time in daily life than you prefer.
- Choose a side project, learning experience, or hobby that's a high priority. Ensure that you have everything necessary to pursue the project, such as supplies, books, or other resources.
- Ban the form of entertainment identified in step one for a set period of time, anything from a weekend to a month – what matters is that it's an achievable amount of time and that you adhere to it.
- Use at least some of the time and attention otherwise devoted to that form of entertainment to pursue the interest from step two.
- Recruit a friend as an accountability partner who can check in regularly and encourage you to stay on track.

Debaters might be surprised by the power that distracting entertainment once held over them – and the amount of time and energy they can finally devote to their interests.

Conclusion

Academics are about more than just learning the traditional topics of reading, writing, and arithmetic. A truly well-rounded education encourages students to love the process of learning and seeking out information itself. Debaters are naturally curious and eager to learn, often pursuing education just for the sake of obtaining more knowledge – even if the only reason they want to learn is to prove themselves right. Their passion for acquiring information is admirable and can set Debaters on the fast track to future success in their chosen occupation, as well as personal enrichment, if they're able to remain focused on the task at hand.

Fortunately, dedication and open-mindedness are skills that can be learned both inside and outside a formal classroom. Debaters who take time to balance their love of learning, their passion for communicating their ideas, some compassion, and at least a little bit of humility can find themselves not only learning more but also creating more meaningful relationships with those around them.

Some people spend nearly one-third of their lives studying. Some choose to enter the workforce earlier and don't spend as much time in classes or libraries. But most people spend at least some of their crucial formative years in school. No matter how long one remains in the academic world, the time is valuable and can establish the first steps on a path into the future. The school experience can affect lifelong self-esteem and other aspects of psychology. With the right attitude and the right choices, Debaters can make the best of that experience.

Additional Tools and Tests

Want to dig even deeper into your academic path? If you have access to the toolkits area of the website, we offer a variety of additional tools and tests to help you explore.

Thirst for Knowledge Test

What is your interest in gaining knowledge? How does your desire for learning affect your life? This tool will help you explore that.

Academic Exploration Test

Do you ever wonder what areas of study might suit your personality? Find out which subjects might be the most satisfying for you.

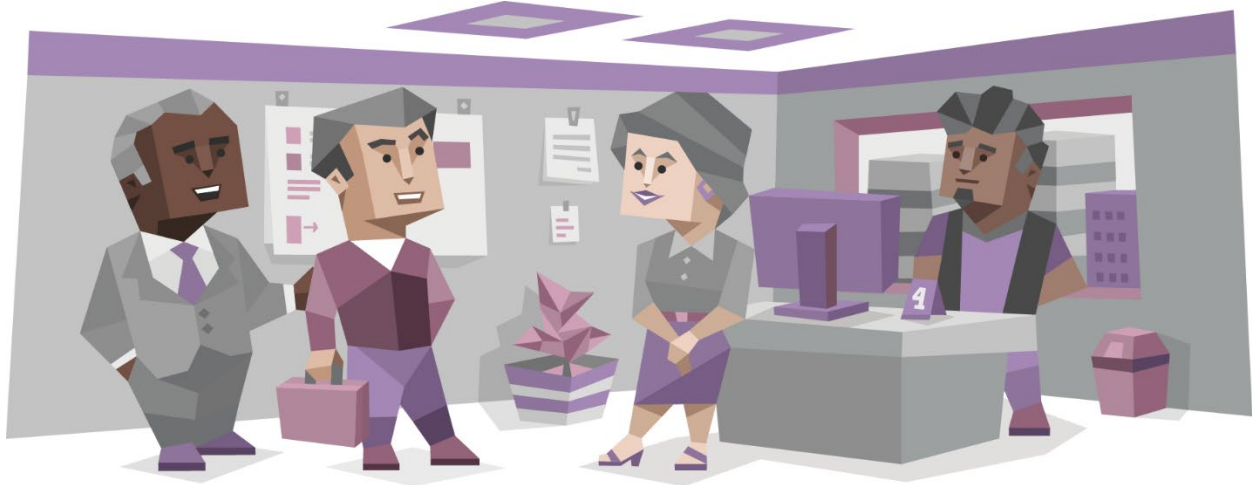
Perfectionism Test

Perfectionism is a desire to be remarkable and outstanding in everything you do. Let's see what role it plays in your life.

Type Guesser (Academic)

Are you trying to figure out what personality type your classmate belongs to? You may find that this simple tool helps.

Professional Development



Debaters' primary professional challenge is finding a career that accommodates their unique style and their need to develop and defend their complex ideas. Then again, as a segment of the workforce, they surprise themselves and others by thriving in seemingly unsuitable careers. There's no one career (or even professional category) that all Debaters must squeeze into. Instead of looking for a non-existent, one-size-fits-all-Debaters job, people with this personality type may want to consider how different parts of any given position might play to their individual strengths. Perhaps more than anything else, Debaters are especially sensitive to the challenges a job provides. They prefer work that makes them think. A post or profession lacking an acceptable degree of intricacy, one that doesn't continually test their imagination, won't satisfy them for long.

As an uncommon personality type, Debaters bring their unique perspective and energy to anything they do. They also have personal skills that can help them adapt to work environments that don't line up neatly with their style and preferences. Throughout this section, we'll discuss their traits and how they can use their skills to achieve balance and excel in professional development. We'll explore what may

cause them excitement, frustration, and boredom in their jobs. We hope this guide gives Debaters the understanding and tools to help them as they consider engaging and rewarding career paths.

Thriving on Theories and Ideas

One of the most prominent personality traits shared by all Debaters is their love for analytical methods and ideas. The best careers turn this trait into a significant strength, as few other personality types enjoy abstract concepts as much as they do. Many become distinguished career scientists, mathematicians, and system analysts, but they're far from limited to those fields. Debaters bring their reasoning skills to many workplaces – they'd be hard-pressed to find a job that has no opportunities for problem-solving at all.

Debaters typically enjoy finding and analyzing underlying principles and ideas, and they delight in sharing such information with others. Many career paths fulfill them in this way, and jobs that come with compelling challenges make Debaters even happier. They're fascinated by research, pattern-seeking, hypotheses, possibilities, and alternatives, making them great corporate strategists, business analysts, video game designers, programmers, and engineers. Regardless of the area, Debaters are system designers at heart. Although this might immediately bring inanimate systems to mind, Debaters can also envision human systems comprised of skilled people interconnecting for greater effectiveness. Debaters perceive their environment as something that can be shaped and fashioned according to their ideas.

People with this personality type are highly analytical, focused, and intelligent, and they surpass many other personality types regarding organizational skills and precise thinking. This makes them masters at theoretical foundations and structures, but

such impersonal solutions can prevent them from applying enough empathy to win over others. They can, at times, be more interested in winning minds rather than hearts, creating a chasm between themselves and the people whose support they may need.

In other words, Debaters tend to do best when they fill a niche that honors their rational ways. This doesn't mean they can't expand and branch out in more practical directions, or that they lack the social skills to win people over – quite the contrary, at times. Their “true North” is the theoretical, though, which significantly influences how they work.

Ever-Expanding Knowledge Base

Debaters usually excel at both brainstorming and inventing due to their capacity to rapidly absorb new knowledge, especially technical information. They have a significant advantage over other personality types for remembering and accessing knowledge. Debaters are so interested in absorbing new information that they seek vast amounts of knowledge on multiple subjects. Their careers are only one aspect of their lives, and most have interests, hobbies, and ideas they follow with enthusiasm outside working hours. Even if the information they gain from such interests doesn't offer immediate benefits, they realize that it may prove useful at some point.

However, this mostly healthy focus has a couple of downsides. Debaters are only satisfied with their career paths when they're confident they'll find enough intellectual stimulation along the way. Professions that aren't challenging or interesting make them restless and frustrated, which can prompt them to satisfy

their curiosity in ways that don't always align with their job requirements or their organization's goals.

Unlike some other personality types, Debaters rarely actually satisfy their curiosity. They're always looking for new processes and refuse to accept unsatisfying or incomplete answers. This makes them naturally great at pulling information together to brainstorm. Although excelling at brainstorming is a fantastic quality, continuing to brainstorm during subsequent project phases significantly slows down the process and can cause tension with coworkers, managers, or customers who need projects or products finished on reasonable timelines.

Incessantly tweaking an idea can produce a constant state of flux and disruption, turning solid goals into continually moving targets. This tendency can also lower morale, especially with more sensitive Feeling types. Other people may perceive that Debaters are questioning and contradicting their every move when, from the Debaters' perspective, they're usefully adding new information or challenging obsolete ideas. Debaters are at a clear disadvantage in such situations because they aren't always good at gauging others' emotions.

People with this personality type sometimes underappreciate their coworkers' roles (not to mention their pride and egos), placing rationality above all. The resultant misunderstandings and miscommunication can lead Debaters to misinterpret others' responses as resistance to growth. Rather than pulling back and giving their coworkers some much-needed space to understand and process information, Debaters may push even harder.

Work as an EQ Workshop

Debaters have much to offer in the workplace, but they have an opportunity to learn as well. They certainly can benefit from improving their emotional intelligence (otherwise known as EQ), and they may want to look at each contact as an opportunity to do so. Assisting a disgruntled customer, coworker, boss, or vendor can be an unpleasant experience. But such stressful events are some of the best opportunities for Debaters to practice skills such as empathy, non-judgment, and positive thinking. They may tend to tell stories and argue their positions excitingly with friends and colleagues, but working on their empathy often requires a deliberate change in behavior. Even if they find it difficult to engage empathetically in the heat of a frustrating encounter, taking the time to reflect (perhaps from the distance of the break room or later at home) can help them identify their triggers.

Social acuity is just as important as other skills, if not more so. Most consider it an essential element of professional development, but Debaters sometimes dismiss the idea because they see little value in small talk and socializing. They do, however, value personal growth, and they can benefit immensely by learning more about what drives and motivates other people. In the real world, sometimes defusing a situation with a problematic stakeholder offers more value than building a system that's twice as efficient as the old one. Such skills provide a tremendous advantage – at work and elsewhere.

Jobs and Skill Sets



As we discuss some specific jobs that suit Debaters' personality traits, keep in mind that the lists are by no means comprehensive. People with this personality type can succeed in any career they choose, and they're limited only by their interests and will. Even "suitable" jobs mentioned here may not be ideal for all Debaters. The factors for deciding one's livelihood are broad and many. Everyone must determine what career is the most appropriate for them – what meets their needs and brings them fulfillment and personal satisfaction. Nonetheless, some jobs align with typical personality preferences, and we'll offer them here for those considering their futures.

Each category below represents a field that can benefit from Debaters' particular strengths, including some specific jobs that capitalize on their personal assets. For Debaters who are already employed, this section may serve as confirmation or an explanation for why they're happy or unhappy in their current role. But it can't be said enough: This section is descriptive and intended to foster insights and ideas; it isn't prescriptive in any way. Career choices must be based on a constellation of

unique and varied personal elements. We can't tell anyone how to be successful or content, but we do hope the following material offers Debaters some insight when making career decisions.

Engineering and Design

Engineering and design are broad categories of disciplines that use science, math, design techniques, and ingenuity to create machines, structures, or systems. They not only create new products but also remove flaws from older products.

Debaters identify with this kind of work. They're "idea" people and pass their ideas on to others for implementation. But in the theoretical realm, there's nothing more satisfying for them than dreaming up ways to influence their environment or manipulate a system. Some jobs that might appeal them include the following.

- Software engineer
- Engineer of any type
- Architect
- Inventor
- Urban planner
- Environmental planner
- Video game designer

Research and Science

Debaters are passionate in their need to discover and explain how things work. Not only do they love the discovery, but they're also fond of the patterns that often reveal themselves in research, and they relish sharing their findings with others. They're

likely to take the initiative to explore what no one has studied before or to find a different approach to older research.

Researchers and scientists with this personality type admire others with similar drive and abilities and collaborate if they feel they're dealing with equals. Debaters hope their discoveries can be used for practical applications and may become involved in such implementation. Their research extends beyond finding the answer, as they embrace how it may affect the future. Some of the jobs in this category include the following.

- Academic researcher or professor
- Physical scientist
- Life scientist
- Astronomer
- Medical researcher
- Physicist
- Psychological researcher

Medicine

In the medical field, Debaters often excel as diagnosticians and practitioners. Their Intuitive and Thinking traits allow these physicians to quickly assess symptom patterns and use them to make accurate diagnoses. They approach treatment the same way. They're inclined to try innovative measures when possible, should traditional therapies fail. Any of the following fields are full of potential medical puzzles to solve and would be satisfying to Debaters who are inclined to enter medicine.

- Psychiatrist

- Pathologist
- Neurologist
- Pharmacologist
- Cardiologist
- Diagnostician

Strategy

It's no accident that we categorize Debaters as "Analysts." Naming this section "Strategy" is cheating a little bit: Everything Debaters do is strategic in some fashion, but not all tactical jobs neatly fit into categories. So this section serves as a catch-all.

What do these jobs have in common? They all involve problems that need solutions, and they all require broad-scope thinking to expand understanding. With their entrepreneurial spirit, Debaters can come up with efficient and innovative solutions. Some jobs where such skills may come in handy include the following.

- Business or corporate strategist
- Management consultant
- Project manager
- Military officer
- Educational consultant
- Investment analyst
- Lawyer
- Security and intelligence position

Taking Up a Trade

Not all Debaters go to college, nor do they all want jobs that require advanced degrees and training. There are plenty of places outside of science and technology where their skills and preferences can serve them well.

Debaters are charismatic problem-solvers who love to discuss their ideas with others – a combination that naturally lends itself to sales jobs. They can also apply their strategic style of thinking to almost anything, from efficient firefighting to making better burgers faster. The possibilities are too vast to list here and are limited only by their wants, needs, and imaginations.

Career Alternatives



Sometimes Debaters can't advance in the workplace; perhaps their employers don't value their unique traits, or maybe there just isn't room for growth. Aside from changing employers, Debaters who find themselves dissatisfied do have alternative options.

People don't need to work in the traditional sense to live comfortably. In this age of possibilities, selling one's time to a corporation isn't the only way to generate income. These days, even traditional employees don't have true job security or any guarantee of advancement. Working for oneself can be a viable option, and it offers many benefits that align with Debater values, including flexibility, independence, and control over projects. Thanks to their ability to create new ideas and make unexpected connections, these creative, bold individuals can thrive in self-employment and as entrepreneurs.

Self-Employment

Self-employment eliminates a significant hurdle Debaters may find in corporate environments: forced interaction with people with whom they disagree. Self-employed workers are somewhat freer to choose which tasks they want to perform and which they want to delegate or outsource. This means that independent Debaters can sidestep some of their pet peeves, including following orders and dealing with people who are unable (or unwilling) to improve. Self-employment offers many significant benefits, especially in today's global and always-connected environment, and individuals with this personality type can find a great deal of success in such ventures.

Entrepreneurship

There's no point in trying to start a business without a good idea. That's where Debaters' ability to come up with unusual connections – intellectually and socially – enables them to shine. Anyone can think up a product, but Debaters have an edge in looking at a situation, discovering apparent needs or desires, finding a systemic

solution that satisfies them, and then pulling together the people needed to make it happen. Consequently, a product or service is born.

It takes an imaginative mind with an independent bent – like that possessed by Debaters – to come up with an idea, product, or solution that has the potential to grow into an innovative business venture. There's a reason Google and Facebook were developed by geeks in their basements and dorm rooms rather than engineers working 9 to 5 at multinational companies. Debaters' style of thinking can spin off in unique ways to capture yet-undeveloped niches in business. When they get help with executing their visions from more hands-on individuals, they have even greater chances of success as entrepreneurs.

Challenging Career Qualities

In modern society, we spend a great deal of time at work, and we expect our careers to give us meaning. Debaters must be careful not to get stuck in jobs that don't suit their traits and temperaments, or they risk dissatisfaction and frustration. Following are characteristics of employment that may not be suitable for Debaters – but again, no occupation nor type of career is off the table. The information in this section is based on their common tendencies; it isn't meant to be absolute or restrictive.

Restrictive Environments

Debaters like to experiment and explore new ideas. Boundaries, structure, and rules that are too rigid can keep them from their comprehensive exploration of possibilities. They're passionate puzzle-solvers and aren't happy when restrictions prevent them from exercising that passion. Debaters may not be able to function at their highest capacity in such environments, and they tend to lash out rather than

conform to what they see as artificial and unnecessary hindrances to their intellectual process.

Too many standards and too much oversight make Debaters' focus too narrow for the way they gain insight. They need a free-range work environment that allows their rich imaginations to play. To function at their fullest, they need independence, not supervision. This doesn't mean they prefer to work alone, but they do need flexibility. Similarly, they may reject feeling locked into a career path that seems predetermined. They're happy just doing the work they're passionate about. Office politics and bureaucratic matters annoy them. Consequently, they may spend too much time railing against confining systems – time that could be spent contributing to an organization's goals instead.

Workplace Cooperation Between Types

Understanding how Debaters behave in various hierarchical roles is one thing; communicating their ideas to subordinates, colleagues, and managers effectively, across many personality types, is another entirely. Let's dig a little deeper to determine how Debaters can best cooperate with their coworkers.

Debater-Analyst Cooperation



Debaters and other Analysts who work together often find themselves “speaking the same language.” They make rational arguments and engage in conceptual discussions. As colleagues, they may be very adept at perfecting specific and detailed concepts, but their minds are always simultaneously scoping more extensive systems for opportunities to adjust and improve.

Balanced Debater-Analyst Cooperation

Systemic Brainstorming

With their penchant for solving puzzles, Debaters and other Analysts delve into systems and concepts, engaging in “what if” discussions about the things they explore with each other. They share a focus on improving any systems or enterprises they come across. They break them down into what works and what doesn’t, try to find solutions for the problems, and rebuild (at least in theory) new models that support their analyses. In the workplace, Debater and Analyst coworkers have similar-enough styles of thinking that they can either confirm, correct, or expand each other’s ideas with a sense of mutual credibility. Their shared methods increase

the trust and comfort they have with each other's opinions, helping to create supportive work relationships.

Because they share a certain style, Debaters and other Analysts can be a perfect match for brainstorming or bouncing ideas off each other. Brainstorming between the two extends far beyond the meeting room. Both are likely to take the time to ponder the different facets of an idea, then continue discussions. "I was thinking about what you said..." may be a familiar refrain between these colleagues. Such a dynamic may create a partnership or even be the start of a team – whether deliberately or, more likely, as an unintended result of similar energies and styles meeting in the workplace.

Socially Compatible

Because people spend so much of their lives working, relationships with colleagues often involve more than just the job. Debater and Analyst coworkers often have a social kinship: Small talk interests neither, so they may find each other's company a relief from the tedium of the usual watercooler chat. What Debaters and Analysts consider conversation may be more complicated than most people are accustomed to in their casual tête-à-têtes. When an organization employs multiple Debaters and Analysts, these employees may find they finally have other people who can handle their sometimes-brash conversational styles.

Similarly, Debaters and other Analysts have contempt for ideological arguments, emotional appeals, and "soft" rationalizations. When they work together, they quickly spot those tendencies. If Debaters and other Analysts notice flaws or inconsistencies in a company or its leadership, they may form an "alliance of the like-minded" over

the perceived weaknesses. Bonding over negative issues has potential dangers, but, if handled correctly, it can also provide fertile ground for positive change.

Unbalanced Debater-Analyst Cooperation

Constant Competition

One pitfall Debater and Analyst coworkers may face is the potential for constant competitive tension. Because they're somewhat rare, Debaters may not have had experience with other Analysts in the room. New encounters can be uncomfortable – especially when Debaters come across other Analysts who share their specific specialties. In career settings with a high concentration of Analysts, the competition can be extreme. Although these personality types aren't prone to drama in an emotional sense, their one-upmanship can cause extensive damage if it spills too much into the workday.

If Debaters and other Analysts become competitive with each other, they risk becoming entrenched in opposing ideas or unrelenting criticism of each other. Analysts are prone to freely show scorn for others' mistakes or displays of flawed logic, and terse remarks can ratchet up the heat as their egos become strongholds they must defend. Of all the Analysts, Debaters are the most likely to appreciate an argument, and they may even set them off intentionally for the fun of it. Where Debaters may envision a resulting synergy of ideas, the results can just as easily be a destructive rivalry where participants tear each other down to prove their intellectual superiority.

A Quagmire of Cleverness

Debaters and other Analysts who nurture their collaborative spirits can find themselves in a quagmire of genius. They may produce *too many* great ideas while brainstorming together. With each new diversion requiring resources and entailing costs, these coworkers can become trapped in their cleverness, unable to move any one objective forward with the competence they so value. At some point, they may need to pull in less theoretical and more hands-on people to lend practical perspective.

Personality theories often refer to Intuitive types, such as Debaters and other Analysts, as “open-minded.” However, they’re open-minded largely in that they can see many options, which sometimes gives them the appearance of flexibility. Yet Debaters and other Analysts can be as stubborn or rigid as anybody else with ideas and obsessions – perhaps more. Such stubbornness can be especially problematic among Debater and Analyst coworkers if they believe their pet arguments are unassailable. Even when they’re right about an idea, it doesn’t necessarily fit all situations; as the adage goes, “When one only has a hammer, everything looks like a nail.” Rather than pushing ideas that aren’t relevant to a work situation or accepted by the powers that be, Debater-Analyst teams may need to compromise their position.

Rebalancing Debater-Analyst Cooperation

Healthy Competition

Not all competition between Debaters and other Analysts is damaging. Any negative impact depends on the level of hostility; it’s more about the tone of the rivalry, such as malicious feelings or attitudes that might enter the contest. Sometimes

competition is healthy. Good ideas and outcomes can arise when coworkers try to outdo each other, if they can keep their actions goal-oriented. If such rivalry persists for a lengthy period or is defined by winning more than results, it can distract from the original purpose. Therefore, tone, attitude, and level of efficiency all determine the value of competition.

Self-awareness is one of the first steps for Debaters who wish to transform toxic work competition with other Analysts into a healthier approach. Awareness of their namesake tendency can help Debaters moderate their voices and use their openness to opportunistic perspectives for good. They can choose a contrary attitude to confirm their sense of being right, or they can choose to offer opposing viewpoints constructively, to add useful information or a significant new dimension to a plan. Self-awareness can provide choice, as well as freedom from impulsive arguments.

Setting up a system that fosters such insight can be a powerful tool for keeping toxic competition in check. The following method recognizes that the need to be right isn't in and of itself a terrible thing – if used in moderation, it can motivate Debaters in healthy ways. However, the more exclusively they focus on being right, the less likely they are to contribute in wholesome and effective ways. The exercise below isn't designed to pass judgment, but rather to increase mindful awareness of attitudes and their effects:

- Draw a horizontal line across an index card. On one end of the line, write, “Being right.” On the other, write, “Contributing.”
- Using an app or some other type of reminder tool, set a *random* alarm. Each time it goes off, take out the index card and ask yourself, “At this moment, where do my thoughts and focus fall on this continuum?” Do it for a week to make it a habit.

- Keep the card and use it as needed. Whenever an interaction feels tense and adversarial, take it out and think about your motivation and how it may be fueling a sense of competition.

If the personal need to triumph hinders measurable goals or even decelerates their progress, it can be objectively damaging. However, reasonable competition can be useful. If Debaters discover that “being right” motivates them too often, they may want to adjust their approach to ensure their value in the workplace.

Opening the Echo Chamber

Debaters and other Analysts sharing rational sensibilities at work can offer each other stimulation without having to wander too far from their comfort zones. With each reinforcing the other, they can create a sense of confidence or legitimacy around their ideas that isn’t always deserved. Just because an opinion is well-reasoned, it doesn’t necessarily make it useful, and Debater and Analyst coworkers can become stuck supporting notions that are worthless outside their bubbles. People often ignore theories that don’t have clear and measurable results. This is especially true in for-profit settings. Although such thoughts can be fun for Debaters and other Analysts to toss back and forth, if they become the primary focus or are mistaken for being useful, they can be detrimental.

In certain situations, Debater and Analyst coworkers may need to recognize when they’re stuck in a loop of their own mental indulgences – and then discover ways to break it. Here are some fundamental questions they can ask to expose useless intellectual exercises at work:

- What concrete and measurable results are likely to result from this line of thinking?

- How does this idea align with my organization's established vision or mission statement?
- How much resistance is the idea likely to receive? Rank it from one (received with joy and fanfare) to 10 (likely a deal-breaker when it comes to keeping this job). If the number is lower, the idea may be worth pursuing. Perhaps the number can even be improved if the idea is tweaked slightly.
- Has management or a peer reviewed the idea for its relevance? Are others onboard with the concept? Who has the authority to decide such things?

Sometimes the questions above may reveal that an idea can't or shouldn't move forward. Letting go can be the hardest thing, but the following suggestions can help:

- Recognize that shelving an idea doesn't say anything about its quality, nor does doing so measure your worth or the merit of the idea. Plans are most often adopted simply because they're in the right place at the right time.
- Give opposing or alternate views a fair hearing. Debaters can be defensive advocates for their ideas and may need to deliberately hold their tongues as they listen.
- Similarly, adopt a "Beginner's Mind." This Zen principle of approaching everything with a fresh set of eyes forces its practitioners to drop preconceptions – an obvious step for letting go when stuck in an unproductive cycle. Ask yourself, "If I was approaching this situation for the first time, what might I notice about it?" However, you need not abandon your experiences. Beginner's Mind involves using your experiences in a new way based on new perceptions or revised circumstances.

American poet Jeffrey McDaniel wrote, "I realize there's something incredibly honest about trees in winter, how they're experts at letting things go." Debaters aren't always

so good at releasing their pet notions. However, letting go is a useful skill that they can learn and develop, with many potential benefits. For example, it can save time spent in futile endeavors, as well as conserve personal energy and mental capacity. It also may help them when they find themselves trapped with Analyst coworkers in an echo chamber of ideas.

Debater-Diplomat Cooperation



Debaters and Diplomat coworkers share the Intuitive trait, which lends them a sense of connection regardless of any differences they may have. A kinship emerges from their collective ability to see beyond the obvious. Their differences are as likely to offer wholesome balance as they are to cause conflict – it depends on their willingness to work together and to appreciate one another’s gifts and preferences.

Balanced Debater-Diplomat Cooperation

Some Common Methods

Debaters and Diplomats prefer discussing the “big picture” rather than small details. Small talk may bore even the most social among them. Both absorb new knowledge

almost subconsciously and then incorporate it into a larger constellation of Intuitive understanding. They're imaginative and creative as they connect the dots, often in intense and unexpected ways.

Their similarities, along with their shared love of unconventional thinking, give Debaters and Diplomats plenty of opportunities to combine their talents on common ground. Both are statistically rare, and they're likely to recognize that they're dissimilar from most colleagues – depending on the job, as some positions attract more Intuitive people than others. However, in the average workplace, Diplomats and Debaters may find that they enjoy the uncommon conversations they have with each other, discovering a stimulating level of compatibility they don't often encounter. Although they may focus on different topics while brainstorming, they both are typically adept at producing copious novel ideas when called on to do so. They're likely to quickly identify each other as “idea people.”

Complementary Perspectives

Debaters are comfortable with systems and puzzles, and they value innovation over all else. They excel at working things out, at least to the extent that they offer theories toward that end. Diplomats add to Debaters' offerings by bringing humanity to their operations. Diplomats can provide “soul” to the systems that Debaters devise or innovate. To say that Debaters are defined by a lack of humanity and that Diplomats are bereft of analytical skills, though, is an oversimplification. Rather than supplementing each other in any complete fashion, each serves to remind the other of considerations that otherwise receive lower priority. When Debaters enthusiastically push ideas forward, Diplomats can remind them that people need adjustment periods before they accept big changes. Debaters, on the other hand, can help Diplomats more easily handle any drama occurring on the job.

In the workplace, this might play out as a wholesome push and pull between the logical and the compassionate. As Debaters help their Diplomat coworkers to stay on the path of rational thought and effectiveness, Diplomats return the favor by softening blunt edges and remembering those they're doing it all for. A great product without sensitive customer service is likely to acquire a bad reputation. Then again, what's the point of outstanding customer service if the product or service isn't viable?

Unbalanced Debater-Diplomat Cooperation

When Efficiency Hinders Support

As much as their Intuition binds them, Debaters and Diplomats still have pronounced differences. Debaters' rapid-fire ideas may not always consider how others might react – a concern that's often prominent for Diplomats. Therefore, if they settle for inflexibility and intolerance, their relationship can be problematic. Unless they seek a middle ground that honors efficiency and innovation yet also shows respect for the feelings, sensibilities, and esteem of others involved, these two may retreat to their own corners and stubbornly insist that the other is wrong.

For example, Debaters may see a project as hindered by those who are slower to accept change, believing that the best approach would be to force them to move forward or remove them from the loop entirely. Their fixation on their ideas may pull Debaters away from more sensitive plans that call for patience and allow other people time to adjust on a psychological level. On the other hand, Diplomats may spend too much time worrying about the feelings and concerns of others, bogging down progress. Cue a lot of impatience on both sides.

Blunt and Gentle Expressions

Debaters and Diplomats may also find that their outward expressions are points of contention. When dealing with people who don't see things their way, Debaters can be brusque and impatient, frustrating and disappointing Diplomats. Diplomats tend to avoid conflict, so they may disengage if their Debater detractors come across as too harsh or condescending. However, Diplomats may take a stand if they believe Debaters' attitudes are hurtful to others' feelings or welfare.

To be clear, Debaters aren't uncaring people, and their bluntness is often delivered in a spirit of support. But they rarely see the point of sugar-coating their solutions or objections just to spare others' feelings. Their version of truth or reality comes before such considerations. This can easily create tension between them and those wearing the label of "Diplomat." As rationally intelligent as Debaters strive to be, and as social as they are, they're notorious for lacking emotional intelligence. Whereas Debaters have no problem with (or even enjoy) criticism and debate, Diplomats are acutely sensitive to contentious words and may shut down.

Rebalancing Debater-Diplomat Cooperation

Starting with Understanding

Debaters who hope to sync with Diplomats at work may want to discover what values are essential to Diplomats. Learning what motivates them can bridge an understanding gap. That doesn't mean surrendering their Debater styles or positions; rather, it draws on that which Debaters value – acquiring information to draw conclusions. To do so, however, they may need to deliberately open themselves to such information rather than assume that they already have a read on their

compassionate colleagues. It's easy to stereotype those who are different – perhaps as “bleeding hearts” in this case – and to go no further in understanding them.

It may be easier for Debaters and Diplomats to connect at work if they remember that they both want to make a difference. Their motivations, methods, and desired results may be dissimilar, but they share the intention of making things better. Once they identify that common ground, they can explore the details with the essential journalistic questions: who, what, when, where, why, and how. The answers may help them reach a deeper level of appreciation of each other's opinions and ideas. It's OK to disagree; in fact, with their diverse styles, Debaters and Diplomats may work together best if they agree to disagree on some issues. But that shouldn't excuse either from making attempts to understand the other with the goal of having a better working relationship.

Those who are interested in better understanding can try a five-minute time-out from judgment. Debaters can perform the following simple approach to gaining insight on their own (without necessarily discussing it with their Diplomat coworkers), or they may ask Diplomats to be entirely in on it:

- The goal is simple: non-judgmental data collection.
- Pick a mutual work topic to ask questions about.
- Establish a short period of time when you will suspend judgment (e.g., five minutes).
- Statements aren't allowed, nor are questions that make your Diplomat coworker defend their positions. For example, “Do you really think that's the right approach?” is a forbidden question. Think like a non-interfering anthropologist or sociologist who is trying to collect information without influencing the

direction of the native population. Or perhaps take on the persona of an objective journalist.

- Borrow heavily from the journalistic questions and fire away.
- After time is up, take a moment to write a nonjudgmental paragraph describing the Diplomat's positions to memorialize them as more than just passing thoughts. If the Diplomat is in on the exercise, perhaps ask them to review the description for accuracy.

Those who pursue the five-minute time-out from judgment may experience two things. First, they may gain a focused, better, and purer understanding of their coworkers' opinions or ideas, free from interpretation and their own filters. Therefore, any arguments and disagreements can be based on a more complete understanding. Second, they may feel they've been heard and that their ideas are valued, which can strengthen working relationships.

Learning the Language of Diplomacy

Debaters can't change the nature of their more sensitive coworkers, but they may do themselves and their organizations a service by accepting that Diplomats' sensitivity has value even in the most impersonal workplaces. Furthermore, learning to soften their sometimes-blunt speech can go a long way toward supporting coworkers who bring a more human element to the table. The absence of such people would severely diminish human resources departments and customer service – just two of the many areas that would be impacted negatively by a world without Diplomats.

Debaters who learn to put a social buffer around their starker offerings can take giant steps toward simpatico work relationships. A car may need time to warm up on a cold morning; similarly, conversations sometimes need a friendly connection before

getting down to brass tacks. When Debaters show more social grace and positivity to Diplomat colleagues, rather than challenges or contention, over time they usually see a blossoming of productive communication and cooperation. Debaters need not force warmth or platitudes, but they can tap into their own sense of curiosity to reach out to Diplomats with a basic conversation exercise:

- Greet Diplomats with a smile.
- Ask how their day is going.
- Give them a few moments to talk about themselves before replying.
- Pick some aspect of their responses and reply complementarily. For example, if they talk about something positive they've been doing, say something like, "Wow, that's cool!" If their response is a complaint, perhaps reply, "Ugh, that really sucks!" or, "I know that must be rough for you."
- Instead of giving "me" or "I" statements, even if they're related, stay focused on what these coworkers are saying.
- After showing some interest in their day, make an excuse to move on with work. ("I've got to get back to work, but it was good to talk with you!")
- When there's a work matter to bring up, use a short version of this exercise instead of immediately launching into business.

It's essential for Debaters not to view themselves as deficient just because they don't place as much emphasis on social niceties in the workplace as others do. Their way has its merits. However, practicing skills that let them relate better to Diplomats can create the efficient communication Debaters crave. A pinch of sugar can keep ideas and facts flowing freely, getting both back to their shared creative ground.

Debater-Sentinel Cooperation



Debaters and Sentinels have fundamental differences in their intent and methods. Debaters love to experiment with the potential of a system, whereas Sentinels attend to straightforward business in the here and now, performing practical tasks and building order to support established goals. When a job suits them, Debaters and Sentinels may gravitate toward different yet complementary roles. When they marry their approaches cheerfully and respectfully, they can move mountains.

Balanced Debater-Sentinel Cooperation

Implementing Solutions Together

In some ways, this is a wonderful workplace match, as Debaters often need people to help them realize their visions, and Sentinels tend to act efficiently and effectively. Debaters are masters of thought but not always follow-through, so partnering with Sentinels can help them refine their ideas and yield practical results. When Debaters reveal a novel idea, Sentinels cautiously start examining the applications – and costs – in the real world, nicely balancing Debaters' often passionate embrace of the new.

Translating broader ideas into specific realities is reversible, in that such an approach can reveal solutions to more conventional problems in return. When Sentinels run up against a roadblock, Debaters may offer unconventional thinking to get things back on track. Imagination can be the tonic that cures outdated or ineffective practices used by Sentinels. The two become invaluable partners when both accept each other's unique strengths and make their unique contributions to productivity.

Future Planning

Another area of balance Debaters and Sentinels offer each other on the job is future thinking and planning. Debaters virtually live in a realm of possibility, always thinking about how to craft the future. Sentinels try to control the present, creating stability in the face of the unknown. They make plans mostly in the context of how they can act in the present to bring about security. When Debaters share their own forward-looking views, Sentinels see more possibilities than they might on their own, and together they can make mutually agreeable plans.

Debaters often bounce from idea to idea, their attention scattered between enthusiasm and curiosity. Their Sentinel coworkers can help them slow down and channel their creative energy in workable, focused directions. Cooperation between the two enables Debaters to picture smart shortcuts and spot hidden obstacles, while Sentinels plot the course of action. When Debaters' imaginative vision shapes the plans made operational by Sentinels, the workplace benefits from the best of both worlds: innovation and consistency.

Unbalanced Debater-Sentinel Cooperation

The Possibility Gap

Unfortunately, the ways Debaters and Sentinels balance each other's tendencies also have darker potential. Their profound differences can cause conflict if they don't consciously recognize each other's virtues and accept the value of cooperation. Debaters may be quick to criticize their Sentinel coworkers' ways when the Sentinels cling to methods and ideas that the Debaters feel are outdated. It's not necessarily out of malice; rather, rationality dominates Debaters' perspective, and their strident nature doesn't always leave room for tact when they express themselves.

One of the most likely breakdowns involves Debaters' love of theorizing. Their constant curiosity over "what ifs" can seem like wasted time to Sentinels, who may struggle to distinguish when Debaters are engaged in a mental exercise and when they're seriously offering a solution. If Sentinels shoot down inspired notions as "impractical" or "impossible," Debaters may take it as a personal affront. In turn, Debaters may view Sentinels as stubborn detractors, something they don't easily ignore. When Debaters resent Sentinels' staid thinking, and when Sentinels dismiss Debaters' ambitions as unreasonable, the tension can make them lose sight of the good they could otherwise do together.

Change Versus Convention

Debaters love change and constantly seek new ideas and areas for improvement. On some level, they crave change, as it represents growth and possibilities to them. Sentinels' combination of the Observant and Judging traits leads them to focus on proven standards and conventions, so they like to work with established ideas and methods. Although it would be too sweeping to say they're entirely averse to change,

they're perhaps the type least comfortable with it, and a lot depends on the pace and scale of the change.

Although their differences can help to balance Debaters and Sentinels, they can just as easily lead to tension and hostility, hindering productivity. Inflexibility and ignorance of the other person's motives – which both are sometimes guilty of – can lead group efforts astray. Debaters may push too hard against what they see as illogical worship of structure and consistency; to these visionary people, overemphasis on time-worn organization and consistency is merely a hindrance. And for their part, Sentinels may see discrediting norms as a threat to the order on which they rely. When each defends their own interests, antagonistic relationships can develop, which is never helpful in the workplace.

Rebalancing Debater-Sentinel Cooperation

The Proof in the Pudding

Debaters may never get Sentinels to match their own imaginative thinking, but that isn't the only way to find balance. Debaters should understand that Sentinels aren't as impressed by theory as they are demonstration – they want something to “take to the bank.” Results earn the cooperation of Sentinels. Debaters who prove their ideas through action gain credibility, which often garners them future support. Although turning their ideas into deeds may be a challenge for these theoreticians, it's an almost inescapable challenge in the workplace, but it is well worth trying to meet. With most people, a good concrete example can far outweigh a barrage of abstract words almost every time.

Sentinels appreciate predictability, so when Debaters build a track record of successful ideas, they also earn the right to ask for a reasonable leap of faith now

and then. Sentinels are generally risk-averse. But past events factor heavily into their judgment, and respected Debaters can draw Sentinels beyond their boundaries by reassuringly pointing to reinforcing examples along the way.

When Debaters are sharing ideas with Sentinels, a simple presentation exercise can help.

- Describe the goal – the value of making the change, as well as what success looks like.
- Highlight the specific benefits, possible risks, and how pitfalls can be mitigated.
- Outline the steps clearly – what it takes in real terms of human effort, training, funding, and time.
- Cite similar ideas that were successful in the past. Focus on the positive outcomes that were achieved, like higher sales numbers or increased efficiency, and how risks were addressed or proven to be unfounded.
- Maintain the congenial, respectful tone of responsible peers planning together.
- Take ownership of the idea by offering to lead in implementing it, and then create the proof of benefit.

Debaters may not enjoy feeling like they must defend their imaginations, but the reality of many workplaces is that visionary thinkers often must do just that. However, professional success is far more likely to come when they gain the support of those with a more conventional outlook, and it's strategically worth the effort.

One Step at a Time

Change, especially when based on ambitious theories and ideas, can make Sentinels uncomfortable. Debaters who are aware of their Sentinel coworkers' concerns can find more support when they link their ideas and theories to practical, specific tasks.

When suggesting changes to a system, such as a company's hiring process, Debaters who bring forward ideas based on modern hiring theories may be met with skepticism from Sentinel coworkers. But highlighting specific, practical tasks (for example, changes to the interviewing process and staff training procedures for those involved in the new process) increases Debaters' odds of garnering favor with Sentinels.

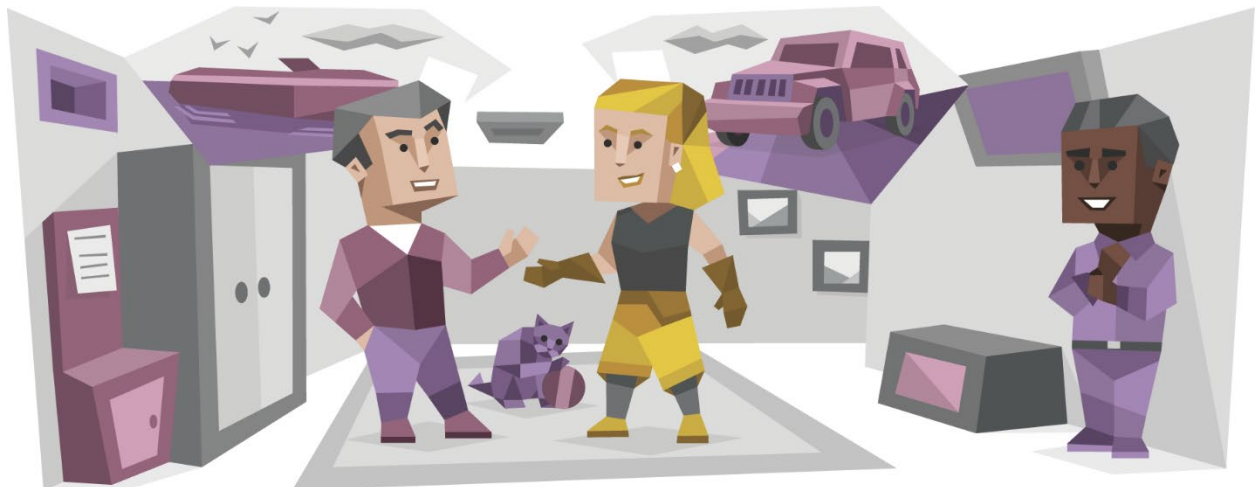
Allowing plenty of time for change to take place – an opportunity for people to verify and appreciate the benefits of each stage – can also build support from Sentinels. Vocal impatience from overeager Debaters may bring out stubborn resistance from even the most supportive Sentinels if they feel that too many things are changing too quickly. To remedy this, Debaters can focus on remaining calm and focused – suggesting smaller, specific changes, then sequentially reshaping things in stages, even when the overall combined effect is significant.

- Break more substantial changes into smaller parts with verifiable short-term targets. (For instance, instead of redesigning an entire retail department, alter just a few displays.)
- Complete each change only for the sake of its own merits.
- Track the results. (Those display changes boosted sales – or not.)
- Be willing to admit when something doesn't work.
- Create a plan to undo and learn from flops. After all, knowing what didn't work and why enables better ideas in the future.
- Roll successes forward into additional, related suggestions to subtly create ongoing progress. (Perhaps expand similar merchandising changes into other areas, too.)

- Incorporate Sentinels' feedback in each stage – they may very well uncover practical issues, and Debaters can use the information to improve a process or project.
- Emphasize the teamwork involved and the value of making productive changes together: “Look what we accomplished!”

Sensible change is a good thing in business, and Debaters can work toward such change while respecting Sentinels as they provide the “sensible” pieces of the puzzle. When change is paced and balanced between innovation and proven standards, coworkers can maintain reliability without losing all-important progress.

Debater-Explorer Cooperation



On the surface, Debaters and Explorers may seem to have little in common, but the truth is more complicated. Yes, Debaters enjoy theorizing about ideas and solutions, whereas Explorers would rather do things through hands-on engagement without incessantly pondering and playing with intangible ideas. The former is motivated by expansive rationality and the latter by a constant search for novelty, experiences, and impromptu solutions. However, they share an adaptive outlook on things, which

gives them a lot of ways to collaborate. When a new problem defies old solutions, both can shift their perspectives quickly.

Balanced Debater-Explorer Cooperation

Combining Vision with Action

Debaters and Explorers can create excellent working relationships when they tap into each other's strengths. They often work well in a two-stage process: Debaters generating new ideas, and Explorers boosting their combined impetus to get to work. Debaters don't always jump into motion, partly because they're more comfortable with theory, but their slower action is more than balanced by Explorers' bias toward action. The two may fall into sync quickly, with Debaters' imaginations excited by Explorers' readiness to engage.

"What if" can be a powerful bond when these two work together. When an idea appeals to both, the chance to discover what might be is an irresistible lure that makes things happen. Debaters revel in potentials but often find the earthy "give it a go" attitude of Explorer coworkers a very refreshing step into reality – it calls for functional experimentation with little restriction. Intellectual energy fuels tangible output when these two take on projects in a balanced way together.

Discovery Unleashed

Due to their shared Prospecting trait, Debaters and Explorers usually don't feel bound by convention. Neither may even give much thought to it. Whether experimenting with a new budget strategy or introducing a new series of entrées on a restaurant menu, these mentally flexible people leave no stone unturned in their pursuit of better outcomes. Debaters see potential everywhere, and Explorers gladly

try out exciting ideas regardless of whether they're theirs or someone else's, making this team adept at opening new and sometimes unexpected doors.

Their willingness to innovate and engage new practices can be profoundly beneficial, especially when they're part of a larger team with other qualities blended in. Their genuine sense of curiosity not only creates options for the future but also inspires contagious energy in their professional environments. The new ideas and methods that Debaters and Explorers brew together can be a refreshing concoction for any business, updating old practices that may have taken hold.

Unbalanced Debater-Explorer Cooperation

Impractical Meets Impulsive

Although Debaters and Explorers can work together well, the combination does face potential problems. Explorers' focus on the present may chafe Debaters, who may see such matters as mundane. Debaters sometimes dismiss out of hand people who deal in applied solutions, out of a preference for more visionary ideas. They usually do so by explaining why the status quo is inferior to the ideas they hold. When they voice their disdain as direct criticism, communication can quickly shut down.

If Debaters' way of thinking is too vague and impractical for too long, Explorers may see them as unrealistic, unintelligible, and disengaged from "real life" in any practical way. Explorers aren't known for impulse control, so when their frustration builds, they may suddenly lose patience. That might mean dismissing Debaters, withdrawing support, or just criticizing them outright. When the two become unhappy with each other, Debaters may resort to arrogance, and Explorers typically move forward however they see fit, ignoring Debaters as necessary. Dysfunction naturally ensues.

A Pair of Wanderers

Debaters often meander in the vastness of their own minds, and Explorers frequently get sidetracked in the experiences of the moment; both are highly distractible, so when they work together, getting off-target is a real possibility. Without some oversight, they may do each other a disservice when their shared curiosity gets out of balance. They risk sharing exciting – but not necessarily productive – things together. In most job roles, such tangential behavior causes performance to suffer and potentially gets employees into trouble.

What makes this worrisome is that neither is likely to have the skills to pull themselves back into focus. They may subconsciously lead each other into immature irresponsibility, as Debaters' unbridled creativity can become enthusiastic, experimental floundering, and Explorers may fall victim to short-sighted, spontaneous decision-making. Without something to inspire consistency, they may find themselves starting much and finishing little.

Rebalancing Debater-Explorer Cooperation

Respecting Different Types of Genius

Genius comes in many forms, and it's crucial for Debaters to appreciate Explorers' preference for hands-on execution. Even though Explorers' focus on practical matters in the moment may seem limited, success can hinge on their attention to the finer points. Debaters should understand that Explorers are great at concrete problem-solving and responding flexibly enough to meet challenges as "boots on the ground" without many preconceptions. This nicely balances Debaters' tendency to overvalue – and thus overemphasize – their abstract ideas and visions of the future.

To understand Explorers' hands-on approach in more positive ways, Debaters can put their own hands into the mix. Participating not just in Explorers' projects but also in their methods and ways of thinking can help Debaters understand the value of other approaches. Explorers are incredibly independent, so Debaters may need to avoid monitoring or judging them by their own standards. If approached in the right spirit and tone, such learning can enable cooperation, as well as increase Debaters' knowledge with revelatory new insights – something they can't get enough of. Debaters can engage such opportunities with little planning by trying this exercise.

- Watch for opportunities to step in and offer help as a collaborative equal.
- Get to know the Explorer's workflow and methods. Adopt a novice's rather than an expert's perspective.
- Ask for demonstrations – the chance to teach a willing student can enthuse anyone.
- Try out their suggestions and practices, under their direction.
- Respect what works, even if it's a different way of doing things.

Both Debaters and Explorers focus on efficiency, just in different ways – one wrangling concepts within their minds and defending them when necessary, the other manipulating the tangible with an eye toward results. Both can better address any problems by understanding the valuable qualities that each brings to the table and knowing that cooperation is a decision.

Guiding Each Other in the Right Direction

To get their wandering attention and enthusiastic distraction under control, Debaters and Explorers can help each other attend to tasks at hand. Multitasking is often required in today's complex workplace, but people vulnerable to losing focus may

need to find ways to deliberately narrow their concentration so as not to get swept away by tangents.

By following a chosen framework together (such as the one below), Debaters and Explorers may also be able to prevent any supervisory crackdown that would hamper them – taking personal steps toward discipline may help them preserve their autonomy. However, while finding their own answers to distractibility, Debaters may need to be sensitive to Explorers' need for independence, perhaps offering suggestions broadly and with an eye toward flexibility. It may be better to use the principles below as a group standard rather than as a standard to be adopted by only certain people, to take pressure off reluctant Explorers. Tailoring a bespoke system to suit their job tasks is up to the parties involved, but some methods to consider can include the following.

- Sequential conditionality: The start of a new venture depends on completing a previous commitment. If you don't have too many balls in the air at once, you will be less likely to drop one.
- Supportive oversight: Not being left to your own devices can help you curtail constant distraction. If you cheerfully – and briefly – help each other stay focused, even individual tasks can feel like a team effort.
- Mutual assistance: Cement a positive working relationship by backing each other when you've gotten off course. It's important that this doesn't become one-sided, however – only if both individuals contribute equally will both remain willing to lend their efforts when needed. "Mutual" is the keyword.
- Accountability: Debaters and Explorers likely need external oversight to keep them accountable for their progress. So, commit to completion times and goals, and report to a third party. Management often provides this naturally, but easily

distracted workers might also benefit from more casual peer accountability or cooperative project management arrangements where standards are enforced. (The latter technique is likely to be the least favorite or least sustainable for Debaters and Explorers – but it may still be worth considering.)

Whatever plan these two come up with to boost each other's dedication and focus works best when it's specific and straightforward, therefore easier to stick to. Neither Debaters nor Explorers enjoy rigid structure, but they likely need some degree of systemic organization and accountability to keep them on track and to lead them to practical results.

Conclusion

Nineteenth-century American journalist Charles A. Dana said, "Fight for your opinions, but don't believe that they contain the whole truth, or the only truth." A common difficulty for Debaters in the workplace – and in life – involves cherishing their own perspective a bit too much. As Dana asserted, there's nothing wrong with defending their opinions if they understand the limits of their own thinking and perspective.

This unique type has much to offer any enterprise. Debaters lean toward innovation and original thought. Imaginative and curious, they're passionate about their interests and ideas – at least when those views are on their front burners. If they can keep their occasionally contentious attitudes in check, they can be quite charismatic and social assets in any workplace. Allowed to run wild and unfettered, they can be difficult to work with, making success elusive. But if they can harness their strengths, they have many skills and talents to offer.

Debaters' greatest work challenge may be to find ways to balance the unique beauty and wonder of their impressive creativity so that it's more in sync with a practical world that typically demands something different. It's well within their ability – and may simply be a matter of awareness and will.

Additional Tools and Tests

Want to dig even deeper into your professional development? If you have access to the toolkits area of the website, we offer a variety of additional tools and tests to help you explore.

Job Preferences Test

Among the most important things you decide in life is how you're going to make a living. Discover which job fields fit you best.

Job Burnout Test

We've all heard the term "burnout." But what does it mean to you? This test will guide you as you take a look at how burnout affects you.

Career Values Test

What should your job look like for you to call it "ideal"? What aspects matter most to you? This tool will help you answer these questions.

Leadership Styles Test

What is your leadership style? There is no right or wrong answer to that question. This test will help clarify your preferred approach.

Leadership Styles II Test

The second part of our Leadership Styles test will explore your desire to be a leader and willingness to delegate power.

Motivation Test

On average, we work for about 90,000 hours over our lifetime. With that in mind, it's helpful to figure out exactly what motivates you.

Ambition Test

How eager are you to succeed, and at what cost? Ambition can be a double-edged sword – explore how it works in your case.

Professional Authenticity Test

When at work, are you acting in a way that is consistent with your true self? Explore difficult questions about authenticity with this test.

Goal Orientation Test

What's the underlying motivation you feel when confronting a challenge? See which of the Goal Orientations influences you most.

Type Guesser (Workplace)

Are you trying to figure out what personality type your coworker belongs to? You may find that this simple tool helps.

Final Words



The Paradoxical Extravert

Debaters lead a paradoxical existence. Although they are true Extraverts who want to engage the world and the people in it, they struggle to connect either to the matters roiling their minds. Because of this tension, they often foist their imaginative thinking on unprepared or reluctant people – they engage the world, but in their own idiosyncratic ways. Though Debaters want to connect to outside ideas, their willingness to protect that connection can falter if it means compromising on a position or a belief. People with this personality type will bluntly and ferociously argue their points. Consider the time-tested question asked in self-help circles: “Would you rather be right, or would you rather be loved?” Debaters want both – but often prioritize the first.

Debaters who keep and protect their own counsel in their paradoxical world have pronounced advantages. The gift of the Debater style is independence, and with independence come innovation and creativity. It takes a certain rebellious spirit to

ignite the creative process, and Debaters have no trouble engaging in intellectual rebellion. They don't mind being the rebel, and it frees them to innovate.

Still, There's Balance

That said, Debaters may still decide that they can benefit from expanding themselves beyond their tendencies. They may find it effective to offset some of their bluntness with diplomacy. And maybe there are times to be right and times to be loved, each deserving a place in their lives as well as adequate attention to preserve both. Sometimes people are limited by the false dichotomies they set up. Things don't have to be "either/or."

Although it's a common fear, Debaters won't lose their independence or blunt their mental acuity by growing emotionally. Living with more emotional intelligence is well within the reach of Debaters who wish to round out their lives. Meanwhile, they can still look at the world in their unique way and build compelling arguments for ideas that are refreshing and system-shaking. They can have and use both if they focus and apply effort. It's not about changing; it's about growing.

The Road Ahead

We've covered many different topics in this profile, and we hope that the chapters have offered insight and answered questions about the Debater personality type. We hope that readers will now find it easier to understand other people and their perspectives. This profile isn't meant to be read just once. When trying to understand another person better, or struggling to understand oneself, another read-through can offer fresh insight.

Furthermore, spend some time on our [website](#) – for example, by exploring our [articles](#) or additional [Tools & Assessments](#). If you lead a team, our [Team Assessments](#) can help you understand its unique dynamics. There is a wealth of inspiring advice and information on the website, and we strongly recommend that you take a look. If you have some spare time, consider lending us a helping hand by taking additional [surveys](#) or simply [sending us a message](#) and sharing your thoughts about this profile or the website in general. We would love to hear from you.

We wish the best of luck to all Debaters. What matters most in Debaters' lives is that their paths through life reflect who they are, deep within. Our lives are often too full of troubles, conflicts, and worries. By working to better understand each other, we can make our relationships, communities, and world more aware, more genuine, and more peaceful.

Until next time.

Addendum: The Puzzle of Personality

Often the very first question people ask after completing our personality test is “What do these letters mean?” We are of course referring to those mysterious acronyms like INTJ-A, ENFP-T, or ESTJ-A. As you may have already learned from the Type Descriptions or articles on the website, the five letters of these acronyms each refer to a specific trait, with certain trait combinations forming various types and type groups. But before we discuss those traits in depth, let’s explore their historical foundations.

The Historical Detour

Since the dawn of time, humans have drawn up schematics to describe and categorize our personalities. From the four temperaments of the ancient civilizations to the latest advances in psychology, we have been driven to fit the variables and complexities of human personality into well-defined models. Although we are still some time away from being able to do that, the current models account for our most important personality traits and can predict our behavior with a high degree of accuracy.

Personality is just one of many factors that guide our behavior, however. Our actions are also influenced by our environment, our experiences, and our individual goals. On our website, we describe how people belonging to a specific personality type are likely to behave. We outline indicators and tendencies, however, not definitive guidelines or answers. Significant differences can exist even among people who share a personality type. The information on this website is meant to inspire personal

growth and an improved understanding of yourself and your relationships – not to be taken as gospel.

Our approach has its roots in two different philosophies. One dates back to early 20th century and was the brainchild of Carl Gustav Jung, the father of analytical psychology. Jung's theory of psychological types is perhaps the most influential creation in personality typology, and it has inspired a number of different theories. One of Jung's key contributions was the development of the concept of Introversion and Extraversion – he theorized that each of us falls into one of these two categories, either focusing on the internal world (Introvert) or the outside world (Extravert). Besides Introversion and Extraversion, Jung coined the concept of so-called cognitive functions, separated into Judging or Perceiving categories. According to Jung, each person prefers one of these cognitive functions and may most naturally rely on it in everyday situations.

In the 1920s, Jung's theory was noticed by Katharine Cook Briggs, who later co-authored a personality indicator still used today, the Myers-Briggs Type Indicator® (MBTI®). Briggs was a teacher with an avid interest in personality typing, having developed her own type theory before learning of Jung's writings. Together with her daughter, Isabel Briggs Myers, they developed a convenient way to describe the order of each person's Jungian preferences – this is how four-letter acronyms were born.

Of course, this is just a very simplified description of the Myers-Briggs theory. Readers interested in learning more should read *Gifts Differing: Understanding Personality Type* by Isabel Briggs Myers. As we define personality traits and types differently in our model, we will not go deeper into Jungian concepts or related theories in this article.

Due to its simplicity and ease of use, the four-letter naming model has been embraced by a number of diverse theories and approaches over the last few decades, including frameworks such as Socionics, Keirsey Temperament Sorter, Linda Berens' Interaction Styles, and many others. While the acronyms used by these theories may be identical or very similar, however, their meanings do not always overlap. One of the reasons behind such a lengthy introduction is that we want to make it clear that there is no single definition assigned to these type acronyms – each theory defines them in their own way and it is entirely possible that if you meet five people who all say “I am an INFJ”, their definitions of what INFJ means are going to differ.

Types vs. Traits

Regardless of its structure, any type-based theory will struggle to describe or characterize people whose scores lie near the dividing line. A different way to look at personalities is through the lens of a trait-based rather than a type-based model. What do we mean by that? Instead of creating an arbitrary number of categories and attempting to fit people within them, a trait-based model simply studies the degree to which people exhibit certain traits.

You may have heard the term Ambivert, which is a perfect example in this case. Ambiversion means that someone falls in the middle of the Introversion-Extraversion scale, being neither too outgoing nor too withdrawn. Trait-based theories would simply say that an Ambivert is moderately Extraverted or moderately Introverted and leave it at that, without assigning a personality type.

A trait-based approach makes it easier to reliably measure correlations between personality traits and other characteristics – for example, political attitudes. This is

why trait-based approaches dominate psychometric research, but that's more or less the only area where these approaches are dominant. Because they don't offer types or categorizations, trait-based theories don't translate as well as type-based theories into specific recommendations and takeaways. Assigned categories such as Extravert or Introvert may be limiting, but they allow us to conceptualize human personality and create theories about why we do what we do – something that a more scientifically reliable but colorless statement, such as you are 37% Extraverted, simply cannot do.

Our Approach

With our NERIS® model, we've combined the best of both worlds. We use the acronym format introduced by Myers-Briggs for its simplicity and convenience, with an extra letter to accommodate five rather than four scales. However, unlike Myers-Briggs or other theories based on the Jungian model, we have not incorporated Jungian concepts such as cognitive functions, or their prioritization. Jungian concepts are very difficult to measure and validate scientifically, so we've instead chosen to rework and rebalance the dimensions of personality called the Big Five personality traits, a model that dominates modern psychological and social research.

Our personality types are based on five independent spectrums, with all letters in the type code (e.g. INFJ-A) referring to one of the two sides of the corresponding spectrum. You can see where you fall on each scale by completing our free personality assessment, NERIS Type Explorer®. This approach has allowed us to achieve high test accuracy while also retaining the ability to define and describe distinct personality types.

Five Personality Aspects

This section will describe five personality aspects that, when combined, define the personality type: Energy, Mind, Nature, Tactics and Identity. Each of these aspects should be seen as a two-sided continuum, with the “neutral” option placed in the middle. The percentages you would have seen after completing the test are meant to show which categories you fall under, and how strong your preferences are.

Let us now go through the personality aspects one by one:

Introverted vs. Extraverted

More Than People Power

When considering people who are Introverts (I) and Extraverts (E), it's natural to go straight to the more social aspects of these personality traits. However, they are more than this. These traits are also defined by their broader response to their environments, which includes other people but isn't exclusively about them.

Introvert (I) Personality

Strength in Reserve

Introverts are well-suited to many situations. A tendency to be reserved helps these personality types to pace themselves. They're likely to listen to others more carefully. Very introspective, Introverts enjoy more focused “alone time” – leading to more and deeper insights. And, while sometimes too sensitive to their environments, this often helps them pick up cues more quickly, making them great at reading many situations.

However, this same reserve means that Introverts tend to find outside stimuli like noise, motion, or intrusive lighting frustrating. Some of this can be an invigorating change of pace – too much unsettles them and drains their energy. These personality types often prefer to be in their own space where they can adjust their environments. Add a human factor to this sensitivity – for example, insistent conversations where they're expected to be just as insistent – and it can exhaust them. They need time alone to regather their energy and restore their calm.

Introverts' reserved, more solitary nature presents challenges, as many societies favor Extraverts and their bolder approach. But it helps Introverted personality types to take things slowly, cautiously, and with less fanfare. Fortunately, if they're willing – and create the time to recharge on their own – most Introverts can handle society's strenuous demands.

In fact, many successful leaders and entertainers come from their ranks, often remaining humble and avoiding an unnecessary spotlight in fame. The Introversion personality trait never needs to disqualify those who possess it from pursuing a goal.

Extravert (E) Personality

The Power of Engagement

Extraverts are interested in engaging with their environment, and they feed off the responses of the people and events around them. They enjoy pushing limits and seeing what the world can do. This all depends on many other factors and life's natural limitations, but Extraverted personality types lean toward taking the initiative and relying on the world around them for validation.

While all of this is noble and often admired in society, it can also become unbridled. Extraverts may put too much value in their engagement with those around them. Being with others can be so important to these personalities that they often find it difficult if they're stuck alone. Boredom comes too easily. This can lead them to do things simply for excitement rather than thinking through more subtle but important considerations. Becoming the center of attention – at any cost – might be too appealing.

However, when they suitably address these challenges, Extraverts are forces to be reckoned with. People with this personality trait tend to advance projects important to them quickly, whether personal or professional. They often choose to lead when given a chance – and can be dynamic in that role. Their outgoing energy can be vital to a social gathering, and their liveliness can be contagious. And there always remains a sense that people are important to them.

Intuitive vs. Observant

Thought at Every Scale

Our second personality scale includes the Intuitive (N) and Observant (S) styles. These traits describe what people are more likely to do with the information gathered from the world around them. Intuitive personality types rely on imagining the past and future potential of what they see. Those with the Observant style are more interested in observable facts and more straightforward outcomes. They prefer to avoid layering too much interpretation on what they see.

Being Intuitive doesn't mean someone can't be practical, and being Observant doesn't mean a lack of imagination. They both use their minds and their physical

senses well. The difference is the spin they put on their experiences – it's where their thinking goes after an encounter with their environment. If Intuitive personality types appreciate Observant types' practicality, and Observant personality types appreciate Intuitive types' imaginative perspective, they can complement each other in ways that make for unbeatable partnerships.

Intuitive (N) Personality

Eyes on the Horizon

People with the Intuitive trait prefer to exercise their imaginations as they seek new ideas and possibilities. They live their day-to-day lives just like any other personality type. But while that's happening, their minds tend to point inward while at the same time gently focusing somewhere beyond the horizon. Their lives are ones of questioning, wondering, and connecting the dots in the "bigger picture," and they love the theoretical. They often ask, "What if?" and ponder the possibilities the future might hold.

But Intuitive people aren't always the most practical, preferring instead to give things deeper meaning. There may be a long wait as these personality types allow their imaginations free rein. They may also leap in too quickly to more complex matters. An entire theory can come together in moments, leaving others confused. In either case, they can appear out of touch to the Observant individuals in their lives. For some Intuitive folk, there may be some truth to this observation.

That said, when there's a need for innovation or a different perspective, people with Intuitive personality types can usually step up and provide a new direction. Practicality can sometimes be overrated, especially when a situation calls for serious change and "coloring outside the lines." This is where Intuitive people shine. They

bring interesting dimensions to life beyond everyday ideas – and take those who decide to go along with them.

Observant (S) Personality

Do What Works

The phrase “real-time” was created with Observant individuals in mind. They’re most in touch with what occurs in front of them, in the present. This doesn’t mean Observant personality types have no regard for the past and future. But they view both from the perspective of how each influences their present actions. This makes them focused and practical people. They mostly root their thinking in the actionable, tangible, and useful. But make no mistake, these personalities can be creative within that realm.

One challenge people with the Observant personality trait may face is a too-narrow perspective. They may reject far-reaching solutions in favor of something more obvious. By continuing something that appears practical at arm’s length but doesn’t fit the bigger picture, they might reduce their hard work to busywork.

People with the Observant trait are often a steadying force that tends to get things done. Their energy is very “hands-on” in the sense of working on real things in real-time. While they’re often smart people, spending a lot of time sitting around and pondering possibilities doesn’t cut it for Observant personality types. They want thoughts and talk to lead to action.

Thinking vs. Feeling

How to Think and Feel About the Thinking and Feeling Traits

Our third, Nature scale reveals the extent to which we value emotions or rationality more when considering options. Does a person tend to use the Thinking (T) personality trait, which relies on the head, or the Feeling (F) trait, which relies on the heart?

But let's not oversimplify. Think of it instead as you might your hand preference: A left-handed person leans more heavily on their left hand, but they still use their right hand, albeit less. We can apply the same approach to a person with a dominant Thinking trait or a dominant Feeling trait – they aren't without some qualities of the non-dominant trait.

Thinking (T) Personality

"How Does This Help?"

When presented with a decision, people with the Thinking trait typically lean on objective information. Knowledge is their indispensable tool. Once these personality types gather the facts, they test their alternatives against logic and reason to see which decision, by those standards, proves the most effective or realistic. They generally manage their relationships by employing fairness and effectiveness as their primary method of dealing with others. Their passions are born of respect.

Whatever value people with the Thinking personality trait place on relationships, they can still dismiss emotional responses, either their own or those of others. This is often because of their discomfort with emotions, which don't always follow the rational path they value. Sometimes, emotions just puzzle them. But that doesn't

mean they have hearts of stone. They often feel in deep, profound ways – they would just rather not decide matters from that place. And, perhaps unfortunately, they may see those who do as weaker decision-makers.

Personality types with the Thinking trait are likely to evaluate things almost relentlessly. This isn't as bad as it sounds. They aren't satisfied if they believe something is not well thought out – they revel in the brilliance of an elegant plan. This makes them great to have around when critical thinking and impartiality of any kind is the focus, and this makes them immensely helpful for sorting out ideas and methods. Their primary filter is, *"How does this help?"*

Feeling (F) Personality

"Who Does This Help?"

People with the Feeling (F) trait follow their hearts and emotions – sometimes without even realizing it. They may show it to different degrees and in different ways, but however they do it, Feeling personality types tend to be caring, compassionate, and warm. These concerned people can be highly protective of those they care about – whether that is their immediate family or remote populations in need.

However, people with the Feeling personality trait often find they become excessive in their concern for others. They may easily burn out – or cause others to – when they become too involved. These emotionally aware individuals can become depressed if they feel they haven't been as selfless in life as they imagine they should be, or if those they have helped seem to fall down regardless.

Feeling personality types' concern for others typically affects all their endeavors. This can be practical and close, as with family, friends, and colleagues. Or it can be broader, as with world peace, ending hunger, and giving the disadvantaged a boost.

But this reliance on feelings doesn't mean there is no logic – theirs is just a different logic. They see that emotions can't simply be waved away, so feelings and the welfare of others shape their lives more than stark facts and cold objectivity. Weighing things this way makes these personalities valuable to have around when the big question is, “*Who does this help?*”

Judging vs. Prospecting

Crossing the Finish Line (By Whatever Means)

The Tactics scale, which includes the Judging and Prospecting personality traits, reflects how people plan and deal with the options they have. But this definition doesn't just concern what individuals write in their day planners. It's much broader. These traits answer questions like, “Do you prefer spontaneity or certainty?” “Do you feel more comfortable acting only with all your ducks lined neatly in a row? Or does a certain amount of flexibility or chaos excite you and prove motivating?” “Do you need more choices or fewer?”

Judging (J) Personality

Making Things as They Ought to Be

People with the Judging (J) personality trait feel most comfortable when the course ahead is well-marked. They would rather come up with five backup plans than deal with events as they come. Preferring to consider their options ahead of time,

personality types with this trait prefer clarity and closure, sticking with the plan rather than going with the flow. It's as if Judging types always keep a mental checklist. When they cross something off their list – or even start an item on their list – they consider it complete and not open to reconsideration.

The downside is, if they take this too far, those with the Judging trait sometimes come across as rigid. However, most are not unreasonably stubborn. It's important to remember their need for structure always is a preference and reality often calls on them to respond in unforeseen ways. Too many surprises in a row can leave these personality types frustrated and stressed. When this happens, they can still be relied on to develop a plan (and a contingency plan), but however well they handle the unexpected, they rarely enjoy it.

Judging individuals tend to have a strong work ethic, putting their duties and responsibilities above everything else. To them, rules, laws, and standards are the key to success. They can be too dependent on these measures, whether applied to themselves or others. But the intent is almost always one of fairness and results.

Prospecting (P) Personality

Figuring Things Out as They Go

Prospecting (P) individuals are much more flexible when it comes to dealing with unexpected challenges. This flexibility helps them seize unexpected opportunities as well. These personality types tend to react to their environments rather than try to control them, helping them to make their own luck in whatever the world delivers. People with this trait hold that life is full of possibilities.

All this opportunism can lead to impulsive decision-making, though. At the same time, they can be overwhelmed by the sheer number of options on their radar. People with the Prospecting personality trait can be slow to commit to something because of uncertainty or the potential of everything else. If they don't moderate this trait, indecision or a lack of conviction can be a problem. They can seem unfocused. What was important to them one week may be forgotten the next.

Despite those concerns, this personality trait can offer a great deal of creativity and productivity. Theirs is almost a stream of consciousness quality. In many ways, it's like these types are constantly brainstorming as their minds create a web of options. This can be a powerful tool for finding solutions. And if they aren't satisfied with something in their lives, it's easier for them to let go of it and choose something else. This can lead to serial passions that keep Prospecting individuals stimulated as they explore the buffet of choices always before them.

Assertive vs. Turbulent

Confidence, Achievement, and You

The Identity scale, made up of the Assertive and Turbulent personality traits, affects all other scales and indicates how confident we are in our abilities and decisions. Identity triggers the way we react to the things life constantly throws at us. How do we respond to success and failure? Criticism or feedback from other people? Unexpected events that suddenly change many things or everything? Even the unknown future?

Assertive (-A) Personality

Calm in the Storm

Assertive individuals are self-assured, even-tempered, and resistant to stress. They don't worry too much, but this is different from apathy. They aim for goals and want successful results, but they typically won't let nervousness color the path to their accomplishments. They're unlikely to spend a lot of time thinking about their past actions or choices. According to Assertive personality types, what's done is done.

However, problems may arise for them if their confidence turns into overconfidence. Assertive individuals may gloss over problems or details that can interfere with their goals and desired results. They may lean toward assuming all will be positive. Assertive people also sometimes presume they are free to do much more than others would allow or tolerate. If overconfident, these personality types may come to believe their confidence overshadows what others want.

But their confidence remains. It can help them move forward where others might hesitate. People with this personality trait report more satisfaction with their lives. They feel more assured of their abilities to handle the difficult and the unexpected. Through this lens, they often create the kinds of success that matter to them.

Turbulent (-T) Personality

Power of Stress, Activate!

Turbulent individuals are success-driven, perfectionistic, and eager to improve. They are always trying to counterbalance their self-doubts by achieving more. Just as they push themselves to become better, they're as likely to push their projects or efforts

in the same direction. Turbulent personality types tend to notice little problems and often do something about them before they become larger ones.

There are potential downsides to all this attention and achievement. Always feeling the need to do more, to have more, and to *be* more, Turbulent individuals can also get caught up in endless thoughts of criticisms, slights, or regrets. This can either bog them down or motivate them to do better. Their sensitivity to potential problems can be useful – unless that’s all they think about and the problems clutter their attention. Turbulent personality types may compulsively scan for what might go wrong instead of keeping their eyes on more positive targets – on what could go right.

Careful and attentive people are always important to society and keep it safe. At the same time, a fear of stagnation can bring about great change. Turbulent individuals beautifully cover both. When these personalities balance their worries and concerns with positive action, they’re likely to prove themselves to be of great value.

Type Groups

Now you know what each type consists of. But how do they fit together?

Our system has two layers: the first (inner) one defines our Roles, the second (outer) one – our Strategies.

Roles

Personality theory is a study of similarities among people with shared traits and how these traits might be expressed through behaviors and attitudes. Traits are the most fundamental part of our framework and include characteristics like Introversion or

Thinking. The next level contains personality types, in which four of the traits are combined and sorted to create 16 personality types. Roles, simply put, are the next level. At the Role level, the 16 types are divided into four groups.

Which personality types belong to each Role depends on two shared traits that they have in common. While all traits influence behaviors and attitudes, the two traits that determine a Role are shared by only four personality types and instill in them some unique, matching characteristics.

Those with the Intuitive trait (Analysts and Diplomats) are paired with the Thinking/Feeling traits because the Intuitive trait focuses on internal processes like thinking and feeling. While they may ultimately play out in the external world, they are primarily inward-looking.

In like manner, those with the Observant trait (Sentinels and Explorers) are paired with the Judging/Prospecting traits. Judging and Prospecting, while they have their internal aspects, are more likely to be played out in the external, concrete world of action and doing. Sentinels with their Judging trait are likely to bring order to their worlds, while Explorers with their Prospecting trait are likely to instill spontaneity into all the actions they perform.

The four Roles are primarily used when they are more likely to explain concepts in a clearer, less complicated way than involving all 16 personality types might. Using Roles this way is particularly warranted if the topic consists of a trait or traits that are a prominent part of the core traits of the various Roles – such as when Intuitive or Observant have a greater influence. But use is not limited to just that. They're like shorthand when Role commonalities suffice in talking about a subject.

In summary, Roles are just another level of the same theory, with each of the four containing four personality types. Those within a Role share a combination of two prominent traits and, therefore, share some similar characteristics.

The Role layer determines our goals, interests, and preferred activities. There are four roles:

Analysts – Intuitive (N) and Thinking (T)

Thinkers, Not Robots

The personality types in the Analyst Role – Architects (INTJ), Logicians (INTP), Commanders (ENTJ), and Debaters (ENTP) – are known for their love of rationality. Because they share the Thinking trait, these types often aim to make decisions with their heads rather than their hearts. But Analysts are far from being robots. Their Intuitive personality trait energizes their imaginations, helping them to come up with creative strategies and motivating them to explore things deeply – whether that’s an intellectual pursuit, a new interest, or even a crazy scheme or thought experiment.

These personalities are driven to understand and create. They have no problem switching between speculative musing and tactical problem-solving. Of course, these broad abilities need to be honed – and, when appropriate, they need to lead to action. Otherwise, Analysts’ active minds can give them a false sense of accomplishment.

These types often love ideas and speculation more than the realities of follow-through. As a result, they risk being outpaced by those who simply sit down and do the work. This can earn these types a reputation for being “armchair analysts” – and,

at times, Analyst personalities may forget that they actually need to test their ideas in the real world.

Driven by Curiosity

Analysts are innately curious. This helps them to ensure that their ideas are workable, rather than just clever. These personality types have a strong drive to learn, and they want to find out things for themselves rather than accept received wisdom. These types may be found stockpiling books, questioning teachers, spurring debates, or driving conversations in forums across the Internet.

Analysts are also relentless self-improvers. Once they've recognized a flaw, they apply all of their rationality, imagination, and desire for results to make it right. Especially when it's balanced with self-understanding, this drive can enable Analyst personalities to push the boundaries of what's possible – no matter what anyone else may think.

Socially Selective

Analysts can have a reputation for being lone wolves. These personality types don't necessarily care about befriending everyone they meet, and they definitely don't surround themselves with random people just for the sake of having some company.

Given a choice between spending time with someone incompatible or spending time alone, many Analysts would choose the latter. And they may not be so subtle about it. 71% of people with Analyst personality types say they're good at shutting down unwanted conversations – far more than any other Role. This brusqueness can make Analysts seem rude, unapproachable, or antisocial, particularly to types that value social harmony.

That said, it's important to note that only 17% of Analysts actually describe their ideal social life as "mostly by myself." Much greater numbers – 30% and 41% respectively – say they'd prefer to have a few good friends or a partner and a few good friends. As a result, it's inaccurate to view these personality types as antisocial.

Instead, it makes sense to view Analysts as socially selective. Like other types, they crave social connection. But these personalities won't feel socially fulfilled by spending time with just anyone. They want to surround themselves with people who really get them – even if it takes effort to find those people. That might be why 46% of Analysts say they actively seek new friendships – which is more than any other Role except Diplomats.

Independent Minds

Analysts have little patience for following in others' footsteps. 58% of these personality types describe themselves as "very independent" – far more than any other Role. Independence isn't just a characteristic of these types – it's an important part of their self-image.

This mindset shows up vividly in how Analysts approach academic and professional settings. These personality types are questioners, reluctant to take anything on faith. And "anything" includes what their teachers or bosses say.

From the outside, this might look like a lack of respect. In our Teachers Survey, Analysts were far less likely than other Roles to say they admired their past teachers. And this mindset persists in the professional sphere as well. 43% of Analysts in the workforce say they would be better than their boss at their boss's job – again, far more than any other Role. Analyst personalities are also far less likely than other Roles to express admiration for their bosses.

But does this represent a lack of respect? Maybe – but this choosiness might well have other roots. Analysts tend to hold themselves to high standards, and they often hold the people around them (bosses and teachers included) to these high standards as well. In addition, Analyst personality types tend to care a great deal about learning and professional success. 85% of Analysts say they have a strong desire to be an important and successful person.

It makes sense, then, that these personality types hold their teachers and bosses to rigorous standards. After all, an Analyst with a poor teacher or boss may be less likely to become successful. Of course, Analysts – just like anyone – will almost certainly find themselves faced with a less-than-stellar teacher or boss. As a result, figuring out how to navigate these situations is an important part of their development.

Problems? What Problems?

You know who talks a lot about their problems? Not Analysts. In fact, 83% of Analysts say that most people complain too much about their problems.

But that doesn't mean that people with these personality types don't *think* about their problems, and they certainly don't shy away from challenges. 61% of Analysts say they're excited by the idea of being responsible for solving problems, and 85% say they enjoy tackling difficult challenges.

A core strength of Analysts is their faith in their problem-solving abilities. Analyst personalities tend to express the highest intellectual self-confidence of any Role, and this gives them the willingness to try their hand at things that may be hard. Taken too far, this can turn into cockiness – which is rarely an asset, whether in relationships or in other spheres. But as long as Analysts balance their intellectual self-assurance

with their innate curiosity, these personality types can find success and even enjoyment in the face of challenges both large and small.

Diplomats – Intuitive (N) and Feeling (F)

Longing for Connection

Diplomat personality types – Advocates (INFJ), Mediators (INFP), Protagonists (ENFJ), and Campaigners (ENFP) – care about helping and connecting with others. They prioritize being kind and generous, and in general, they'd rather cooperate than compete. Empathy seems to come naturally to these personalities. It can almost seem as if their hearts and minds resonate with other people's emotions.

These types aim to understand themselves and others. They often have deep insights into human nature, and they can use these insights to influence the people around them. Fortunately, Diplomat personality types tend to do this with care. They are sensitive to other people's feelings, and they want to nudge the people around them in positive directions.

Striving for Change

Diplomats have a deep belief in the ideals of humanism – altruism, compassion, and understanding. These personality types believe it is possible to create a kinder world, and they strive to do so every day.

The Intuitive trait fuels this optimism. Paradoxically, though, it also makes these types hyper-sensitive to wrongdoing. This sensitivity provides Diplomat personalities with the motivation they need to tackle injustice, which is important. If left unchecked, however, this personality trait can trigger self-righteousness or single-mindedness.

In general, Diplomats are motivated by principles rather than practicality. This helps them to stay true to their big dreams and ideas. That said, these types may have trouble enacting plans that are pragmatic rather than passion-driven. Diplomats can be tempted to ignore day-to-day tasks in favor of their big dreams and ideas. As these personalities mature, however, they often learn to balance these necessary tasks with the big-picture thinking they enjoy.

A Higher Purpose

Among friends and family, Diplomat personalities can range from quietly caring to brightly gregarious. Unfortunately, their open hearts can make them vulnerable when others are inconsiderate. That said, these types wouldn't have it any other way. Someone must trust first, and Diplomats will almost always volunteer.

These personality types see magical beauty where others see the humdrum of daily life. This trait attracts many Diplomats to creative expression. These types can be passionately inspired by music, writing, cuisine, theater – or many other creative pursuits.

Diplomats want to bring progress and beauty to the world around them. These types are led by a sense of higher purpose, and they care about serving the greater good. As a result, activism, spirituality, healing, and volunteering are common interests for these personality types.

The Need to Belong

For Diplomats, authenticity and connection aren't just buzzwords. These concepts – which might seem vague or wishy-washy to other types – form the bedrock of

Diplomats' lives. This explains why relationships matter so much to these personality types – and not just *any* type of relationship, but rather real, meaningful bonds.

When asked about their ideal social life, only 8% of Diplomats would like to spend most of their time alone. Instead, the majority of Diplomats express a desire for a partner and a few good friends. These personalities may also worry more about loneliness than other types, with nearly two thirds of Diplomats saying they worry about being lonely in their old age.

For many Diplomats, a central challenge of their lives is to balance their need for authenticity with their need to belong. More than any other personality Role, Diplomats say that the need to belong often motivates them to do things they otherwise wouldn't. This sort of behavior might not bother other types, but it poses a real dilemma for Diplomats. Being fake can feel literally painful to these types, who long to be loved and accepted for who they are, not for their ability to fit in.

For Diplomats, an important part of self-development is learning to be real – even if they fear that doing so won't make them popular. The irony is that many Diplomat personalities only feel a deep sense of belonging and connection once they learn to approach relationships as their whole, true selves.

What is Success, Anyway?

If your life goals are to earn pots of money, land an impressive job, buy a fancy car, and be better than everyone else – well, you're probably not a Diplomat.

But that isn't to say that Diplomats don't have their own type of ambition. 85% of Diplomats say it's important to them to make a lasting impact on other people, outside of their family and closest friends. In other words, these personality types

want to make a lasting difference in the world – which is no small feat. This might explain why Diplomats are second only to Analysts in saying that they sometimes set impossibly high standards for themselves.

Perhaps because they have such a lofty view of success, Diplomats are the Role least likely to consider themselves successful. It's important to note that the great majority of people with these personality types still say they'd be upset if they never became successful. As a result, many people with these types may feel as if they're constantly striving toward ideals and expectations that they'll never meet.

To address this sense of inadequacy, many Diplomats find they must let go of comparisons to other people. 79% of Diplomats say they consciously compare themselves to others either often or very often. By releasing these comparisons, Diplomats can free themselves to do things their own way, in their own time – rather than fretting over whether they're successful yet.

Time to Leap

You know that expression, “Leap and the net will appear”? Diplomat personality types can fall into the trap of thinking they've leapt – metaphorically speaking – when they're actually still perched at the ledge. Because these personalities have such active mental lives and imaginations, they can forget that thinking about starting a business isn't the same as actually starting a business, or that watching videos of dancers isn't the same as throwing themselves into a pirouette.

For many Diplomats, the secret to tackling their greatest challenge is simply to take action. Of course, that's easier said than done. The majority of Diplomats say they overthink simple tasks – so you can only imagine how much they might overthink major life decisions or their most precious dreams.

Fortunately, Diplomats tend to have a deep intuitive sense of what is right for them. Many of these personality types find that by tuning into this wisdom – and honoring it – they can find satisfaction and meaning in their everyday lives, no matter what challenges arise along the way.

Sentinels – Observant (S) and Judging (J)

Character and Competence

Sentinels – Logisticians (ISTJ), Defenders (ISFJ), Executives (ESTJ), and Consuls (ESFJ) – are cooperative, practical, and grounded. They feel comfortable with who they are, and they take pride in their good character and their competence. These personality types seek order, security, and stability, and they tend to work hard to maintain their way of things. This leads to a deserved reputation as the cornerstone of any group or organization, from family to church to the office and the factory floor.

Careful and consistent, Sentinel personalities tend to be self-motivated. This means that they rarely need external inspiration to be productive and focused. They work hard and aim never to let anyone down, and they expect other people to embrace this same ethic as well. Given a choice, these personality types prefer to collaborate within a clear set of rules. Following proven methods makes more sense to them than swanning around in search of innovation. Their motto is, “If it works, don’t break it.”

Steady Progress

That said, Sentinels are hardly unimaginative. They simply take inspiration from the past rather than the future. These personality types remain loyal to established best practices and traditions, whether that’s the best way to make a pizza crust or the

most efficient way to write an algorithm. This enables them to make steady, consistent progress – which is exactly what they enjoy. Sentinels would much rather guide a single project to completion than start (and abandon) a flurry of interesting ideas.

Sentinel personalities thrive in environments that have clear hierarchies and rules. Whether or not they're in a formal leadership role, they care about setting a good example, and they gain great satisfaction from guiding a well-functioning group. This can make them excellent teachers, managers, and community officials, as well as caring parents and hosts.

Guidance and Wisdom

In their personal lives, Sentinels want to offer stability and wisdom to others. They see it as their duty to give their families safe, happy lives that prepare them for the real world. An appreciation of strong relationships allows these personality types to share generously with those they respect and love. Sentinels feel bolstered by having reliable people in their lives, and they make sure they hold up their end of the bargain. Birthdays, dinner parties, and camping trips are delightful events under their enthusiastic direction.

These personality types are happiest without drama – though they can occasionally be stubborn. In particular, inconsistent people can test Sentinels' patience. It can be difficult for Sentinel personalities to accept people who lack their conscientiousness. Fortunately, they often serve as engaged and caring mentors to those who wish to grow in that direction.

Love and Care

Sentinels are the personality Role least likely to say they fall in love easily – but don't let that fool you. Sentinels may not spout love poems, but they do express affection and admiration – they just do it a little differently than other personality types. Sentinels often show their love in practical ways, such as checking the tires on their partner's car or making them a nutritious dinner. To other types, these actions might not look romantic, but Sentinels do these things with love and care.

In all of their relationships, Sentinels want to make contributions. This attitude informs how they treat not only their nearest and dearest but also their acquaintances, neighbors, and coworkers. These aren't the personality types who neglect their responsibilities or leave the office kitchen a mess – in fact, they're often the types who quietly clean up other people's messes, both literal and metaphorical.

Of course, Sentinels wouldn't *mind* being recognized for the ways they help others, but these personalities rarely demand attention. Instead, they work behind the scenes to make everyone's lives run as smoothly as possible, even if that means taking on unglamorous tasks like remembering to buy toilet paper or handling their family's income taxes. They may not be obvious with their feelings, but Sentinels do care and care deeply – you just have to know how to spot it.

Due Diligence

Sentinels have a core set of principles that they bring to their academic and professional pursuits. These principles include diligence, honesty, and respect. The result is that Sentinel personality types tend to work hard, striving to meet deadlines, and generally get things done. This can be seen even from a relatively young age –

Sentinels are far more likely than other Roles to say that they developed productive work habits in school.

These personality types have a clear vision of what it means to do things “right,” and they take great pride in living up to these standards. Sentinels are rarely willing to cut corners and do shoddy work – even if doing so would help them get ahead. They are less likely than any other Role to say that they could compromise some of their principles to advance their career.

Above all, Sentinels stand out for their ability to stick with their work until it’s done – even if the work is tedious or rote. These personality types are far less likely than others to say that they often abandon work in favor of doing something more interesting and fun, and they’re also less likely to say that they get distracted from what they’re working on. For Sentinels, productivity is a bit of a superpower – and they get great satisfaction from exercising their ability to get things done.

Planning Ahead

Sentinels know the value of a well-made plan. Compared to other Roles, Sentinel personalities are far more likely to say they’d rather prepare for problems rather than tackle them as they arise. And Sentinels aren’t afraid to think up every contingency that might arise – as long as they can do something to avert disaster, that is.

Of course, we can’t prepare for everything – although if anyone could, it would be a Sentinel. Like everyone else, these types must occasionally face unforeseen problems. Learning to roll with the punches, so to speak, is an important part of their personal development. Over time, Sentinels can learn to distinguish between when they should stick with their plans and when they’d do well to change course. And

when they do so, these personality types can press through even the most challenging of circumstances, bringing together determination and adaptability.

Explorers – Observant (S) and Prospecting (P)

On the Fly

Explorers – Virtuosos (ISTP), Adventurers (ISFP), Entrepreneurs (ESTP), and Entertainers (ESFP) – tend to be self-reliant and quick-thinking. These personality types don't mind handling uncertain situations on the fly – in fact, they live for those types of situations. Explorers' flexibility helps them to adapt to the moment, even if they don't feel particularly prepared.

These types tend not to be obsessed with precise detail – unless they're really in the zone, in which case they can muster a level of precision and focus that would make a seasoned engineer blush with envy. Usually, they prefer workability and usefulness to perfection. Explorer personalities enjoy learning different tools and techniques, from rotary saws to sheet music to emergency response strategies.

Living for Change

Explorers can change their minds with minimal regret or second-guessing. People in this Role dislike monotony, and they may stray from their obligations in order to try new things. If these personality types sometimes leave business unfinished, let clutter build up, or misplace important things – it's because they've moved on to something fresh.

These types enjoy being free of obligations, where they can indulge themselves or their interests on their own time. They love delving into something interesting, but their interest tends to wane as soon as something becomes "mandatory." An

Explorer personality might design and build their own dream house, but end up procrastinating on simple repairs after a few years.

Social Ingenuity

This free-form attitude can make Explorer personalities socially dynamic as well. Their spontaneity draws them to appealing strangers and interesting experiences. When things get in the way of a good time, they apply their ingenuity to get around it. Explorers want to see what happens next!

Explorers enjoy being on the leading edge of things – whether that means having the latest technology, trying out fashion trends, or checking out the newest restaurant in town. Many Explorer personalities enjoy sharing these findings with others, and they take pride in introducing their friends and loved ones to the latest and greatest things. The result is that time spent with Explorers is almost never boring or repetitive – and Explorers wouldn't have it any other way.

Explorers in Love

Explorer personality types have a reputation for constantly being on the move – and some people might wonder whether this restlessness applies to their romantic relationships as well. According to our research, however, relatively few Explorers (32%) say they're easily bored by romantic relationships that are stable and predictable. In fact, Analysts and Diplomats are significantly more likely to agree with this statement.

So, what *are* Explorers like in romantic relationships? First, Explorers are slightly less likely than other Roles to say that falling in love scares them. These personality types thrive in unpredictable situations, and what is falling in love if not unpredictable? The

early phases of a relationship are energizing for these types – full of new experiences and fresh discoveries.

It's true that Explorer personalities are somewhat more likely than other Roles to avoid commitment. Still, the majority of Explorers – 63% – say they usually seek commitment in their relationships. And overall, Explorers are slightly more likely than average to say that intimate relationships have increased their maturity more than anything else. So, while Explorers might have a reputation for being commitment-phobes, it's clear that these personality types see the deeper value of long-term relationships – and, more often than not, this is exactly what they're looking for.

Doing the Work

Explorers are highly spontaneous, connecting with their environment in a way that's almost childlike in its wonder and sheer fun. But when they need to work on something that's frustrating or unexciting – well, that can prove something of a challenge.

This may show up in how Explorer personality types approach their academic and professional lives. Explorers are slightly less likely than other Roles to say that they developed productive work habits in school. They're also less likely to say that it was easy for them to do well in school. Many school environments are relatively prescriptive, filled with required courses and standardized curricula. As a result, Explorer personalities often find themselves forced to sit through classes that just don't excite them – which, for these types, can be unmotivating. Unfortunately, this can persist in their professional lives as well – after all, most jobs require at least some degree of routine, unglamorous work.

This isn't to say that Explorers are slouches – far from it. When they're working on something they're passionate about, these personality types can move heaven and earth. And, over time, they often find ways to deal with the necessary evils – in other words, the unexciting tasks – that make work and life run more smoothly.

Perhaps it's most accurate to say that Explorers look for ways to balance work with leisure. They're the Role least likely to say they make themselves finish all of their tasks before they allow themselves to relax. While some personality types might brand this behavior as laziness, this isn't necessarily the case. Explorers' ability to balance work with fun can help them avoid burnout. Ultimately, this can help them to enjoy more fulfillment – and yes, a surprising degree of productivity – in their lives.

The Power of Risk

51% of Explorers say they take risks simply for the fun of it – far more than any other personality Role. This might sound reckless, and indeed it can be. But, done responsibly, risk-taking can be one of the best ways to learn new things, solve tricky problems, and grow as people. As Explorers know, we can only make so much progress in life if we stay in our comfort zones.

As long as they temper this trait with a degree of self-control, comfort with risk can be one of Explorers' greatest strengths. It can motivate them to open up in their relationships and empower them to seek out new academic and professional opportunities.

These personality types don't resign themselves to the "lives of quiet desperation" that Henry David Thoreau famously wrote of in *Walden*. Instead, Explorers can use their own brand of bravery to free themselves from conventionality and create lives that work for them.

Strategies

The word “strategy” suggests a course of action. In our use, Strategy describes how personality types act in response to the world around them and how they might choose to accomplish things.

Strategies express themselves primarily in two ways: social style and resistance to stress. Social style entails how other people factor into an individual’s Strategy and to what degree. One example might involve whether a person prefers working in a team or alone.

Resistance to stress includes the degree of impact that a stressful situation might have on an individual and their efforts, as well as how resilient they might be when trying to restore themselves after a challenging event. An example of this might involve whether a person quits after a jarring setback or presses forward.

The Energy aspect (Introverted/Extraverted) brings to each combination a social piece. When individuals pursue their goals or satisfy their needs and wants, to what degree will they involve other people? Do they want to achieve things independently, or are they collaborators and team players? Extraverted personality types often wish to have more people around, and Introverts tend to prefer doing things more independently.

But the Energy aspect also speaks to risk and taking leaps of faith. Extraverts tend to be more adventurous, and they are brimming with enthusiasm for the activities in their lives – especially if they involve other people. Introverts feel a pull toward lone activities and are usually calmer and quieter, preferring quiet and solitude or smaller, more intimate groups when possible. Introverted personality types are not as interested in adventures as their Extraverted counterparts.

The Identity aspect (Assertive/Turbulent) describes levels of confidence and resistance to stress. It helps us understand what might motivate someone. Are they being pulled along by their self-confidence, or are they pushed to excel because they are perfectionists focused on preventing mistakes and failures?

Assertive personalities are much less likely to worry about things – even results. Their motivation may involve boldly realizing the potential that they assume they have. They are less concerned with the opinions of others and may stand up to their critics – not to impress them but to “correct” them. Turbulent personalities are self-conscious, cautious, and perfectionistic. They may go one of two ways. They may push themselves to high levels of success to avoid disappointment in themselves, or they may opt out of doing something because of the potential for stress and the chance of failure.

In summary, Strategies combine the Energy aspect and the Identity aspect. Together, they describe how individuals respond to life and reflect their preferred ways of doing things. When merged, the Energy and Identity personality traits influence many areas of life, including social preferences, confidence, stress, and risk-taking, to name a few.

The Strategy layer shows our preferred ways of doing things and achieving goals. There are four strategies:

Confident Individualism – Introverted (I) and Assertive (-A)

Substance Over Superficiality

Confident Individualists tend to trust in themselves. They enjoy their own company and don't mind spending time alone to pursue their interests. Over time, this can give these personalities an impressive range of skills and interesting ideas.

But these types take pride in their skills for their own sake, not to impress others. They tend not to see the point in social displays and bragging. While they're proud of who they are, these personality types don't always feel the need to prove themselves to anyone else. They prefer substance to superficiality and personal honesty to playing along.

Confident Individualists are motivated by their inner world rather than outside expectations. They're opinionated, but they aren't excessively worried about what others think. These personality types express their thoughts unapologetically. They're rarely pressured into agreeing with others – even if agreeing would be more convenient.

Self-Assurance and Self-Reliance

If left unchecked, this relaxed self-assurance can lead to complacency. These personality types' live-and-let-live attitude goes both ways: They don't push others to change, and in return, they don't particularly want anyone to push them to change. At times, Confident Individualists may miss information and opportunities that challenge their views because they simply don't place much importance on others' approval.

In their personal relationships, these types tend to be strong and honest. Their loyalty and affection are genuine rather than forced. These personalities only express respect and care if they really feel them. Fortunately, if they do feel them, they see no reason to hide how they feel.

No matter how strong their relationships, these types also value self-reliance. They can handle difficult situations well because they tend to be emotionally secure and resistant to stress. Although these personalities rarely seek the spotlight, their quiet examples of determination and honesty can be nothing short of inspiring.

Confident Individualists in Love

Confident Individualists tend to be a bit choosy about their closest confidants. This is especially true when it comes to finding a romantic partner. Perhaps because Confident Individualists know how to find contentment and fulfillment even when they're single, they're in no rush to settle for a partner who's less than a good match.

These personality types may also be less likely to stay with a partner who lets them down. Confident Individualists are less likely than any other personality Strategy to say they often give second chances to those who fail to fulfill commitments to them. Again, perhaps because of their strong intrinsic sense of worth, these types don't necessarily feel compelled to stay in a relationship that isn't working out.

Confident Individualists are the Strategy least likely to say they believe in soulmates. They're also the least likely to say they know a lot of couples whose marriages they envy, or would aspire to have. And it might not come as a surprise, then, that they're the most likely to say they don't want to get married.

It would be inaccurate, however, to assume that Confident Individualists are lone wolves with no interest in committed intimate relationships. The majority of these personality types – 79% – *do* express an interest in getting married. A similar percentage say they're unafraid of being committed to a single partner for the rest of their lives. It's true that Confident Individualists are independent, and they probably won't get into a relationship just for the sake of being in a relationship. That said, these types often do have an interest in romantic connection – they just want to find the right person before they become attached.

Unlikely Leaders

Confident Individualists bring their love of independence into their academic and professional pursuits. They're more likely than any other Strategy to say that learning as part of a group is distracting rather than helpful. As you can imagine, group projects can be frustrating for these personality types – whether at school or in the workplace.

This isn't to say that Confident Individualists *can't* work well with others – far from it. But if given a choice, these types would prefer to operate independently and figure things out on their own. At school, these personalities may be drawn to independent study opportunities. At work, they may try to develop a specific area of expertise that allows them to make their own decisions and do most of their tasks on their own.

From this description, Confident Individualists might not sound like natural leaders, but that isn't necessarily the case. Just over half of these personality types say they're inclined to seek out leadership and management roles. This is well less than their Extraverted peers, but it's still a majority. In addition, nearly 70% of these types say

they have excellent leadership skills. A quick look at famous Confident Individualists includes real-life leaders (Bill Gates) as well as fictional ones (Gandalf).

Confident Individualists tend to hone their ideas and skills on their own, and they often prefer to work alone. That said, these personalities may be willing to take up the reins of leadership if that's what is necessary to turn those ideas and skills into real-world progress.

The Right Mindset

Confident Individualists are more likely than any other personality Strategy to say that control over their mindset is the most important factor in determining their happiness. On average, they rank their mindset as a more significant factor in their happiness than their financial situation, their friends and family, their job, or their health.

This statistic reveals a great deal about Confident Individualists. These personality types believe in their personal effectiveness and their individual worth, and they know how important it is to maintain this mindset. As long as they balance this self-conviction with a willingness to learn from others, Confident Individualists' positive mindset can become a self-fulfilling prophecy, helping these personalities to not only achieve great things but also find lasting happiness.

People Mastery – Extraverted (E) and Assertive (-A)

Bold and Confident

Personality types with the People Mastery Strategy are known for their ability to handle stress. This helps them to act boldly and maintain confidence, even in the face of challenges or criticism.

Thanks to this confidence, people with this Strategy feel energized and at ease in social situations. They seek social contact as well as stimulating and challenging experiences. These personalities like traveling to see things, people, and places, and trying something new – even things they don't end up liking can be exciting for them.

Nothing to Prove?

If they don't keep themselves in check, though, People Masters can become too confident. These personality types tend to be insulated against self-doubt and the need to prove themselves. As a result, they don't always test, or even consider, their own limits or ambitions.

Taken to the extreme, this can create a pattern of comfort-seeking. They may even roll their eyes at people who chase more intimidating goals. At the other end of the spectrum, these personality types can ignore sensible caution, landing themselves in extraordinary and dangerous situations.

At times, People Masters may not be considerate to those who aren't able to maintain such a comfortable boldness. But this doesn't have to be the case, by any means. By taking others into account, these personalities can actually help to draw other people out of their shells in a way that's energizing and empowering.

Finding Balance

Fortunately, most People Masters fall somewhere in the middle. Ideally, they embrace healthy ambition while finding social fulfillment and connection. Social interaction plays a big part in People Masters' happiness. Although these personality types are self-confident, they still appreciate praise and recognition. They don't need

people's approval, but they still crave friends and loved ones with whom to share their lives.

These types may be opinionated, but they don't always worry about having others agree with them. This can help these personalities to be moderate even in disagreements because their ego and confidence aren't at stake the way they often are for Turbulent Strategies. People Masters are not fond of grudges, and at heart, they want to bring people together to make things happen.

These types often stand out for their charisma and self-assurance. As long as they don't use their talents to steamroll or put down others, these personality traits can be quite appealing. These types have little fear of rejection, and they love including others. This can make these personalities wonderful friends, loved ones, and colleagues, who always aim to energize those around them.

People Masters in Love

According to our research, People Masters seem to fall in love a bit more frequently than the other Strategies. They're also less likely to say that falling in love scares them. It's easy to imagine why this is the case – People Masters' Extraversion leads them into situations where they're likely to meet new people, and their Assertive personality trait helps them to feel confident about the prospect of new relationships.

Some might wonder whether this would make People Masters less reliable than other personality types when it comes to being a good partner. Is it possible that these types' self-assurance would make them complacent or uncommitted once they're actually *in* a relationship? Not necessarily: About half of People Masters say it's necessary to go out of their way to please someone they love, and this response

puts them on par with other types. In addition, People Masters are the Strategy least likely to say that long-term commitments make them anxious.

In other words, although People Masters' confidence and social ease might make them sound like players, these types can be as committed and eager to please their partners as anyone else. And being in a relationship with a People Master can be a wonderful thing – even for people who are completely different. After all, People Masters' social energy and their can-do take on life can be infectious in the best possible way.

Speaking Up

People Masters don't tend to filter their opinions. These personality types say what they think, and they think what they say. As with nearly any trait, this can be a strength or a weakness.

People Masters are often seen as straight-shooters who can be trusted to speak honestly. In academic and professional settings, many teachers, classmates, colleagues, and managers appreciate this quality. After all, if used appropriately, candor is a powerful way to connect with other people. The “what you see is what you get” nature of a People Master personality can be refreshing, whether in the classroom or the workplace.

But there's a difference between being candid and being rude – and at times, People Masters may toe that line. In academic settings, this can put them at odds with their teachers and classmates. And in professional settings, these personality types may gain a reputation for being inconsiderate, arrogant, or even ruthless.

Learning to speak honestly *without* speaking over other people is a step on many People Masters' path to personal development. Fortunately, once they master this balance, People Masters can unleash the many gifts they bring to their schooling and their work. In particular, People Masters can excel at dealing with awkward or tense interpersonal situations – whether that's getting a group project back on track or delivering bad news to a customer in a straightforward but considerate way.

Going for It

79% of People Masters say they see problems as opportunities. These personality types trust themselves to tackle hard problems – *and* to gain insight and experience from the process. Ideally, this conviction becomes a self-fulfilling prophecy, with People Masters taking on ever harder challenges and learning important lessons along the way.

What sets People Masters apart isn't just their confidence, however. It's also their willingness to team up with others. These personalities know that we tend to be more effective when we collaborate and ask for help. People Masters can be especially good at creating opportunities for the people around them to use their strengths. And that may just be one of the secrets to People Masters' success.

Constant Improvement – Introverted (I) and Turbulent (-T)

Sensitive Souls

Constant Improvers tend to be sensitive and introspective. They are often deep individuals who enjoy having their own space and freedom. In general, these personality types feel more comfortable on their own than mixed up in the judgment of the real world.

This may be because they share the two personality traits most representative of sensitivity to their environment – Introversion and Turbulence. As a result, they may find it stressful to deal with tense environments or new situations. In these moments, Constant Improvers can be deeply uncomfortable – although they may not want to let on how they really feel. In reaction, these personalities might retreat inward, react defensively, or try to escape the situation altogether. Alternatively, they might give up their own wants or needs in an effort to keep the peace.

Driven by Doubt

Constant Improvers tend to experience self-doubt. They have a strong drive, but it comes paired with a strong fear of failure. These personality types invest a great deal of their identity in their successes. As a result, even a minor misstep or embarrassment can be crushing.

On the upside, this vigilance offers these personality types a knack for sensing trouble. This can be quite useful in situations that need to balance risk and reward – whether a financial investment or a romantic opportunity. When faced with a potential risk, these types look for ways to prevent problems. Although it slows them down in the short term, this approach can prevent longer-term issues.

Constant Improvers direct much of their attention toward their personal interests. They strive to master hobbies, careers, or new means of self-expression. This level of dedication can create impressive, beautiful results.

People with Constant Improvement personality types can be perfectionistic, dedicating tremendous time and energy to their pursuits. Unfortunately, if they put too much pressure on themselves, this approach can backfire. For example, Constant

Improvers may feel forced to abandon an endeavor because a single detail doesn't line up right.

Reality and Romance

At times, Constant Improvers may experience a nagging feeling that something is missing from their lives. It's worth noting that often this really is just a feeling, not a reflection of reality. These personality types have it in their nature always to be seeking something more – even if their lives actually are going just fine.

But as Constant Improvers assess their lives, wondering what might be missing, they may find themselves focusing on their romantic relationships – or lack thereof. These types are significantly less likely than their Assertive counterparts (also known as Confident Individualists) to say that they enjoy being single. And these personalities are more likely than Confident Individualists to say they often construct an ideal partner in their heads when they're single.

Although Constant Improvers may find themselves longing for romance, they don't necessarily find it easy to start up a relationship. They're less likely than other personality Strategies to say that they usually take the initiative in asking someone out. This makes sense, given that Constant Improvers can feel hesitant about putting themselves out there – and asking someone out is an incredibly vulnerable position to be in.

This might sound like bad news, but it doesn't have to be. As they grow and mature, Constant Improvers often learn how to transform their feeling that something is missing into positive energy – and by doing so, they not only discover gratitude for the good things in their lives, but also become proactive about making helpful

changes. This mindset shift can empower these personality types to find fulfillment in their relationships – as well as in every other aspect of their lives.

The “Right” Career?

Constant Improvers’ longing for “something more” extends to their professional lives. Just over a quarter of these types say that their career is a great fit for them – a rate of agreement that is less than the other Strategies.

This doesn’t necessarily mean that Constant Improvers are in the wrong careers for them – although they might wonder if they are. More than half of these personality types say they often think about switching careers, and they’re more likely than the other Strategies to say that they feel stuck in their current job.

This restlessness doesn’t have to be a bad thing. In fact, restlessness can be an incredible motivator to do great things. The trouble comes when Constant Improvers feel trapped: wanting to make a change, but suspecting they’re unable or helpless to do so. This feeling can have a number of roots, such as self-doubt or a general worry that other people don’t “get” them.

As in other areas of their lives, Constant Improvers who pursue personal growth often discover that their feeling of helplessness is exactly that – a *feeling*. This can be a powerful discovery. In its wake, these personality types are better able to harness their personal and professional strengths and deal with their feeling of “stuckness.” This may take the form of finding a new career, or it might involve advocating for themselves in their current workplaces so that they get more of their needs met. Either way, Constant Improvers often find that they have more agency in their professional lives than they’d realized.

The Strength of Sensitivity

In general, Constant Improvers care a great deal about what others think of them. This can trigger insecurity, to be sure, but when kept in balance, it can create some truly wonderful traits. These personalities are often curious about and sensitive to others' feelings. This can make them excellent listeners, friends, confidants, and partners.

Some types might think that sensitivity is synonymous with weakness, but Constant Improvers know that isn't the case. These personality types often exemplify how sensitivity and vulnerability can be hidden strengths. Their attunement to their own struggles and insecurities can help them to bond deeply with others. It can also motivate them to act with kindness and compassion.

Although they may not always realize it, Constant Improvers offer the world a wealth of gifts. Once they learn to trust themselves as much as they trust others' opinions, these personalities can shine.

Social Engagement – Extraverted (E) and Turbulent (-T)

Boldly Sensitive

Those with the Social Engagement Strategy are an interesting group. In some ways, Extraverted and Turbulent personality traits conflict with each other. Extraversion leads to risk-tolerance and boldness, and Turbulence leads to self-doubt and sensitivity.

This can mean that Social Engagers tend to do what comes naturally first and think about it later. In this way, they are almost an exaggeration of their underlying personality traits. This may sound like a bad thing, but it doesn't have to be.

Social Engagers venture into the world with enthusiasm. They enjoy being the center of attention and enjoy social status. At times, this may mean that they hide their true selves to impress other people, pretending to be someone else in order to be liked. Fortunately, Social Engagers' genuine interest in others often shines through, helping these personality types to create authentic connections with the people around them.

Social Engagers in Love

Romantic relationships aren't always the easiest – hence Shakespeare's observation that "the course of true love never did run smooth." You might think that Social Engagers' self-doubt would cause them to play it safe when it comes to the rough waters of love, but that isn't the case. These personality types tend to dive headlong into relationships – they're more likely than any other Strategy to say they fall in love easily. And they're also less likely to say they enjoy being single.

Social Engagers are far from passive about their romantic lives. These personalities care deeply about pleasing their partners – in fact, they're the Strategy most likely to believe they need to go out of their way to please the people they love. Social Engagers are deeply devoted, willing to pour all of their affection and care into their partner.

But not everyone is willing – or able – to do this in return. Social Engagers may feel it acutely if their partner doesn't seem equally affectionate or devoted. This can be especially challenging because these personality types care so deeply about receiving praise and admiration. As a result, they might feel hurt by a partner who is reserved in expressing their affection.

As they go through life, many Social Engagers discover that not everyone is as expressive as they are – and that’s okay. These types may need to use their social acumen to connect with the ways their partners *do* share love. For example, they may realize that their partner expresses affection through physical touch, spending time together, or even helping out around the house. Once they attune themselves to the ways other personalities demonstrate their love, Social Engagers can find incredible fulfillment and joy in their romantic relationships.

Working It

Social Engagers may find themselves drawn to lines of work that involve plenty of human interaction. The service industry can be a natural fit for these personality types, as can nearly any job that involves helping customers solve problems. Social Engagers are energized by the opportunity to talk with others, and they’re especially invigorated when they can tell that they’ve actually made someone’s day a little better.

This isn’t to say that Social Engagers are anything less than ambitious. In their own way, these personalities do care about being successful. Everyone has a unique definition of “success,” of course, but many Social Engagers feel especially successful when they receive recognition, such as awards, promotions, or positive feedback on their work. These types tend to be motivated by a desire to impress and please others – not only because they enjoy praise, but also because they genuinely value the good opinion of their bosses, coworkers, and customers. And of course a salary increase is always nice, too.

Social Engagers’ ambition and desire to please can make them wonderful employees and colleagues. At times, however, these personality types often discover a need to

pause and make sure they're being true to themselves as well. Their personal development path may lead them to consider their own values and needs – and make sure that their professional lives line up with these values and needs.

That said, these types know that their career is just one aspect of their lives. 74% of Social Engagers say they're always looking for new hobbies to get into – more than any other personality Strategy. Whether those hobbies include volleyball, viticulture, or volunteering, these types care about being well-rounded. Paradoxically, this well-roundedness can help them to find more enjoyment in their careers as well as in other aspects of their lives.

The Highs and the Lows

Social Engagers can experience highs and lows – sometimes within a matter of minutes. Their Extraversion can push their Turbulent need for success into overdrive. Meanwhile, their Turbulent personality trait can trigger almost instant self-doubt. Although these types are capable of taking quick action in a way that seems decisive, they may find themselves plagued by uncertainty afterward.

As they grow, many Social Engagers learn how to use this unusual combination of traits to their advantage. Their Extraversion can help them move past the self-doubt that comes with the Turbulent trait, enabling them to expand their comfort zones even when it isn't easy. Meanwhile, their Turbulent trait can help them to be more considerate in their boldness. The result is that these personality types can hold many contradictory traits in harmony, being both fun and responsible, active and reflective.

This push and pull can be stressful, but it's part of this Strategy's charm. These personality types chase their goals relentlessly, but they also indulge their desires

and seek out fun. Thanks to this balance, they can lead happy and fruitful lives – sharing adventures and accomplishments with others whenever possible. Whatever direction these personalities pull, they are sure to pull the crowd with them.

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